Dirt Rich 2

The Plot Thickens: How to Scale Out of Your Land Business Without Skipping a Beat

Mark Podolsky

Hey!

Download the bonus materials for learning to scale and automate your land business at www.thelandgeek.com/dirtrich2

What Other People in The Land Geek Community Have to Say

Here is what some of the people in The Land Geek community who attended some of our trainings to teach the principles you'll learn in this book have shared about their experience learning and applying just some of what you're about to learn in Dirt Rich 2:

"Mark, let me start by saying that your coaching program has completely transformed my life. I found myself divorced later in life and was a single mom looking for a way to supplement my income using pockets of time in my busy schedule. I've dabbled in entrepreneurship, so I had an idea of what business models didn't work for me but hadn't found yet found the right fit or right community. I stumbled across your book Dirt Rich and devoured it over a weekend 18 months ago. Your passion for the business and supporting others' success is contagious and felt on those pages. I knew from the book that this was an opportunity I was not passing up. I immediately started in the next Flight School Class, implemented the foundation laid out for me and began setting up the systems. I wanted to fast track my success and applied for your coaching program as soon as Flight School ended. As expected, you and your team did not disappoint. My coaching year was spent getting systems in place, stressing the system, plugging the holes and growing the machine all with the guidance from my coach, Tate and yourself. I have not yet replaced my income, but I built a rapidly growing business that gave me the confidence to retire from my job to work my land business full time. The coaching program allowed me to build and implement the foundation, structure and systems necessary. I cannot recommend it enough to others who are looking for an extra revenue stream, security from corporate America layoffs

or a future income replacement. Thank you for your passion, transparency and authenticity."

— CHERYL PAULSEN

"I graduated in August of this year and I'm approaching my 50th transaction! Pretty pumped! I love doing business in this community and using the Land Geek process!"

—JEREMY D. BROWN

"Right now, I'm on an island in Belize and swam with sharks yesterday. I got a $500 down payment on a property and a signed terms deal, $200 per month for 36 months. I never spoke to the buyer. Can't beat it."

—ROLANDO CARDENAS

"There is nothing quite like sitting on the couch, watching TV, eating ice cream, and getting a notification that says, "Someone paid the doc fee for X property." Thank you Mark Podolsky!"

—MALLORY MABUS

"The Land Geek community is home. We're supposed to surround ourselves with people who are smarter than us, more successful than us, and kinder than us. We're supposed to surround ourselves with folks that have already achieved our current goals, people who lift us up and share their love and camaraderie. We need to be surrounded by like-minded people who are just as passionate as we are and with whom we share similar interests and values. These are just some of the characteristics of the Land Geek community. What a gift. What a blessing. This is why I call Land Geek my home."

—DEREK J. GELBER

"I sold 13 properties this month. I've hired more VA's and focused even more on making and refining my systems."

—MICHELLE BRIDGER

"Three years later, I have "finally" quit my job. I vividly remember crying in the car on a commute home from the office three years ago when we had just started our business, thinking we would never get to this point. Well, the day is here, and I am a full-time land investor! My gratitude for this community is more than I can put into words, and I want others who are still slaving away at their day jobs and burning the midnight oil to know that it is worth it and you can do it, too. Embrace the suck, you got this!"

—CHLOE BAWMANN

"Win of the week: I just sold two lots. I bought them for $1,700 and sold them on terms for $225 per month for 60 months. That's $13,500 with a doc fee of $199 for 804% profit!! My best deal yet. I literally talked to the guy on Facebook messenger for five minutes. My wife is doing a happy dance for me."

—ADAM

"We sold three properties last week. The big win was a property I purchased for $9,000 and sold for $10,000 down and $550 a month for 48 months."

—LARRY MURELL

"I love the "singles" that I buy for $8,000 and sell for $20,000 but my favorite deal was on two side-by-side properties in Florida. I bought them both for $8,000 total, so $4,000 each and sold them for $50,000 each. I sold them on terms and the down payment was

$10,000 each plus $1,000 a month, so I more than doubled my money just on the down payment."

—MICHAELA C.

"After one year, we got to just under $3,000 per month in passive income. After two years, we bounce around between $8,500 to a little over $9,000 of passive income per month, with goals to get bigger and bigger."

—DEREK WHITE

"I am forever and always grateful for the Land Geeks and their openness and willingness to help someone who's just starting out. This is a great business, and you present it in an accessible way. Bootcamp rocked! I learned a ton. I was able to pay back the cost of Flight School, and then some, within three months. I'm making passive income of $900 per month."

—ASHLEY L

"My passive income is not huge. It's $852.02. But it's every month. The software handles most of the payers. I got one JV deal where my partner got the down payment, and I got a $100,000 note. If you're stuck or worried about the economy and interest rates, I hope this perks you up. Here to help."

—STEVE HODGDON

"We are in the process of closing on five properties from two sellers. Our inventory is down to two parcels, so this is a great time for this to happen. We may yet make our goal of recapturing all of our capital investment by the end of October"!"

—ALAN WILLIAMS

"I sold a property in exactly one week!"

—BRANDY DAFFAN HORKEY

"I just wanted to share my wins this week as a new land investor. I joined this group about three months ago and have bought three parcels since. I sold not one but two of them on terms yesterday! I knew the business of land investing was legit, but this gave me even more confidence in it. I can't wait to become more invested in this!"

—COLE SUNDEM

"I bought a property for $5k a few years ago. The state says they are putting a highway through the middle of it. Dang. The state called back a few days ago to let me know they want to buy the property for $66k!!! Nothing is signed yet but that is a smokin' deal!!!"

—P.J. REILLY

"I had a person from my buyers list invest in a property for $130 per month for 60 months. Then he decided he didn't want to give ACH info when he saw the contract. He said he would pay cash of $7,000 instead. We agreed. The deal went south. He wanted to invest money elsewhere. He stayed on my buyers list. Eight weeks later I got a hold of a Land Arb Property. I sent out my list the next day "marking it down" to $200 per month for 60 months. He purchased it hours later, allowing me to double my money for five years to come and paying an extra $4,200 over the life of the loan."

—JOHN W. OLBETER

"I bought a lot via a larger wholesale deal for $3,283 and sold it for $35k cash the next day because I already had a buyer lined up!"

—MAXIMILIANO LEMURA

"I sold 60 acres on terms for 7.5 years, earning me $30,000 off of a $6,000 purchase."

—JEFF JONES

"I bought four properties for $2,000 a piece and sold all four on terms for $60,000 with a $5,000 down payment generating close to $800 per month for 72 months and making my capital back in just four months. I'm just grateful!"

—BRYAN LARK

"I acquired eight, 2.5-acre parcels in Luna County, NM (all adjacent). My payment is $450 per month for 60 months ($56.25 per parcel). I also paid $1,050 down.

I sold one and after paying a doc fee for $199, the guy defaulted. I was able to resell that parcel and five of the other parcels to someone else. She already put $600 down and paid a $199 doc fee. She will then pay $894 per month for 60 months ($924 including note fees and taxes).

In the end, I'm in this deal for just $52 down, deducting the first $199 doc fee and the $799 I just received from the $1,050 I put down for the eight parcels. I will also net $444 profit per month for the next five years and still have two additional parcels listed for $100 down and $149 per month for 60 months. The yield works out to be 20.631%."

—LLOYD IPPOLITO

"I had a small win with a nice return yesterday. I paid $375 for a lot and sold it on terms $60 per month for 24 months ($1,440)."

—MIKE ALDER

"I bought my first land in Nevada. The closing is tomorrow, and I already sold it. The down payment I'm receiving from the sale covered my purchase price and I'm expecting 77 months of payments starting next month. I also sold land in Florida - not bad for the month."

—YOSI BET YOSEF

"I had three sales within 24 hours. Interestingly, I had written that my goal for August was seven sales. By August 30 I had made five sales. Then on August 31 I got three more."

—KIRK PEART

"I sold my first property for a 3,500% return on investment on terms. If anyone has questions, help, or just wants to talk, reach out to me or this community of amazing people. I'd love to help give back what you have all given to me. Thank you! Seriously reach out any time. To your success and future, much love."

—MANET YAZIDI

"I just sold my first piece of land! I paid $500 for the land, which is in Texas. And I just sold it on terms with $99 down and $99 per month for 36 months, totaling $3,663. Man, it feels good!"

—BRADLEY FULP

"I sold one property on terms for 1,100% profit, not counting the 9% interest."

—MATT NUNN

"This was last week:

1. *I sold land that I had purchased for $4,000 wholesale a few months ago on terms for $15,891, with $447 down and 52 monthly payments of $297.*

2. *Finalized the sale of land I had purchased one month ago, after waiting for a one-month guarantee period to pass. I had purchased the land for $10,000 and sold it on terms for $52,463, with $1,947 down and 73 monthly payments of $692.*

Flight School classes are invaluable, as you learn from instructors with years of experience in this business and a proven model/recipe. I am diligently following the recipe and have sold six properties in less than eight weeks. I have also bought three lots from mailing with two more in progress, as of today."

—RAJ SENTHI

"I sold my first property! Super excited!! I posted the property on Facebook in several buy/sell groups yesterday morning and had a really good response in one particular group. From that post, a husband and wife went to look at the land today and made me an offer this afternoon. After some negotiation, we agreed on a price a few minutes ago, a total of 33 hours from when I posted it on Facebook for the first time. Wow!"

—MELISSA CALLEGARI

"Wow!!! I learned more about business and marketing in a day and a half than I learned getting my MBA and in 20 years of working for corporations. It's worth the investment in yourself to find your family's path to financial freedom."

—LOREE P.

"Flight School has allowed me total time, money, and location freedom! I highly recommend it."

—JAKE S.

"I really appreciated all the tips. The coaches, leaders, and Mark really know what they are talking about. I have learned a lot. I appreciated watching a Facebook ad being written in real time. I also appreciated the tips on creating a buyers list. I have already learned a lot, and there is still one more day!"

—RACHEL S.

"My struggle was sending out 2,896 mailings at once. But my wins from this have produced over 40 parcels to possibly buy this month. I do feel like I'm now surrounded by the land investor community. If anyone is thinking about doing this, jump forward and JUST DO IT!"

—LISA WANNEMACHER

These are just some of the experiences shared by people just like you, who attended some of our trainings to teach the principles you'll learn in this book, edited only for formatting and clarity to fit into book form.

To see and hear even more experiences of people in the Land Geek community, visit thelandgeek.com/students-say.

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To my Mom and Dad for making this all possible. Your unconditional love and support have been everything to me.

To Noah, Elan & Ella - I love you more than words can say, but I'm going to try anyway! Near or far, you're always in my heart because you make the world a brighter place just by being YOU.

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Introduction

In 2018, I published my first book, *Dirt Rich*, with the goal of helping people break into the wonderful world of real estate investing without having to battle with tenants, toilets, or termites.

How? Land investing.

Before publishing *Dirt Rich*, I had only shared systems I had built to generate what I called the "ultimate subscription model" for creating passive income with people who had been through one of my programs.

Since publishing *Dirt Rich*, people all around the world have been able to use those systems as well.

Some invested as a side hustle, building passive income to supplement their day job income, fund vacations, get out of debt, or save up for their dream house. Others grew their land business into a full-time income, quitting their day jobs to obtain a life of fiscal independence, with the flexibility to work where they wanted, when they wanted, and with whom they wanted.

As the months and years passed, more and more people became aware of just how profitable land investing could be. Thousands of new land investors joined my online communities and joined my programs. Some read *Dirt Rich* and wanted even more guidance and support in implementing the steps I outlined in the book. Others had already started implementing the steps and wanted help taking their side hustle or full-time land business to the next level. They had built

a steady stream of income but were still heavily involved in their business. They were still acquiring and scrubbing lists of land from assessors' offices themselves. They were still mailing offers themselves. They were still calling sellers, doing their own due diligence, drafting ads, talking with buyers, processing paperwork, and more.

They had achieved time, financial, and location freedom in that they could work whenever and wherever they wanted and were generating a healthy income. Some of them had a little help but, for the most part, if they stopped working, eventually their income would dry up.

For these people to truly take their businesses to the next level, they needed systems, processes, automations, and people in place to take over the day-to-day operations of their land businesses.

To help those people achieve complete time, money, and location freedom, I began teaching the systems, automations, and delegation strategies that I had developed over many years to extract myself from the day-to-day operations of my business without missing a beat. Very quickly, student after student started realizing the benefits that it took me years to achieve as I developed what I shared with them.

And now, I'm going to share the same systems, automations, and delegation with you.

If you've tasted the freedom that land investing can bring but find yourself still doing too much in your business, keep reading. I wrote this for you.

If you want to achieve the ultimate time, financial, and location freedom without having to do all the work yourself, keep reading. I wrote this for you.

If you want to transform your business into one that allows you total freedom to work when you want, where you want, and with whom you want, keep reading. I wrote this for you.

Implementing the systems, automations, and delegation strategies I share over the rest of this book will get you to a land business that is 90 percent automated and allows you to enjoy life on your own terms.

Even better, you can start experiencing the benefits right away if you start implementing as you read. One by one, tasks will fall off your to-do list. They'll be systematized, automated, or delegated with ease.

All you need to do is take action.

Get started.

Implement what you'll learn over the rest of the book, and you'll be well on your way to building the business—and life—of your dreams.

Ready?

Let's get started.

Part 1

Setting Up Your Business to Start Making Your Way Out

Chapter 1

Rainy Days & Sundays Always Get Me Down

What would life be like if you woke up and didn't care what day it was?

That's my reality today, and the reality for many land investors I've helped over the years.

But life wasn't always that way.

Before building my land business, I spent most of my days sitting in a cubicle getting micromanaged. That was my life. My nine-to-five could have been summed up in one simple word: soulless. I was more excited for those two hands to hit the magical five o'clock than I was for any rich man I was bending over backward to make richer.

Unlike my colleagues, attending cocktail parties to sit pretty with the upper echelons of society wasn't enough to keep me satisfied. Neither was the "esteemed" status of being an investment banker working for fancy private equity groups. Every time I put on those finely threaded clothes or took out my sparkly jewelry, I knew I was living a lie. I belonged up there with the cream of the crop but, in reality, I felt miserable inside.

There was one little light inside of me, however, that provided me with a beacon of hope: flipping raw land. Flipping raw land online

was a side hustle that was gaining traction, and I was making a killing on it. In fact, I was making a 300 percent return on my investment.

To other investment banking people, starting a side hustle flipping raw land might appear strange. I was making great money in a prestigious industry. What was the need to do all the extra work to build a side hustle?

A lot of it started in December of 2001. The terrorist attacks of September 11 had happened only a few months earlier, and I couldn't kick the harsh realization that life is short. My side hustle was growing and was much more fulfilling than my day job. I was ready to take a chance on myself.

It wasn't easy to uproot my life by switching my career path. I tried all I could to keep one foot in the door. I tried to negotiate a consulting agreement. I couldn't stand the thought of losing my health benefits, especially with a pregnant wife. But the dilemma was clear: I was either in or I was out—no ifs, ands, or buts. So, I said I was out.

If you've ever quit a job that sucked the soul out of you, you might understand the wave of elation I was riding on the drive home the day I handed in my notice. I felt like a thousand pounds had been lifted off my shoulders. I felt free, but also scared: there was a conundrum of emotions dancing in my belly.

Naturally, I called my mom and told her I quit my job. In her wise, motherly voice, she told me something I really needed to hear. She said, "Mark, that's great. You're going to be fine. I'm proud of you." With my mom's blessing secured, I took the leap of faith. I went full-time into the land of real estate. In other words, I was officially off to the races.

Once I built my land business, however, I no longer cared what day of the week it was. I was fueled by a sense of purpose and

excitement of another busy day buying and selling land.

My typical day would start at 6:00 a.m., with my eyes shooting open, fully energized to start the day. No longer did I dread Sunday nights or getting up any morning. Every morning would start with excitement to check my phone to see if I had made any money while I was sleeping. That feeling is hard to beat, looking at your phone to notice another sale and knowing exactly what you need to do to process the deal and paperwork that day.

I'd get to the bank right at 9:00 a.m. when the doors opened to sign the deed and have it notarized.

Around 9:30 a.m., I'd leave the bank with all the paperwork in hand and head over to Kinko's to use their big scanner to proudly send my customer their plat map along with a letter congratulating them on the acquisition of their new land investment as well as physical copies of the pictures and the story and all the marketing material I had put online.

It would take me thirty minutes at Kinko's to get all the copies ready to send. Around 10:00 a.m., I'd drive over to the UPS store to mail the package to my buyer. All that driving meant that I was having a good day.

Many times, my phone would ring on my way to the UPS store with a new lead. I'd answer the phone and talk about another deal. It'd be someone wanting to buy another piece of land from me. We'd talk all about this five-acre plot. They'd seem very interested, so I'd ask them the magic question: "How much do you want to put down?"

They'd ask, "Can I put down $1,000?" I'd say, "Sure. How about you put $2,000 down and I lower your interest rate by half?" Sure enough, they would. They'd put $2,000 down and I'd make yet another sale.

Time to process more paperwork.

I'd spend the next few hours typing up paperwork—purchase sale agreement, land contract, name, address, legal description, all the details about the property. As the day goes by, I'd work straight through lunch. Too energized; too stoked.

My phone would be ringing. My inbox would be filling up with emails. I'd jump back and forth, answering calls, responding to emails, handling all sorts of questions about my properties. Next thing I'd know, there'd be more deal flow coming in.

As the calls and emails would come in, I'd make notes on my computer, logging everything into my spreadsheet. Next would come due diligence, contacting local abstractors, contacting the county and seeing whether taxes were owed on properties, checking all the boxes to get more land in, processing sales, and conducting all the due diligence needed to run a "successful" land business.

Hours would pass and I'd be just as energized late afternoon as I had been at 6:00 a.m., when my eyes first opened, without even taking a short break. The next time I'd notice the time, I'd realize it was five o'clock in the afternoon.

I'd hear the kids running around the house and my wife calling out to me that dinner was almost ready. The kids would interrupt, asking if I could play with them until dinner. But I'd need one more hour to get to a good stopping point. "One more hour," I'd request. "I'm almost done with my day." But after a little more prodding from my wife and kids, I'd decide to end my day, play with the kids, and have dinner with the family.

After the kids would go to bed, however, I'd be right back at it. It was important for me to finish up all the administrative details from the day.

I’d go to bed smiling because I’d be having coffee with my mentor, Ori, the next day. After making another $8,000, I couldn’t wait to tell him about all my newfound success.

Chapter 2

Solo Economic Dependency

"Mark, please don't insult me and call yourself a business owner. You're not."

About seven years into my land business, I sat down for my first mentorship meeting with my first land business mentor. I was very proud of the business I had built.

I had been profitable since the first month. I had made more than $100,000 in profits in my first year. I had made enough to quit my job as an investment banker for good within eighteen months, and my business only grew from there until 2008 when the Great Recession hit. When the economy took a turn, my income dropped. It got bad. Eventually, I was forced to swallow my pride and cut expenses.

While it wasn't fun at the time, I'm now thankful for having struggled through the Great Recession. Had the Great Recession not happened, I might never have met with my first mentor, Ori. I hadn't planned on hiring a mentor until the recession hit. Before then, I was very happy and making a lot of money. But when the economy slowed down, I realized there was a lot about the land business I didn't know. But I didn't know what I didn't know, so I reached out to Ori to ask whether he would agree to mentor me.

Harsh Words

I was excited when Ori agreed to mentor me and went into our first meeting feeling very encouraged. My plan was to tell him about my business and ask him for help identifying my blind spots.

I had it all planned out in my head. I would tell him about my business, and he would be impressed. I'd then tell him about how the Great Recession impacted me, and he would be sympathetic.

Boy, I was wrong.

I started telling him about my business, but the moment the words "my business" came out of my mouth, he interrupted me.

"Mark, please don't insult me and call yourself a business owner. You're not."

Ouch. That wasn't what I expected.

"What are you talking about?" I asked, defensively. "I make my own hours. I don't have to show up at an office. I'm not fighting traffic, commuting like I used to. I don't have a boss!"

He wasn't convinced—or impressed.

"Well, if you stop working tomorrow," he replied, "what would happen to your so-called business? What would happen to your family if you died tomorrow? Will your income continue coming in?"

"No."

"Entrepreneurs build something bigger than themselves. When Steve Jobs died, Apple didn't fall apart. But if you die, Frontier Properties is done. So don't insult me. You're not a business owner. You've just created a better job for yourself. You need to start getting yourself out of the business."

That was when the lightning bolt hit me. He was right. I might not have had a boss, but I hadn't built a business. I had built myself a better job. I wasn't a business owner. At best, I was a freelancer, with 100 percent of my income dependent on my ability to work. I was suffering from the dreaded solo economic dependency.

The Freelancer Trap

In 1997, Robert Kiyosaki and Sharon Lechter released a book that would change the way millions of people view work and money, *Rich Dad Poor Dad: What the Rich Teach Their Kids About Money That the Poor and Middle Class Do Not!*

Rich Dad Poor Dad explores the differences in the mindset and actions wealthy people take by comparing Robert Kiyosaki's biological father, whom Kiyosaki calls his "poor dad," to a mentor of Kiyosaki's, whom he calls his "rich dad."

Kiyosaki's "poor dad" worked hard his entire life. He followed the typical employee path and took care of his family but never obtained financial freedom. Kiyosaki's "rich dad" accumulated wealth through entrepreneurship and investing.

One of the core teachings of *Rich Dad Poor Dad* is the concept of the four cash flow quadrants.

The four cash flow quadrants represent four ways people make money: as employees, self-employed, business owners, and investors.

Most people work their entire life as employees. They commute to work, punch a clock, and commute home. Some people aren't good employees or don't like having a boss, so they become self-employed. These are the ironically named "freelancers," who are far

from free. Freelancers don’t own a business; they just create better jobs for themselves.

They are doctors, lawyers, consultants, and other service providers. They are their own bosses, but if they don’t work, they don’t make money. If they want to make more money, they either raise their prices, work more, or both. This is what I had built for myself the day I sat down with Ori.

Business owners have systems in place that help them make money even when they aren’t working. They hire people to implement the systems and delegate or outsource as much as possible. To make more money, they hire more people, raise prices, add products or services, or adjust their systems. They don’t work more. Investors make money by acquiring assets that produce passive income, such as loan portfolios or businesses. To make more money, they acquire more passive income-producing assets.

When you first get into the land business, most likely you will start out as a freelancer, and for good reason. You need to learn the ropes of the business so you can effectively delegate. But if you remain a freelancer, you can become trapped in an only slightly more enjoyable job you’ve created for yourself. You might make more money and not have a boss, but you’re trapped by your work because you need to work to make money. That’s what I call the freelancer trap.

The only way to escape the freelancer trap is to become a real business owner like Ori pushed me to become. You need to build a real land business with systems, automation, and delegation that doesn’t require your input to function. Only then can you be truly free.

Solo Economic Showdown: Penn and Teller vs. Wink, Goldman, and Stanton

Who would you rather be, Penn and Teller or Chris Wink, Matt Goldman, and Phil Stanton? The answer might surprise you.

Penn and Teller are all over Las Vegas and TV. They're known around the world and make a tremendous living.

I don't know how many shows they do a year, but it's a lot. And, although they clearly love what they do, at some point, it has to get tiring. I bet you after the thousandth time performing the same illusions, they'd love to not have to show up to make money.

What about Chris Wink, Matt Goldman, and Phil Stanton? Do you even know who they are? Most people don't. In 1987, the trio started performing a live show together, combining high-energy live music and art performances. Their schtick was to perform while wearing blue masks and body paint. If you haven't guessed it by now, Wink, Goldman, and Stanton are the creators of the show Blue Man Group.

To this day, hardly anyone knows the creators of Blue Man Group. I even had to look them up to make sure I got their names right. But they have built a real business that continues to make them money even without them showing up. Like Penn and Teller, you can buy tickets and see Blue Man Group perform live. Unlike Penn and Teller, you can catch a Blue Man Group show in cities around the world without Wink, Goldman, or Stanton needing to be there.

The trio doesn't need to be at any show to make money. All they need is seven to nine performers willing to paint themselves blue and follow their formula. They set up their business to run without them. That setup allows them to create passive income every single month.

Penn and Teller have solo economic dependency. Their income depends on their ability to work. Wink, Goldman, and Stanton's income does not. Their income will continue to come in month after month without them having to do a thing.

If you want to build a real land business without solo economic dependency, you need to follow the Blue Man Group model.

Being Rich vs. Being Wealthy

Imagine I could wave a magic wand and grant you one wish. But here's the catch. I only grant one of two wishes. I can either double your net worth or give you eight more hours every day for the rest of your life.

Which would you choose?

To some, immediately doubling your net worth is tempting. You could do more land deals. You could buy your dream house or take that trip around the world you've always wanted to take. Or maybe you could have enough money in the bank to retire.

But what about time? What would eight additional hours do for you every day? What could you do with that time? Could you spend even more time with your family? Could you cut down to working two or three days per week? Could you get back in shape or improve your golf game?

What problem would you rather solve, not having enough time or not having enough money? To me, time is the easy choice.

We have countless ways to solve money problems. Money problems are easy to solve. You could make more, spend less, or do both.

But time is our most valuable and finite resource. You can't make more time like you can with money. We all have the same twenty-

four hours in the day and need to sleep during a big chunk of that. And we all have only a very, very short time to spend on this little blue marble circling the sun.

If you make a lot of money but have to keep working to continue to earn that money, you have solved your money problem but not your time problem. That's the reality with many doctors, lawyers, investment bankers, consultants, and C-suite executives. They make a lot of money, but if they stop working, the money stops coming in.

Would you want to trade places with those people? Would you want their stress? You might like their house, their car, and those luxury vacations they can take, but they have no control over their lives. They sit in traffic or stuff themselves into crowded trains or buses to and from work every day. By the time they get home, they're physically and mentally exhausted from all the demands of the day.

Does that sound like freedom to you? Does it sound like a fulfilling life? What good is all the income they make if they don't have any time or freedom to enjoy it?

It doesn't matter what you do. If your income stops coming in if you stop working, you are not truly free.

Solo economic dependency impacts anyone with a job, even the highest-paid athletes in the world. That's why we hear so many stories of athletes going broke after they stop playing. They make millions of dollars for a very short period of time. If they don't find other sources of income after their playing career ends, they will eventually go broke.

NBA great Shaquille O'Neal recognized this during his career. When talking about his time with the Los Angeles Lakers, he recognized that he was rich while Lakers owner Jerry Buss was wealthy. Shaq had to show up every day for practice and games to earn his income. And when he got too old to compete in the NBA, his paychecks would stop.

Jerry Buss didn't have to be on the court, or anywhere else for that matter. His earning potential also didn't have the same shelf life as an NBA playing career. Other people ran his business and made him money.

Since retiring from the NBA in 2011, Shaq has built a business empire to continue to grow his income and net worth. According to reports, Shaq now makes more passive income from his business ventures than he made as a player in the NBA. His portfolio has included more than 155 Five Guys restaurants, 17 Auntie Annie's pretzels shops, 9 Papa John's pizza franchises, a Krispy Kreme donut franchise, and more.

Shaq became rich by playing basketball but became wealthy by owning businesses. He now serves as a commentator for NBA games, not because he has to but because he *wants* to.

By building and investing in businesses, Shaq solved both his time *and* his money problems. His businesses generate more passive income than he made playing in the NBA. And he has the time to do whatever he wants because he doesn't have to show up anywhere to make that money.

That's the secret to becoming wealthy. You might not need two hundred restaurants to cover your desired lifestyle. But to become wealthy you need to solve both your time *and* money problems. That means you have enough passive income to cover your desired lifestyle without having to work to keep your income coming in. Only then will you be truly wealthy.

The Time and Money Freedom Formula

It doesn't take too long for people in the land business to see the value of systems, automation, and delegation. We create systems for

finding deals, mailing offers, and more. We build highly profitable, efficient operations using systems, automation, and a small team.

But the systems, automation, and delegation we use to grow a land business *won't* help us make our businesses run without us. They will help us become highly paid freelancers, not business owners.

We need *different* systems to escape the freelancer trap and build passive income machines. We need systems that don't require our involvement, and those are *very* different systems from the ones that do require our involvement.

Those types of systems can help you retire in the next two to four *years*, not two to four *decades*. Those are the systems that will make you the Blue Man Group of the land business.

It doesn't matter if you've already become the Penn and Teller of the land business. If you are ready to escape the freelance trap and solo economic dependency, you can. All it takes is a willingness to implement the systems you'll learn in the following chapters.

These systems have been used by hundreds of land freelancers to build land businesses that give them true time and money freedom. They have helped everyone from students to firefighters to lawyers to dentists to doctors to teachers to stay-at-home parents escape solo economic dependency and enjoy a life of true freedom. And they can help you, too, no matter how much money you make or how deep into your career you are.

Take Roberto Chavez, for example. Roberto came to our coaching program as a successful attorney tired of trading hours for dollars as a lawyer. He was tired of the pressure to bill hours and tired of being dependent on his stressful job to pay his bills. But because his day job was so demanding, Roberto couldn't spend a lot of time as a land freelancer. He needed to put systems, automation, and delegation in place as soon as possible. So, as soon as he got

comfortable buying, marketing, and selling land, he started implementing the strategies you will learn in this book.

Within one year, he was generating over $10,000 a month in passive income. He was no longer dependent on his day job to pay his bills. After putting in place the systems, automation, and delegation strategies you will learn in this book, Roberto had options for the first time in a long time. He no longer had to work five days a week as a lawyer, so he cut back to three days a week. He now spends one full day doing whatever he wants. On the other day, he helps out his elderly dad on his ranch, bonding and deepening that father-son relationship.

A year after that, Roberto is generating more than $20,000 a month in passive income, only two years into his land business. He's now getting ready to quit his full-time job completely to start a family. That was Roberto's dream. In one short year, he had already cut down by two days a week. One year after that, he's completely free.

It doesn't matter what your dream life is, you need to first escape the freelancer trap and solo economic dependency. In the next chapter, I'll share exactly how the systems you'll learn in this book will be your ticket to freedom.

Chapter 3

The Mindset Needed to Shift Out of Your Business

When it comes to building a land business, it's easy to do too much work yourself. After all, you are the cheapest person you can hire. You work for free. Surely, free is cheaper than paying someone to perform a task. Or is it?

What if "free" isn't really free? What if performing tasks yourself is actually costing you hundreds of thousands of dollars a year? If you do the math, you'll discover the true cost of "free" labor is extraordinary.

Let's call our two business owners Edgar and Cathy. Edgar and Cathy have been buying and selling land for three years. They each make $2,000 per week in profits and work fifty hours per week.

With simple systems, people, and software in place, no more than five of those hours would need to be worked by Edgar or Cathy. The other forty-five hours could be worked by a virtual assistant for $10 per hour.

While the prospect of working only five hours per week sounds nice, Edgar thinks he can't afford to put the systems, people, and software in place. He continues to do all the work himself. One year later, Edgar is still working fifty hours per week and making $2,000 per week. He makes $40 an hour for his time.

Cathy takes a different approach. She sees the time and money it would take to put systems, people, and software in place as an investment. She values her time and doesn't want to be stuck working fifty hours per week. Investing $450 per week to free up forty-five hours every week sounds like a good deal to Cathy. Even if she doesn't get any more profitable, she would rather work five hours per week for $1,550 than fifty hours per week for $2,000. Instead of $40 an hour for her time, Cathy makes $310 an hour and has forty-five additional hours per week to do whatever she wants.

Let's continue the example, focusing on additional improvements Cathy can make to her business by investing just ten of those forty-five hours she freed up into being a CEO of her business. She adds additional automations, improves her systems, and trains a commission-only virtual assistant to take over some of the few tasks she was still performing, such as closing sales. Six months later, her business is making $4,000 per week in profits, and Cathy is able to reduce her hours to just two hours per week. Even better, she's no longer doing any of the day-to-day tasks; her two hours per week are spent further improving her business as a CEO.

When they started, both Edgar and Cathy were working fifty hours a week and making $2,000 per week, or $40 an hour.

At the end of eighteen months

- Edgar is making $2,000 per week or $104,000 per year. Cathy is making $4,000 per week or $208,000 per year.
- Edgar is working fifty hours per week. Cathy is working two hours per week.
- Edgar is making $40 per hour worked. Cathy is making $2,000 per hour worked.
- Edgar is performing mundane tasks. Cathy is performing CEO duties.

Whose life would you rather be living eighteen months from now, Edgar's or Cathy's? If you want to spend your days buying and selling land like Edgar, you can stop reading now. You have everything you need to do that using what you learned already in this book and in my first book, *Dirt Rich*. You'll be able to make great money, but you will have to work hard to keep that money coming in.

But if you want to create more time *and* money for yourself, like Cathy, keep reading. The rest of the book will help you build a land business that takes back your time, giving you more control of the twenty-four hours we're all given each day. No more having to send out offer letters. No more having to run to Kinko's or the post office. And no more having to talk to sellers and buyers all day. The systems, people, and software I share with you will help you get there.

But before you move forward, you must shift your mindset from that of someone who buys and sells land, like Edgar, to someone who owns a land business, like Cathy. Otherwise, you won't do the work to extricate yourself from your business. You'll take that one extra call because it's easier for you to do it quickly than to take the time to train someone else to do it. You'll give up on training a virtual assistant to implement your systems because you can do it quicker. You'll write that one ad yourself. And you won't spend a few hours putting in place software that can save you a few hours every day. I've seen it over and over again. The systems, people, and software I share with you can help you go from fifty hours a week to two hours a week, like Cathy, and even two hours a *month*, like me. But you *must* shift your mindset from that of an employee to that of a CEO or business owner first. If you can't or won't make that mindset shift, you will never shift out of your business.

Do You Want a Better Job or a Better Life?

If there's one thing most people can agree on it's that we can always make more money, but we can never make more time. No matter what we do, we each only have twenty-four hours a day. But what if we *could* structure our business so we had more control over those twenty-four hours and didn't have to work eight to ten hours every day? When we shift the way we think about work, we can build a business that allows us to achieve just that—more free hours to do whatever we want every day.

For people who work in day jobs, the vast majority of those twenty-four hours are spent sleeping, working, commuting, and taking care of errands and other obligations. Most people are lucky if they have an hour a day to themselves.

That's what makes the idea of becoming a business owner so attractive. Not only can we make more money, but we can also leverage other people's time, money, and software to create more free time for ourselves. So, while we might not actually create more total time in the day, we can easily create more *free time* for ourselves and our families, especially in the land business where we don't have to worry about tenants, toilets, or termites. All we need is the right systems, people, and software in place and we can create eight to ten more free hours for ourselves every day.

Developing a CEO Mindset

Derek Sivers knows the struggle of delegation. Sivers started a company called CD Baby by accident in 1997. He had been selling his own music on his website and some friends asked whether he could help them sell theirs as well. And that began the rollercoaster journey for Sivers through which he helped sell more than $100 million worth of music for more than 150,000 people through CD Baby.

In 2008, Sivers sold CD Baby for $22 million through a charitable trust, which will pay him a nice salary every year while he is alive and donate the remainder to benefit music education when he dies. Not bad for a business he started by accident.

How did he grow an accidental business to something worth millions of dollars? It wasn't easy and took a big mindset shift for Sivers.

"You're so busy, doing everything yourself," he explained. "You know you need help, but to find and train someone would take more time than you have! So, you keep working harder, until you break."

As Sivers writes in his book *Anything You Want: 40 Lessons for a New Kind of Entrepreneur*, breaking into the delegation mindset means making yourself unnecessary to the running of the company. That's why it's so important to develop the mindset I talk about in this chapter. This is one of those times when you'll need it to make progress.

That's what makes building a simple system every team member could follow so helpful. With Sivers, when an employee had a question, he answered it, but more importantly, he also explained the thought process and philosophy behind his answer. That allowed his team to start making or improving systems.

"I asked one person to start a manual, and write down the answer to this one situation, and write down the philosophy behind it," writes Sivers. "Ten minutes later, new question. Same process:

1. Gather everybody around.
2. Answer the question and explain the philosophy.
3. Make sure everyone understands the thought process.
4. Ask one person to write it in the manual.
5. Let everybody know they can decide this without me next time."

After only a couple of months, there were no more questions, and Sivers stopped going to the office, started working from home, and even moved to California.

"Because my team was running the business, I was free to actually improve the business!" he writes. "I was still working 12-hour days, but now I was spending all my time on improvements, optimizations, and innovations. To me, this was the fun stuff. This was play, not work."

The CEO's Secret Weapon: Leverage

At its core, the single factor that distinguishes employees from CEOs is leverage. Simply put, CEOs leverage other people's time, money, and software to produce results while employees *are* the leverage other people use to produce results.

That's exactly what Derek Sivers did with CD Baby. He looked for ways to leverage other people's time, money, and software to perform. When people asked him questions, he answered, gave them context, and asked someone to document the system so others could perform the task.

That gave him the freedom to choose what he wanted to do with his time. In his case, he chose to still work twelve hours a day so he could build CD Baby. But, as he puts it, he delegated everything except for what he described as "the fun stuff" that he loved to perform. That's freedom.

In the land business, when we use the CEO's secret weapon of leverage, we get to make similar choices as Sivers. We can choose to be like Cathy and invest part of those hours back into our businesses and enjoy the rest. I choose to use that freedom to work two hours a month. I spend the rest of my time with my family, friends and teaching people like you how to break into—and scale

out of—the land business. If you develop a CEO mindset, you'll get to do whatever you want, too.

> *In the late twentieth century, CEOs used to measure the success of their business based on how many people they employed.*
>
> *Today, the fewer people you have working with you, the better.*
>
> *The most effective land business CEOs can leverage systems and technology to build a highly profitable business with only a few team members.*

Determining Whether You're Ready

Before you transition from employee to CEO, you must be able to pass a simple two-part readiness test. If you can pass this test, you're ready to navigate the uncomfortable but important shift from employee to CEO. If you can't, you must first address these two big issues before moving forward. Doing so will make the difficult transition to CEO much easier for you.

First, you need to truly understand your business. Land business CEOs understand their business from the inside out. This is important because it helps you delegate and outsource more effectively. It helps you set up better systems. It helps you answer questions from team members as you transition your work to them. And it helps you identify and prioritize tasks to delegate, outsource, or automate while you focus on the bigger picture of scaling your business.

Second, you must be ready for a challenge. If you're not willing to push through temporary discomfort to achieve permanent freedom,

you'll never make the shift. If you're anything like the students who have followed the process I share with you here, your transition will be uncomfortable for twelve to eighteen months, after which you will achieve true time and financial freedom. You must be ready for that discomfort. If not, you won't do the hard work of delegating, outsourcing, and automating your business.

So, if you understand your business and are ready for a challenge, you're ready to move forward.

Making the Mindset Shift

In 2004, Gary Boomershine was burned out. He was married with two small kids and was working eighty to ninety hours a week at a Silicon Valley technology startup. He had been traveling around the world and working around the clock, never getting to see the light outside because he was always in buildings when the sun was out. He enjoyed the work but hated his life. So, he and his wife decided to make a big change. He needed to work less without taking away his ability to take care of his family.

To achieve his goal, Gary leaned on the concept of the four quadrants from *Rich Dad Poor Dad*, which we talked about in chapter 2. Until that point, he had been making money as an employee. To discover true freedom, he knew he needed to be more of a business owner or investor.

So, in 2005, he founded his company RealEstateInvestor.com. Since then, Gary has purchased six hundred types of properties, growing his business using systems, people, and automation to achieve both time and money freedom. Now he helps others build freedom through real estate investing.

Gary agrees that *way too many people* get stuck doing *way too much work* for *way too little money*. He sees way too many real

estate investors doing too much of the day-to-day work themselves. Even worse, much of that work could be delegated to someone for no more than $10 an hour. Some could be automated using software. Yet, real estate investors have a hard time letting go of the $10-an-hour tasks.

According to Gary, shifting your mindset so you can let go of the $10 tasks requires you to look at time, money, and opportunities with an investor's mindset. To paraphrase Gary: There's a return on investment on money. There's a return on investment on time. And there's what's called a lost opportunity cost or opportunity cost. And you have to get these concepts. And then, how do you apply them in real estate immediately?

Most people understand how the concept of getting a return on investment, or ROI, works with respect to money. If you buy a piece of land for $1,000 and sell it for $4,000, your investment gain is $3,000, so you made a 300 percent return (profits) on your initial investment ($1,000). Most land business owners understand this and apply it to their business. They want all their money to go toward buying land they can sell for a profit to get that return.

As you shift toward becoming a CEO, you also must consider the return on your investment of time. Gary suggests valuing your time between $250 and $1,000 per hour if you want to live a nice life. If you are earning less than $250 per hour for the time you invest in your land business, consider outsourcing anything you can outsource for less than $250. With the land business, you can outsource all day-to-day tasks for $2 to $15 per hour if you use the systems I share with you later in this book. The only things you need to keep are CEO tasks. Many land business owners understand this concept as well but don't assign a value to their time and outsource tasks to lower-priced virtual assistants. This keeps them on what Gary calls the Hobbit wheel, stuck working way too much for way too little money.

Finally, CEOs also apply the concept of lost opportunity cost, or opportunity cost, to their business. Going back to the example of Edgar and Cathy, an employee mindset would describe Edgar as having stayed still with Cathy making a substantial return on her investment of time and money to leverage systems, people, and software. A CEO mindset would have a similar perspective with respect to Cathy but would look at Edgar differently. A CEO would describe Edgar as having suffered significant opportunity cost. Edgar lost the opportunity to free up forty-eight hours per week while increasing his profits to $208,000 per year.

Focusing on the return on lost opportunity cost in addition to the return on investment of time and money is important because it helps us avoid complacency. If we only think of our business in terms of time and money, it's easy to keep living our own versions of *Groundhog Day* for another week, month, or even year. But when we consider all the opportunities, we give up by doing so, we're more inclined to get started and push through.

A Better Life Awaits

Toward the beginning of this chapter, I asked you whether you wanted a better job or a better life. Do you want to live like Edgar, working fifty hours per week to keep his business running? Or would you prefer to live like Cathy, working two hours per week as the CEO of her business with the freedom to do whatever she wants with the rest of her time?

When you leverage systems, people, and software to make more money in less time, the return on your investment is to be living a better life. When you don't, your life will remain the same.

The choice is yours. You can move forward with the mindset of an employee and miss out on the opportunity for a better life, or you

can move forward with a CEO mindset and live a life of your own choosing.

If you're ready to live a life of your own choosing, keep reading. The rest of the book will show you the way.

Part 2

Optimizing Your Systems to Make You Unnecessary

Chapter 4

Why You Need Systems before Anything Else

In the 1993 movie *Groundhog Day*, Bill Murray plays a cynical, egotistical weatherman named Phil Connors who becomes trapped in a time loop causing him to relive the same day—Groundhog Day—over and over again.

Every morning, he woke up at 6:00 a.m. on February 2—Groundhog Day—in Punxsutawney, Pennsylvania. And every day followed almost the exact same routine as the preceding February 2. No matter what Phil did, nothing changed. Everyone around him said and did the exact same things as they had done the day before.

Phil quickly realized he was stuck in an endless loop. At first, he took advantage of his situation, tricking people and conning people. Over time, however, he began to transform himself into a new man, starting to help people and ditching his cynical, egotistical ways.

Only after changing his ways was Phil able to break the loop and wake up to it being February 3 (he was even nice to Needle Nose Ned).

My Real-Life Groundhog Day: A Land Investor without the Right Systems

After Ori confronted me about not being a business owner, I realized I had been living my own version of Groundhog Day. I may not have had a boss, but I was living the same day over and over again. I woke up, still tired from the day before, and almost immediately started checking email. I double-checked pricing for lots, prepared offer letters, and spoke with my virtual assistant to make sure the mail would go out that day. I then spent hours talking with people who might be interested in selling me their property.

A single call with someone interested in selling me their property lasted thirty minutes or longer. Sellers would share long histories about why they bought the property, what their goal was for the property, and why they were so disappointed that their dreams never became a reality. Sometimes we negotiated a sale. Many times, we didn't, and all that time on the phone would be wasted.

I'd spend the rest of my day marketing properties I owned, closing sales, and driving back and forth to Kinko's. That meant even more phone calls, this time with potential buyers. It also meant preparing promissory notes, purchase sale agreements, and land sale contracts. When all that was done, off to Kinko's I'd go to print out maps, make copies of maps, and send property report packages to the buyers.

If my typical day sounds exhausting to you, it's because it *was* exhausting. After Ori opened my eyes to the fact that I hadn't built a land business but had only built myself a better job, I couldn't believe I hadn't realized it sooner.

By the time I came up for air from all the research, marketing, phone calls, and paperwork, my day would be over. I'd go to bed feeling like I hadn't got enough done only to wake up the next morning feeling like I hadn't got enough sleep.

While the money was good, the toll it took on me was harsh. I was in a constant state of scarcity thinking. There was never enough. I couldn't do enough work. So, I spent a lot of my time working in my land business. And when I wasn't working in the business, I was thinking about the business. If I wasn't busy, I wouldn't feel good. I was a deal junkie. I had some systems in place, but they all required me to be involved in the business. They were systems to make me more efficient, not to make me unnecessary. My business was running me. I wasn't running the business. That was no way to live.

Using Systems to Take Back My Time While Making More Money

After leaving that meeting with Ori, I made a commitment to myself that I would no longer let my business run me. Instead, I would take back my time and build a real land business that wouldn't need me to be by the computer or on the phone all day. That said, as motivated as I was to get the results, I didn't let go of my bad habits very easily. I was more like a toddler giving away a toy.

Eventually, I let go of my bad habits but was kicking and screaming the entire time. The result? I made a lot of mistakes along the way too. The outcome? It took me five years of trial and error, but I made it happen. I was down to working two hours per month and making more money than I was when I was working full-time buying and selling land. (Today, my clients take only twelve to eighteen months to achieve that same outcome using the processes, tools, and strategies I'll share with you in this book! But I didn't have the benefit of any of those. I had to figure them out—or create them—myself!)

My entire life was changed. I could work whenever I wanted, wherever I wanted, and with whomever I wanted. I no longer woke up still tired from the day before. I was no longer tied to my email or

phone all day. And I was no longer on a first-name basis with every employee at my local Kinko's.

Now my days look completely different. I'm down to working *in* my business just two hours a month—a weekly thirty-minute meeting with my acquisition manager. During that meeting, he updates me on deal flow. We discuss how many offers went out that week. He tells me how many deals are pending. He updates me on how many deals we bought and how many deals we're marketing for sale. He tells me how many deals we sold.

We then discuss personnel and systems issues. This helps ensure everything is going smoothly with our team. We discuss and plan how to resolve any issues with team members. We talk about how the systems are working and how we can continue to improve them.

This thirty-minute weekly meeting is all we need. It allows me to make sure everything is on track and nothing in the system has been broken. It also helps me talk through any improvements I want made. And that's all I need to do to keep my business running smoothly.

I still love to be productive and busy but do so by doing things that fulfill me instead of answering emails, talking on the phone, and running to Kinko's every day. I spend time with my family, work out, read, meditate, work *on* my business thinking of ways to improve and grow as the CEO, and help others build land businesses.

Having the freedom to do what I want, where I want, and with whom I want is the greatest benefit that creating these systems has provided for me. It's even greater than the income it generates. I had income before I had the systems. But I had no time or energy. Now, I have income and complete time and location freedom. And that's true freedom. That's what systems did for me. And that's what systems can do for you. That's why you need systems before

anything else in your land business if you want to achieve true freedom.

Learning from My Mistakes

When I first started building systems for my land business, I was scared. At the core of my worries was that I thought I couldn't trust anyone. I also viewed hiring people as an unnecessary expense that would reduce the money I had available to buy land.

I thought people wouldn't care as much as I did or work as hard as I did. I thought I would be vulnerable if I gave people passwords to my accounts. I thought I would be taken advantage of. I was afraid they would screw something up and I would be left holding the bag and constantly trying to clean up their messes. I also didn't want to go through the hiring process and the firing process.

It was a mixture of anxiety and fear. Building a real business was new to me. I didn't feel competent in it. That caused me to have a lot of internal conflict. On the one hand, I was committed to building a better life and knew the key to doing so was to put systems in place. On the other hand, I was anxious and scared. I didn't want to screw things up or be taken advantage of.

Fortunately for me, I had my mentor to push me. He wasn't as emotionally invested in my business as I was and had already experienced the freedom that comes when you systematize your way out of having to work in your business all day.

I met with him dozens, if not hundreds, of times throughout that five-year period. Every time he pushed me. He asked, "Did you hire this person?" or "Did you get out of this piece of the business?" If I hadn't, I would be embarrassed and feel that I was not living up to my word.

The more he pushed me, the more I implemented. And the more I implemented, the more I wished I had done it sooner. From my very first hire, I realized these people do care just as much as I do about my business. They see the benefit of their work and take pride in their work. I just needed to structure my relationship with them right. I needed to let them know how important their work was and incentivize them right.

Over time, I realized they were actually better than me. They came to the work with a fresh perspective and thought of things to improve the business that never crossed my mind. My solo venture became a collaboration, and it was very gratifying. The business started to grow much bigger than when I was doing everything myself.

Not only that but the systems we had in place gave me great peace of mind about the stability of my business. If a key team member left, I could quickly get someone else up to speed without missing a beat. Not only was *I* not needed anymore but no single human being was needed. We had systems that anyone could learn.

That was all I needed to experience to know Ori was right, so after a slow start, I pushed forward as fast as I could to create systems and processes and hire even more people. I also realized that hiring people was an investment with a much greater return than if I used that money to buy properties because I not only made more money, but I also had complete time and location freedom.

How Systems Helped a Husband and Wife Find Financial Freedom in Eight Months

Jon and Valari Burnett were living a normal life in 2017. Jon had a full-time job, and Valari was home with two kids under two years old. But Jon's work environment was stressful. He was working for a company managing vacation rentals, so he had little control over his

schedule and had to work every holiday. He also had only about thirty minutes of time to spend with the family each day.

While he never sought out to own his own business, he and Valari decided to pursue land investing as a way to dip their toes into a low-risk entrepreneurial venture. After exploring their options, they joined a sixteen-week program we offer called Flight School in July 2017. With Jon working a full-time job and Valari being busy with two kids, they didn't have a lot of time to work on their business. They could work at 5:00 a.m. before Jon went to work, during lunch and nap breaks, and after the kids went to bed.

Flight School appealed to them because they would get access to coaching, accountability, and the systems and processes that took me five years to develop and even more time to perfect. They didn't have to spend years making mistakes like I did. They didn't need to spend hours checking email, talking on the phone, and driving to Kinko's every day.

Within one month, they bought their first piece of property. Two months later, they sold it. And by March 2018, just eight months after starting their land business, Jon was able to quit his job for good to help grow their land business. Jon went from seeing the kids for thirty minutes a day to hours and hours every day. And they have complete time and location freedom because they have systems, people, and technology to do whatever they don't want to do in their business.

Do You Want More Time, More Money, and More Freedom?

What would you do tomorrow if you didn't have to be anywhere, at any time, or with anyone in particular? Would you travel the world? Would you spend quality time with your family? Would you sleep in?

If your day would look different from today, implementing systems into your land business is your solution.

Systems help you work when you want, where you want, and with whom you want. They stabilize your business and ensure your success does not rely on any human being to run it. If you get sick or can't work for a while, you can get someone else to jump in. And if a key team member leaves you, you can get someone else up to speed quickly.

With the right systems in place, you can spend your days doing whatever you want. Want to be able to spend quality time with your family? You need systems. Want to have complete control of your calendar? You need systems. Want to not be so dependent on any human being to make money? You need systems.

Once you have solid, dependable systems in place, you're bulletproof. But the first step to putting the systems in place is to shift the way you look at your business. Way too many people skip this important step and end up making their lives much harder than they need to be. We'll explore this mindset shift in the next chapter so you can learn from their mistakes.

Chapter 5

Identifying the "Three Whys" Needed to Scale Your Business

On the Japanese island of Okinawa, legend has it that a fountain of youth has kept its residents living well into their hundreds. Fortunately for you and me, we can all tap into that fountain of youth without having to travel to Japan or anywhere else. Thanks to *Blue Zones* author, Dan Buettner, we can all build our own fountains of youth by simply identifying the "three whys" of our business. Buettner set out to understand what fueled the world's population of centenarians in what he dubbed Blue Zones—five places in the world where people live the longest, healthiest lives. In Japan, he learned the secret to their long, healthy life was having a sense of purpose beyond the immediate work they did. They call this sense of purpose, *ikigai* (pronounced *icky guy*) in Japan.

In his 2009 TED talk and follow-up 2011 book, *Start With Why* (Penguin Publishing Group, 2011), author Simon Sinek introduced the value of purpose in business to the mainstream world. Today, millions of people credit becoming more inspired in their lives and more successful in business to Sinek's teachings. What does this have to do with scaling your land business? Everything. As Sinek explains, "There are only two ways to influence human behavior: you can manipulate it, or you can inspire it." This is true when trying to inspire others, as well as to inspiring ourselves. In the land business, we need that inspiration if we ever want to scale our businesses without us having to do all the work.

Starting with Why

The concept of having purpose being key to growth is not just a concept promoted by authors or inspirational speakers. It's been proven over and over again. Countless studies confirm the value of purpose to helping people achieve business, personal, and community success.

With our work lives, Sinek notes in his book that studies show that more than 80 percent of Americans aren't working their dream job. That was me even after I had built up a significant income buying and selling land. I was making good money, but I wasn't working my dream job. I didn't want to be on the phone with people all day. I didn't want to be on a first-name basis with the people at Kinko's. I loved the land business, but the job I had built for myself was *not* what I wanted for my life.

Beyond work, a twenty-seven-year study published in the *Journal of the American Medical Association* confirms what Buettner observed about how having purpose in our lives helps us live longer, healthier lives. Specifically, the University of Michigan Health and Retirement Study conducted with the support of the National Institute on Aging and the Social Security Immigration found that purpose was "significantly associated" with living longer, healthier lives.

What about building your business with a motivated team? You've probably guessed it by now, but all the data out there confirms that purpose helps us motivate ourselves and the people we lead. For example, global business consulting firm Deloitte conducts an annual survey of employees around the world, focusing on the millennial and Gen Z generations. Among their survey topics is what motivates them to work hard. Year after year, having purpose beyond the transactional part of their work is among the most important factors cited by workers.

> "There are only two ways to influence human behavior: you can manipulate it, or you can inspire it. We are drawn to leaders and organizations that are good at communicating what they believe. Their ability to make us feel like we belong, to make us feel special, safe and not alone is part of what gives them the ability to inspire us."—Simon Sinek

So how do we incorporate purpose into our land businesses to enable us to scale? We do so by identifying the "three whys" that build purpose: your personal why, your family why, and your community why.

Identifying Your "Personal Why"

Why do you want to get out of your business? Why does this matter to you? What can you achieve if you get out of your business?

Twice a year, Tate Litchfield goes completely off the grid to enjoy far-flung fly-fishing travels with his father and brother—watery journeys he never could have done without discovering his "personal why" to building a land business he can scale. Tate loves being outdoors. "It's one of the most undervalued resources we have in this industry—and it's free," Tate has told me. He's just one of the hundreds of people who've been able to follow their passion by optimizing their systems. Having a personal why to go off the grid and be outdoors with his father and brother motivates Tate to make sometimes scary decisions to systematize, delegate, and use software to run his business.

If you just go into business to generate income, you might never systematize your way out of it. And if you don't systematize your way out of it, you will never achieve the big personal goals in life

that will make you truly happy. You might build a substantial income, but you won't enjoy your life. But if you go into business because you want freedom and flexibility to become a healthier version of yourself, you are more likely to carve out time to train for that marathon or go to the gym. If your why is to inspire others through the lessons you learn, you will be more likely to carve out time to pursue giving a TED talk. The options are endless.

For example, when Roberto Chavez first got started in the land business, his personal why was to stop depending on his nine-to-five job as a lawyer. He didn't want to be trapped by a nine-to-five job for the rest of his life, even if that job was one as a lawyer. Roberto shared his thoughts with me recently: "I was running away from what I saw. It couldn't be the rest of my life if I stayed only with that," he explained. "It was the fear of never building something that would generate money while I'm sleeping, while I'm on vacation or I'm having fun. I didn't want to look back twenty or thirty years from now and still be in the same place."

People have many whys for scaling their business and no one is better than any other. The only rule is that your personal why must be your own for it to work. Identify your why and keep it top of mind. That will give you the motivation to put in place the systems, people, and software to free up your time while you continue to make more money.

Personal Whys: Costa Rica, Van Life, and Skiing

When coaching client and former Land Geek coach Chris Clark discovered his personal why, he was a corporate jet pilot who found himself with extra time on his hands and fell into real estate and flipping houses, which was driving him nuts with the competition. Investing in land, however, was much more appealing. "I love the simplicity of it—the fact that it's just one seller and then one buyer," says Clark, who was able to spend a

month in Costa Rica through his land investments. Another client, Nat Bruno, has been able to relive his ski-bum days (#vanlife) by chasing the snow around the world.

That's the beauty of personal whys. They can be anything you want. As long as it's something important to you, it will work.

Identifying Your "Family Why"

Why does getting out of your business matter to your family? What could you do for your family if you could make substantially more money while working significantly fewer hours? What family traditions could you start? What positive influence could you have on your kids? What impact could you have on other people's families by hiring a few virtual assistants and giving them an opportunity to earn significant income helping you run your land business?

As with our personal whys, the answers to those questions are limitless. When Valari and Jon Burnett started their land business, they wanted to get Jon out of the working world and spend more time together as a family. That "family why" gave them the motivation to structure their land business so Jon can be present with the family for hours every day. When Roberto Chavez started, he wanted to cut down his hours as a lawyer and spend time with his aging dad. That goal gave him the drive to put in place the systems, automation, and delegation strategies needed to cut back to practicing law three days a week. He now spends an entire day helping out his elderly dad on his ranch, bonding and deepening that father-son relationship.

Your family goals might be different from what Valari, Jon, and Roberto had in mind. You might want to free up time to enter the dating world. You might want to start a family with your spouse. You might want to break a generational pattern of poverty in your family.

Or you might want to get out of a family business you run out of obligation, not passion. Use the 5 Second Rule, which I describe later in this chapter, to help you identify the family whys you could achieve if you scaled your business to make more money in less time.

Identifying Your "Community Whys"

Why does getting out of your business matter to your community? What impact would you like to make on other people's lives if you could scale your land business to give you more time and money than you ever thought possible? I call those, "community whys."

Sometimes, the impact we make on our communities is direct, such as funding parks, hosting charity events, or otherwise helping others. Other times, the impact we make is on the people we buy land from or the communities in which we invest. For example, one of my clients is an oral surgeon named Dr. Robert Demick. Dr. Demick was three months into coaching when he got a call from a seller who wanted to accept his offer—but there was a hitch. The property, which was a financial albatross on the seller, was co-owned by three siblings. His contact wanted to sell the property, but she hadn't spoken with her siblings in ages. Dr. Demick's offer became the motivation the buyer needed to rekindle her relationship with her siblings. The woman was in tears when she called Dr. Demick to report that the trio had reunited.

As Dr. Demick recalled to me: "Mark, you're not going to believe this, but this land deal was a life changer for this family because it forced them to have a discussion for the first time in years."

Another land seller had struggled to afford his medicine before being able to sell his property to a student of mine. The proceeds for the sale funded an entire year's worth of medication. "It's literally

changing the quality of my life by selling you this land," he told my student.

By buying and selling land, we are helping people invest in the only asset on earth that lasts forever. We help sellers get cash for land they are underutilizing. We are helping buyers take control of a generational asset they can use to develop family memories.

Our impact goes beyond the buyers and sellers in our transactions too. Our land businesses can help counties improve schools, roads, hospitals, and other resources. Our businesses can employ people around the world and provide them with an opportunity to fund a better quality of life. For example, one of my virtual assistants has been with me for four years. The commissions he earns for working hard and going the extra mile to serve our buyers and sellers put his pay on par with physicians in his country. He's used the money he's earned with me to establish economic independence and live a more intentional life. He gets joy out of his job. He's able to train fellow Filipinos to help us too. And when they hear stories about families reuniting or people able to afford medicine, that gets them more inspired too. They're no longer working for just a paycheck. They're working for something bigger than themselves.

A Big Mistake to Avoid with Your Whys

Have you ever wondered why some celebrities or professional athletes end up broke, or worse, shortly after their career ends? Some of them are likely taken advantage of or mismanage their money. Others might do so because of a lack of purpose. Throughout their lives, the only thing they wanted was to break out of poverty or middle-class living. They wanted to be rich and famous so they could buy their parents a home and set their families up for long-term success.

They spend their entire high school and college years pursuing that singular goal. By their mid-twenties, they sign their first big contract and have more than enough money to fulfill their wildest dreams. While that sounds like a good thing, for many athletes it leaves them without purpose. They spend their entire lives focused on a singular goal and don't know what to do with themselves when they achieve it. For that reason, it's important to set whys that scale with you as you scale your business. For example, if your personal why for scaling your business is to make $1 million, what do you do after you hit that goal? If your family why is to help your kids become the first generation to attend college, what do you do when they get accepted? Does your life or business no longer have purpose? Of course not. But you must be careful to identify whys that scale with you.

If your personal why is to make $1 million, ask yourself why that is important to you. Do you want to give back to your community? Do you want to free up time to improve your health or fitness? Those are personal goals that scale. You can always give back to your community in bigger and better ways and continue to improve your health or fitness. That reduces the risk of you attaining your goal and finding yourself struggling to find purpose. When you have no purpose, everything is a distraction.

Using the 5 Second Rule to Identify Your Whys

Many people get so stuck in their daily routines that they almost shut down the part of their brain that dreams because it's so frustrating to think about dreams when we don't believe we can achieve them. If that's you, try this. Recently, I heard about the "5 Second Rule" (which is different from gobbling up a gummy bear you've just dropped on the ground if it's been less than 5 seconds). Instead, this 5 Second Rule, popularized by the speaker Mel Robbins, urges people to act on their ideas before they can count down from 5 to 1.

“The 5 Second Rule is simple,” explains Robbins. “If you have an instinct to act on a goal, you must physically move within 5 seconds, or your brain will kill it. The moment you feel an instinct or a desire to act on a goal or a commitment, use the Rule. When you feel yourself hesitate before doing something that you know you should do, count 5-4-3-2-1-GO and move towards action. There is a window that exists between the moment you have an instinct to change and your mind killing it. It’s a 5-second window. And it exists for everyone. If you do not take action on your instinct to change, you will stay stagnant. You will not change. But if you do one simple thing, you can prevent your mind from working against you. You can start the momentum before the barrage of thoughts and excuses hit you at full force.”

Take no more than 5 seconds and identify your personal, family, and community whys.

Incorporate Your Whys into Everything You Do

Once you have your whys in place, incorporate them into every team call and training document. Remind yourself and your team why you do what you do. Make sure everyone feels like they’re working for a purpose bigger than themselves.

Make sure everyone knows you’re helping people invest in the only asset on earth that lasts forever. Your whys will fuel you and your team to go the extra mile for your land buyers and continue to scale your business.

Chapter 6

Using the Land Geek Process of Systems Building to Optimize Operations

When I first started Frontier Equity Properties, I was so busy working in my business, learning my business—doing, doing, doing—I felt like I was never able to step back and look at *what* I was doing. It took me years and years to take the time and be intentional before I was able to identify:

Okay, here is something I can automate.

Here is a process I can make.

Here is a system I can make.

I made my business much harder on me than I needed to. Through the Land Geek, my goal is to make building a land business much easier for you than it was for me.

I wasn't alone either. Even productivity experts often struggle to systematize their way out of their businesses. Take Dawn Marrs, for example. Dawn is an automation master, but even she was overwhelmed with her business for quite some time. "I was too busy serving clients, and building systems for other people, and building courses and that kind of thing, so I put it off," she shared with me. Finally, she went on a retreat with her mastermind, mapped out how she would systematize her business over the following year, and

then implemented it. Now, she enjoys all the benefits of business ownership that we all strive for—more time, more money, and more fulfillment—than when she was working full-time doing everything herself.

As she suggests, "The best thing you can do to take yourself out of overwhelm is to get a really solid plan and then execute it—either execute it yourself or hire someone else to execute it for you." It sounds simple. Create a plan and execute it. But not just any plan will work. You need a *solid* plan. Way too many people work systems that increase productivity but still require you to do way too much work. Continuing to work those systems and expecting to be able to stop working in your business is like building a house on a cracked foundation. Eventually, disaster will strike.

That's why I created the Land Geek Process of Systems Building. The Land Geek Process of Systems Building has helped many students optimize, delegate, and automate operations in their land businesses so they can work less, make more, and enjoy all the benefits true freedom offers. Here's how you can use it to optimize your land business too.

Start Simple

In the book *Systemantics: How Systems Really Work and Especially How They Fail*, author John Gall explains that a complex system that works is invariably found to have evolved from a simple system that worked, a concept now referred to as Gall's Law. You cannot design a complex system from scratch and expect it to work according to Gall's Law. You must start simple and add complexity over time.

The Land Geek Process of Systems Building asks you to look at system building in three simple parts:

- *Optimization:* Making the best or most effective use of a situation or resource.
- *Delegation:* Empowering other people to perform.
- *Automation:* Using software to implement tasks with unparalleled consistency.

Optimization simplifies your business by eliminating wasted steps in performing daily tasks in your land business. Automation through software reduces the tasks people need to perform. People add complexity. Using the right software to automate tasks that don't need human intervention promotes consistency and simplicity in your business. What's left after optimization and automation are CEO tasks and daily tasks that require intervention. As the CEO of your business, you should keep the CEO tasks and delegate the daily tasks to virtual assistants.

Here's how the Land Geek Process of Systems Building works to help you optimize, automate, and delegate effectively.

Optimize Your Way to Success

Learning to work with simple systems means optimizing what you're doing. The simplest way to do that is by following these steps:

1. Create a list of tasks you perform.
2. Identify tasks you can eliminate, delegate, and automate.
3. Stop doing all tasks you can eliminate.
4. Record yourself performing the rest of the tasks.
5. Hire a technical writer to write out the processes that cannot be eliminated.
6. Hire a virtual assistant to take over those tasks.

Going through these steps helps optimize your business in several ways. For example, creating a list of current tasks will likely open your eyes to what you're doing all day. Many of my students are

surprised by all the time they spend performing tasks that don't move the needle in their land businesses. Many find they can immediately eliminate several tasks.

Recording yourself performing tasks and hiring a technical writer to write out the process, often yields significant time savings. Between the recording and the written process, a virtual assistant will no longer need to ask you how to perform each piece of the task. They will have a video and written process they can follow. You can use Zoom or Loom video recording software to record your screen and microphone for free.

The more you record and write out, the more time savings you will achieve. For example, I recorded myself performing several tasks that only took me two minutes to perform. Some of those tasks I performed on a daily basis. While that doesn't sound like much savings, I was able to delegate those tasks to a virtual assistant and save two minutes a day for the rest of my life for each of those daily tasks. I've repeated that process with many two-, five-, ten-, and even thirty-minute tasks. Those time savings add up.

You can find freelance technical writers in many places. I've had good luck hiring freelance technical writers on Upwork.com, Freelancer.com, and HireMyMom.com. I suggest hiring three freelance writers for your first video and choosing the best one to handle the rest of the videos. Give each writer the same first video and instructions. Let them know there's potential for more projects. Make sure you give all three writers the same video so you can accurately compare their performance.

Once you have found your preferred technical writer, send that writer the rest of the videos. Then work to identify a virtual assistant to start taking over the tasks. I recommend using the same process. Hire three freelance virtual assistants on a project basis. Let them know there's potential for more consistent work. Give them each the

same task to complete. The one who does the best job will get ongoing work.

In an age where AI tools can generate text or even attempt to create procedures, you might wonder why hire a human technical writer? The answer lies in nuance, context, and deep understanding. A human technical writer doesn't just transcribe your process; they understand your business, your team's needs, and the 'why' behind each step. They can spot potential pitfalls, suggest improvements, and tailor the language to your company culture - things that current AI tools may miss.

As technology evolves, the tools we use to capture and document processes will change. Today, it might be a video; tomorrow, it could be a virtual reality walkthrough or an interactive AI session. What remains constant is the need to accurately capture your unique processes and make them accessible to your team. By focusing on the core principles - clear communication, accurate documentation, and human understanding - your SOPs will remain valuable, no matter what tools you use to create them.

Repeat steps four through six—recording tasks, having a writer document the process, and delegating to a virtual assistant—until all tasks that don't require your level of discretion are off your plate.

Automate with Care

Later in the book, I will share details about a few simple pieces of software that can automate a large part of your business operations. For now, I want you to focus more of your time on elimination and delegation. If you are already automating tasks, use the process in this chapter to train a virtual assistant to take over whatever you do to keep those automations running. However, don't introduce additional automations until you and your virtual assistants have

performed the tasks that will be automated a few times. A lot of business owners learn this lesson the hard way.

Take Elon Musk, for example. Assembly lines have been producing cars for decades. Naturally, robots could handle factory operations for Tesla, right? Not so fast. When Musk was trying to keep up with the demand for the highly popular Tesla Model 3 electric car, he decided to build a complex assembly line using robots to keep up with demand.

Theoretically, the robots should have outperformed the humans. They could work twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week, and didn't need bathroom breaks. But Musk found himself losing $100 million a week. It was so ugly that the show *60 Minutes* covered the disaster. The automated assembly process was way too slow and ended up on the brink of catastrophe.

Facing public embarrassment, Musk decided to give humans a shot, so he created a third assembly line completely staffed by humans. Almost immediately, production improved. As Musk described it, "Excessive automation at Tesla was a mistake. To be precise, my mistake. Humans are underrated. People are way better at dealing with unexpected circumstances than robots." Overall, Tesla's output increased by 50 percent with humans at the helm while Tesla worked out the kinks in its systems and processes.

The same is true in the land business. First, we optimize. Then we delegate. And then we automate after we and our team learn the processes and work out the kinks. Follow that order and you will create a much simpler and more effective business.

The Simplicity Test

To find out if your new process is simple enough to set you up for success, test it on other people. With my business, I

recruited my daughter, who was twelve at the time. I gave her every process I was trying to implement and asked her whether she understood it. If she did, we tested it out in action. If not, I made it simpler.

A perfect example of a simple system is those airline safety cards in the seatback pocket of planes. They are so simple and precise, with the exact pictures and words for what to do in case of an emergency. That's important too; imagine how hard it would be to exit an airplane safely if someone handed you a two-hundred-page binder of diagrams, charts, explanations, and data when something goes wrong midair.

Delegate or Die

Once you know your process intimately and it passes the simplicity test, you're ready to delegate. You might not *feel* ready to delegate—delegating can be one of the hardest things we do as entrepreneurs—but you *are*. And if you ever want to achieve the euphoria of complete financial and time freedom, you must delegate.

Continue creating lists of tasks you can delegate and might automate. Work on this list every day. Keep it close to you. You'll be surprised by how many new opportunities you will find for delegation or automation weeks or even months after you created your initial list, as you experience the benefits of optimizing, recording, and delegating.

Once you've found your writer and virtual assistant, force yourself to let go of projects. Start by delegating the tasks you hate most. Perhaps you hate list scrubbing, managing note portfolios, or creating contracts. Many of my students delegate those tasks first. Next, delegate tasks you're neutral about. That might include due

diligence or posting ads. Finally, delegate tasks you enjoy doing but can delegate to someone else at a much lower cost. The vast majority of our tasks can be performed by people making between $2 and $15 per hour.

Adding Automation to Save Even More Time

Once you've evaluated your tasks and started delegating many of them to humans, you're ready to start thinking about automation. By far, the best way to automate is through software. Like Musk's robots, our software doesn't complain or ask for a raise. It performs consistently and doesn't get distracted. It simply works. The only thing you need to be sure of is that you and your team understand how the tasks you automate work when performed manually. That will empower you to troubleshoot if something goes wrong.

Here are some examples of perfect candidates for automation at this stage of scaling out of your business:

- Your mailings: You can automate inserting the name, address, and legal description of the property, and only have to adjust the offer price.
- Your contracts: You can automate the creation of the promissory note, purchase and sale agreement, and land sale contract, and only have to change your buyer's name, address, and pricing or payment terms.

What to Keep

After going through this process, you should not have much left to do. You've identified *all* the tasks you do. You've eliminated tasks that don't need to be done. You've created videos, written systems, and delegated many day-to-day tasks to virtual assistants. And you've started using software to automate many of those tasks.

In my business, the only tasks I keep on my plate are evaluating the key performance metrics, supervising my acquisition manager, and performing CEO duties. In fact, I now perform all of my CEO duties during one weekly thirty-minute meeting with my acquisition manager. He manages the rest of the business, supervising the other virtual assistants and ensuring the business is running smoothly.

During those weekly calls, I ask my acquisition manager questions about business performance. Here are some of the questions I ask so I can understand the health of the business:

- How many offers went out this week?
- How many deals are pending?
- How many deals did we buy?
- How many deals are we marketing?
- Where are we marketing?
- Which ads are more effective and which platforms are more effective?
- How many deals did we close?
- How can I make your life easier?
- What am I not doing that I can do?

Because I use software to automate mailings, note collection, and many other tasks, I can confirm many of the numbers without speaking with my acquisition manager. Talking with him helps me confirm those numbers and get more context to the performance.

With our remaining time, I'll suggest adjustments I think can benefit our business, such as new places to advertise properties. I know that the biggest killer of business is complacency. So, even if everything is working, I put on my strategy hat and try to stay ahead of the game. I also help him address any issues he needs help with.

> “It’s good to learn from your mistakes. It’s better to learn from other people’s mistakes.”—Warren Buffett

Your Challenge

Putting systems in place is really that simple. But you need to take action. That’s why I want you to start using the Land Geek Process of Systems Building today. Don’t wait to finish the book. Once you’re done reading for today, start identifying what you can eliminate, delegate, and automate. Then pick at least one task to delegate and hire three technical writers. Don’t wait for perfection. Just start. You can improve and get more comfortable delegating as you go. For now, just keep it simple.

With systems in place, you’re ready to find the right people and software to run your business. I’ll walk you through exactly how to do that next.

Part 3

Attracting, Hiring, and Delegating to Independent Contractors to Implement Your Systems

Chapter 7

How to Choose What to Delegate First

Two of the richest men in modern history weren't Land Geeks—they were steel and oil guys—but they sure knew how to delegate their way to success.

When John D. Rockefeller was talking to a young employee, he famously said: "Has anyone given you the law of these offices? No? It is this: nobody does anything if he can get anybody else to do it . . . As soon as you can, get someone whom you can rely on, train them in the work, sit down, cock up your heels, and think out some way for the Standard Oil Company to make some money."

Andrew Carnegie, meanwhile, laughed at the notion of arriving at work at 7:00 a.m. and being the last one to leave in the evening. "You must be a lazy man," he told Pennsylvania businessman A. B. Farquhar, "if it takes you ten hours to do a day's work. What I do is to get good men, and I never give them orders. My directions seldom go beyond suggestions. Here in the morning, I get reports from them. Within an hour I have disposed of everything, sent out all of my suggestions, the day's work is done, and I am ready to go out and enjoy myself."

Sitting down, kicking up our heels, and enjoying ourselves? Sounds good to me! That's why this chapter is all about how to choose what to delegate first—because delegation provides clarity. And clarity in

your business could be the difference between freedom of time or constant misery.

Stabilize, Optimize, Expand

Frank Kern, an automation marketing expert, helps keep business owners on track with the "stabilize, optimize, expand" model. "An entrepreneur will hustle, and they'll be successful, and they'll start making money; and then they go try to do something else credible with another offer," explains Kern on the *Marketing Bites* podcast, "and they go straight into trying to expand the business when in reality the business isn't even stable yet."

Once again, it comes down to having a stable foundation. This helps us begin the work of implementing our systems.

Swim Lanes

If you've ever been a lap swimmer, you know the feeling of having an entire lane to yourself. At peak times, when the Masters group is practicing the butterfly, or the high school team is thrashing about, it's pretty chaotic. You're missing your rhythm, and you might even find yourself doing the completely wrong kind of stroke.

This is why I love the idea of "swim lanes" so much. It's part of a system that also includes process maps, diagrams, flow charts, and more—a system proven to work and help you live like John D. Rockefeller and Andrew Carnegie.

Here's how it works.

1. Draw a swimming pool. At the beginning of the pool, write "looking for land to buy." At the end, write "managing notes and transferring deeds once the property is paid off."

2. Draw swim lanes for each person in your business. At the beginning, there is one swim lane. The same person does everything from beginning to end. As you add more people, they get their own lane.
3. Use the system-building technique to create systems for each task that needs to be done between looking for land and sending the deed.
4. Delegate and outsource to people—put those tasks at the right place in the swimming pool in terms of the person doing it and the place in the timeline.
5. Software is a "person" in this case—you can automate tasks out of people's swim lanes and into a lane for each piece of software you invest in.
6. Eventually, your swim lane should be pretty empty, leaving only your CEO activities.

I'll be the first to admit that the swim lanes concept takes a little while to master. In simplest terms, the concept of swim lanes in business views your land business as a swimming pool. Floating all around the swimming pool are all the tasks that need to be done for your business to run well. When you are doing all the work yourself, your swimming pool has no lanes at all. It's just one big pool. In order for all tasks to get done, you need to zigzag all around the pool performing the tasks.

As you bring other people into your business, your pool starts to get more organized. You install lane markers that keep tasks within defined lanes. Everyone knows what tasks they need to perform. You perform the tasks in your lane, and someone else performs the tasks in theirs. All of the tasks in the pool get done much more efficiently. As you add more people (and software), you install more lane markers to create more swim lanes and divide the tasks among more people and software to create more efficiency.

Unlike other systems, the big benefit of swim lanes is the way it helps organize and visualize all the tasks that need to be performed.

It gives you a thirty-thousand-foot view of your business tasks and how they are performed at all times.

Swim Lanes in Action

One of my students, Jeff Dettmer of AOK Land in Ohio, the master of swim lanes, recently shared his experience creating swim lanes for his business with me:

> *The concept of swim lanes was a challenge for me to really grasp, initially. Basically, you can't do everything yourself. At the beginning, you are. You're doing everything. That's important. You need to learn the ins and outs of running a land business. But if you want to grow your business and live a lifestyle you love, you can't do everything forever.*
>
> *If all of the individual tasks of the business are in your lane, those tasks are on your to-do list for every day or every week. Let's say you have one hundred items. That's a lot of work to have to do consistently. It can take you away from doing high-impact tasks to grow your business.*
>
> *If we draw a pool with multiple lanes, however, we can start to identify tasks that can be performed by other people or by software. Perhaps you find maybe half a dozen of the most mundane tasks in your lane can be performed by a piece of software. Move those tasks you're performing from your lane to a lane designated as tasks that are automated by software. Now your lane has fewer tasks, and your to-do list has shrunk a little bit. You still have a bunch of tasks in your lane but fewer.*
>
> *As you scan the tasks in your lane, you can start to identify additional items to outsource to a virtual assistant or automate using other pieces of software. As you do, tasks in your swim lanes move to other lanes. Eventually, the only tasks you need to*

perform are the CEO tasks or tasks you choose to do because you love them so much.

The magic of swim lanes is how they illustrate what needs to happen in your business. That visualization is powerful. From your team's perspective, everyone knows each other's responsibilities. Nothing can slip through the cracks because people assumed someone else was responsible for performing a task. And from your perspective, seeing dozens of tasks in your lane along with the CEO-level tasks really shines a light on how you are using your time.

"It was a bit frustrating at the beginning because virtually everything was in my lane," says Jeff. "But then I just started chipping away at it. I've had issues. I think I'm on my third intake virtual assistant right now. I've spent good money on the wrong software and discovered real problems. So that's been a challenge and also a learning experience. And now, I'm working a lot less in the land business; I don't have to do what I call the big rocks in the jar. The properties are coming in, and it's working out well."

Creating swim lanes and then looking for opportunities to shift tasks from his lane to automation or other people's lanes changed Jeff's business. It can do the same for you too. I've included a blank swim lanes graphic for you to get started. Download your copy at TheLandGeek.com/DirtRich2 and start listing the tasks performed in your business in the appropriate lanes. Be sure to use pencil because we're going to help you move a lot of those tasks out of your lane throughout the rest of the book.

Delegate First What You Hate the Most

What does your swim lanes graphic look like? Does it look like Jeff's did when he first got started, with virtually everything in your lane? Did you run out of room in your lane and have to start over, writing smaller to fit everything in? If you did, don't worry. You're not alone.

And you have plenty of room for improvement. But where should you start? Simple. Start by first delegating what you hate doing the most. It's literally that simple. Here are some common examples from the Land Geek community.

Like we talked about when choosing what to systematize first, one of the tasks most land investors hate doing the most in the beginning is acquiring and scrubbing lists. So, we go to a site like Upwork.com and find a virtual assistant to acquire and scrub lists for us based on the videos and written processes we created using the Land Geek Process of Systems Building.

For example, with a video, checklist, and list of properties, your list scrubbing task becomes a very simple, one-off task to delegate. You can assign the task to someone before you go to bed and wake up to a very nice list you can use to start mailing. Of course, my team and students automate our mailings, so we just upload the list and start sending out mailers on autopilot. If you're not there yet, that's ok. You'll have a list that has been scrubbed to your specifications by the time you brew your morning coffee. And, like I mentioned above, you can work on delegating offer creation and mailing next.

When list acquisition and scrubbing, offer creation, and mailing are delegated, the next piece of the process most land investors delegate is talking on the phone with potential sellers. I've been on the phone for hours at a time with potential sellers hearing stories about when they bought the land, how they bought the land. Maybe it's the dashed dream of never being able to build on the land; how they misread the future.

What if you got an intake manager to listen to those stories? We'll talk about intake managers and how it works to delegate seller calls to them more in depth in the next chapter. List acquisition, list scrubbing, offer creation, mailing, and talking on the phone with potential sellers takes a little more training. Thus, generally speaking, I suggest starting by having a U.S.-based virtual assistant

join your calls and eventually have them lead the calls with you and then take over the calls when they're ready. I also suggest compensating them based on performance. Share cost savings with them to motivate them to get the best prices for the properties. This puts them in complete alignment with you and your business.

For example, I let them know that due diligence often reveals things that make us need to renegotiate our offer. I then offer to pay them for an extra hour of work for every hundred dollars they negotiate a price down on a deal. We typically pay an intake manager $15 to $20 an hour. So, they really pay for themselves quickly. And not having to talk to sellers is a big time-saver that allows us to focus on bigger-picture parts of our business.

Even if you enjoy talking to sellers, a CEO is much better suited for higher-level tasks, which we will talk about later. Plus, the more you delegate, the more of your *time* becomes freed up to do whatever you want. Life becomes so much better. You're able to spend more time working *on* your business, optimizing processes, building a better team, researching more counties, and selling through your inventory. You can be more impactful in the business by growing sales, increasing volume, and looking for even more sources of cash to buy even more properties. And you can spend more time with your family, working on a fitness plan, taking up a new hobby, or sailing around the world—it's up to you (and any of those things are better and more fulfilling than talking with sellers all day . . .).

Another task true CEOs should not be doing for long is writing ads. While ads are important, you do not need to be writing them yourself. You can find English-speaking ad writers on many websites like Upwork.com and Fiverr.com for between $5 and $10 an hour. And you can easily set them up for success by creating a simple database of top headlines and ad copy you have crafted yourself. You're the CEO. There's no reason for you to spend the time doing the actual labor of copying and pasting, putting these ads out on sites like Facebook, Craigslist, and Zillow—the marketing platform du

jour as I write this, or whatever marketplace is hot when you're placing your ads. That's not a great use of your time when you can outsource it for just a few dollars.

What Life is Like After Delegating Just a Handful of Tasks You Hate

How freeing would it be if you no longer had to do the work you hated in your land business?

Imagine what your land business would look like if, for a few hundred bucks a month, all of these activities could be done well, on autopilot, by someone else:

- Acquiring lists
- Scrubbing lists
- Creating offer letters
- Mailing offers
- Screening calls from potential land sellers
- Performing due diligence
- Writing ad copy to sell your property
- Placing ads

What would that free you up to do? In your business, you could

- Spend the time you save researching additional counties to target to put more volume through your automated system.
- Evaluate, tweak, and test alternative ad copy to consistently improve ad performance.
- Work on raising capital to be able to buy even more land.
- Focus on improving systems to get even more efficient.

The list goes on. You could do any number of things a CEO should be doing.

What about in your personal life? You could use some of that time saved to

- Get back to the gym.
- Pick up (or rekindle) an old hobby.
- Spend more time with your kids.
- Volunteer to support causes you care about.
- Help your aging parents.
- Take more vacations.
- Write that book you've had stuck inside your head for years.
- Really, do whatever else you want.

You can have all of that, and more, simply by delegating a handful of tasks you hate that other people can do just as well for a fraction of what your time is worth. In fact, as you'll learn over the rest of the book, you can delegate all eight of the tasks listed above without building a big team. One or two virtual assistants and a specialized due diligence service provider can easily do all those tasks for you.

So, what does it feel like to get the weight of all of the tasks you hate off your shoulders? It's liberating, like there's no gravity anymore. You feel like you're floating through life doing more of what you love and less of what you hate because of your land business. You start seeing more opportunities all over the place and have the time, money, and energy to pursue them.

> "We have an executive VA, who we found on Upwork, and we just kind of clicked with her. She went from reporting to becoming our bookkeeper. It's a lot; I sold a lot of property last year and our books are a disaster. So, she's cleaning all that up. I told her I wanted her to ultimately start taking over the business piece by piece—going back to being our executive VA—and then really start getting it done. She is *so* stoked because she's been doing our books; she knows how much we make.

> Soon, she'll do the hiring and start taking over every little bit of this business."—Matt Forbes, HarborTrustInc.com

The first eight tasks listed above are the least exciting, most time-consuming, safest, and easiest things to delegate. Thus, if you don't know where to start, start with those. But if there are other tasks you hate more, it's perfectly fine to start in a different order, as long as you use the Land Geek Process of Systems Building to delegate them well. That will set your virtual assistant up for success while lifting the heavy weight of tasks you hate from your shoulders.

Your Challenge

You have systems in place. You have your swim lanes identified. And you likely have way too many tasks in your lane and not enough in other lanes.

Before moving on to the next chapter, "The Simple Solution for Automating Deal Flow to 10x Your Inventory," choose at least one task from your swim lane that you hate to do. Use the Land Geek Process of Systems Building to create a system you can use to delegate that task. Then, just like at the end of the last chapter, hire a virtual assistant to start performing that task.

Again, don't wait for perfection. Just start. You can improve and get more comfortable delegating as you go. For now, just keep it simple and delegate at least one task you hate.

Chapter 8

The Simple Solution for Automating Deal Flow to 10x Your Inventory

At first, Matt Forbes was wary of the land business—he was reluctant to risk his money. But when he began listening to my podcasts and learning of this basically risk-free opportunity, he was ready to dig in. "Once I understood the model, I thought, 'This is a slam dunk,'" recalls Forbes, who now runs HarborTrustInc.com. He soon found himself handling all the calls, though, and he and his wife were spending more time than he initially imagined on the business.

Then Matt heard about an intake manager he could pay just $10 to $15 an hour to automate deals and increase inventory. "That changed everything because if you don't have property to sell, you've got nothing—you've got a hobby, and it's not a very good hobby either," he says. "Getting our intake guy right away made me feel like we got super lucky."

Did Matt *really* get super lucky? Or does Matt just *feel* super lucky? You tell me. Matt learned that an intake manager could help automate deal flow and get more properties into inventory without having to be on the phone with sellers all day. He knew having more properties in inventory meant he could sell more properties. And he knew that inventory could grow profits exponentially while working *less* in his business.

So, what did he do? He hired an intake manager. That's not luck. That's smart. That's the Land Geek way.

Finding his ideal intake manager right away certainly involves some level of luck. Some people test out a few before finding the right fit. So maybe immediately finding the right intake manager was somewhat lucky. But hiring an intake manager and putting them in a position to succeed using the Land Geek Process of Systems Building was not luck. It's what good CEOs like Matt do.

> "Colors are more vibrant. Food tastes better. Life is so much better the minute you stop talking to sellers."—Mark Podolsky, The Land Geek

How to Find an Intake Manager

So how do you begin the process of adding the right intake manager? You have already taken the first step when you used the Land Geek Process of Systems Building to systematize and optimize your operations. Having documented systems will set up your intake manager for success. This is important. The Land Geek coach Scott Todd describes his intake manager as the one position he can't live without in his business. "But," he warns, "they need to understand how the process works. One of the mistakes people often make when they're outsourcing anything is thinking, 'I can just give the keys to somebody and they're going to drive the car, and they've got it.'" That's why it's so important to use the Land Geek Process of Systems Building to create systems that help set them up for success.

With that in place, actually finding intake manager candidates isn't that difficult. For example, you can find them from word of mouth from land investors whose intake managers have more capacity. The

Land Geek community is a great place for this. You can also use freelancer sites. You can even use virtual assistant placement services where you hire a company to vet candidates and present you with candidates. These sites and services change all the time, so visit TheLandGeek.com/DirtRich2 for an up-to-date list of my favorite places to find virtual assistants.

In addition, you can hire an intake manager through a land-focused virtual assistant service, such as LandVA4U, which was created by the Land Geek students Pete Schmitt and Anthony Napodano. They train college-educated virtual assistants on acquisitions, due diligence, intake, marketing, sales and even bookkeeping. As a member of the Land Geek community, you can get a discount on their services by visiting https://www.landva4u.com/thelandgeek

"It can seem overwhelming," says Erik Peterson of Landopia.com. "The reality is, it's not that hard to hire this person," he says. "Focus more on communication, negotiation, and organization skills, along with the ability to speak English well, than whether they have specific experience. Your systems can help them with the tasks. As they gain experience, they'll move up in skill level and be able to perform more tasks for you. But finding someone who naturally communicates well, is well organized, and can handle negotiations is important."

Erik's intake manager spends about five or six hours per week on his business, but the time it saves him is far greater. "It takes all those administrative tasks off my mind," he says. "I don't ever have to think about it—I know my intake manager has it under control and I can rely on that person to take care of it."

What an Intake Manager Can Do

As the name suggests, the primary role of your intake manager will be to manage the process of acquiring properties, including:

- Acquiring and scrubbing lists
- Creating and sending offer letters
- Communicating with sellers
- Managing the due diligence process
- Negotiating offers with sellers based on due diligence results
- Handling the closing process, such as preparing deeds, preparing and managing sales documents, and recording documents

To the extent you have other virtual assistants working with you, such as due diligence specialists, your intake manager will supervise them as well.

That means moving all of those tasks to someone else's swim lane with one hire.

How does this work in the real world? How does it impact your life? Here's how Matt Forbes describes working with his intake manager, who works ten hours a month to streamline his business.

> *I use Voxer [messaging software] to communicate with my intake manager, Eric. If he has questions, he messages me, and I reply. It works very smoothly.*
>
> *Eric fields emails, voice mails, and other messages that come in about property. He even helps finalize due diligence, checking back taxes and briefing me with information he finds. He also runs title through my title guy before we close on a deal.*
>
> *When he's done—less than twenty-four hours later—he messages me to tell me if we're good to go. If we are, we move forward. If not, we pass. With Eric vetting properties, my life has become so much easier. He's now better than me at it. It's a slam dunk.*

And here's how Tate Litchfield describes the impact on his life of working with an intake manager:

> *You're trying to buy a really good property and have been playing phone tag with somebody for weeks. They finally call you back, and it happens to be on a Saturday when you're at lunch with your wife, forcing you to say, "Hey honey, I really love you, but I got this guy. He's finally calling me back. I really need to take this call because it's going to make me a lot of money." And your wife says okay. Then thirty minutes later you come back to the table feeling on cloud nine because you just agreed to buy a property that you're going to make a ton of money on, but your wife is upset.*
>
> *For me, yes, it multiplies the time I save easily by 2x or 3x, but it also prevents me from having those disruptions that take me away from the time with the family or time that I'm spending on sales or high-level work within the business. I could never not have an intake manager.*

In other words, while the tasks they perform are valuable, an intake manager does *much more* than simply perform a list of tasks. They free up your time. They help you avoid disruptions in your daily life. They can even keep you from fighting with your spouse. Talk about high-value impact!

Your Intake Manager: The Key to 10x Your Inventory

Like many land investors, Land Geek student Mimi Schmidt was handling intake (and most other tasks) herself when she got started. Even doing everything herself, she was able to quit her job at U.S. Customs and Border Protection to become a full-time land investor. After freeing herself from her day job, she took a fresh look at her land business and got more involved in the Land Geek community. In doing so, she saw opportunity after opportunity to streamline her

business and assume a real CEO role. One of the first pieces of advice she received was to delegate talking with sellers and other administrative tasks to an intake manager so she could become a true CEO of her business. The idea of becoming a true CEO excited Mimi, so she did it.

Almost immediately, Mimi began to experience the joy that comes after delegating administrative tasks—and communicating with sellers—to an intake manager. As she describes it now, she was "shocked" at how easy her life became after she hired her intake manager. "She's basically running half my business now," says Mimi. "The phone calls come in an automated fashion, and my intake manager has a pricing matrix she can use to negotiate with sellers. She knows exactly what she can buy and sell properties for." Mimi only sees the properties she buys in her business when the copywriter virtual assistants create content for the sales listing. "And it should be that way," Mimi says.

Today, Mimi's intake manager only contacts her with problems the CEO of the company needs to be involved in solving. Among the tasks Mimi's intake manager handles are:

- Handling accepted offers by fax, email, phone, and voicemail
- Communicating with prospective sellers
- Pushing properties to due diligence
- Setting up closings
- Uploading paperwork to software systems for signature
- Managing Mimi's other virtual assistants

> "I don't know what I'd do without my intake manager."—Mimi Schmidt

Onboarding and Working with Your Intake Manager

With all the incredible things that happen in your business and personal life with an intake manager on board, some people tend to delegate everything they have systematized to their intake manager on their first day. After all, your systems make it much easier for someone to move all of those tasks to their swim lanes. And after investing so much time, effort, and money systematizing and hiring, it's natural to want to get a return on your investment as fast as possible.

For best results, however, avoid putting too much on your intake manager's plate right away. Test them with one task at a time and grow from there. This is a lesson many of us learned the hard way. As Tate Litchfield describes it:

> *Just think about when you learned how to drive a car; you didn't just jump on the interstate. You learned how to back up and pull forward; you learned how to turn the wheel to go right, turn left. And you learned different things for a stick shift. Over the course of six months to a year of practicing with your learner's permit, you learned as much as you needed to be able to drive on your own.*
>
> *Take that same approach to teaching someone how to do the work of an intake manager. Do the work together for a while. Work with them just like you would teach someone how to drive. That will set them up for success. You've got to be committed to their training. That means hitting some bumps in the road and running into some resistance from people learning the process and getting through it all together.*
>
> *When you work together for some time, tasks will click one at a time and you will be able to add more and more tasks. Each time you do, you've relieved yourself of one more task from your swim lane. And when you're done, you will have relieved yourself*

from one of the biggest pain points of this business—taking forty-minute calls from sellers—and a whole lot more.

Your Challenge

Are you ready to 10x your inventory while *working less*? You're only an intake manager away. Take the plunge. Join the fun. Hire and start training your intake manager. If you need help, visit TheLandGeek.com/DirtRich2 to get my latest recommendations about sites and services to find candidates. The sooner you start, the sooner they will be able to 10x your inventory while taking over the most time- and energy-sucking parts of your land business.

Chapter 9

Outsourcing Your Due Diligence with Virtually No Risk

If there's one area of land investing that causes the most undue anxiety when it comes to outsourcing, it's due diligence. Land investors fear the worst. That's natural, of course. Investors fear being stuck with properties they can never sell. They worry about undertaking unlimited liability risk.

I experienced similar feelings when I first started outsourcing. I didn't want to be stuck with a property or lose all my profits to an unexpected liability. But I also didn't want to be stuck having to perform due diligence my whole life either. I wanted to experience the freedom and joy of being able to work when I wanted, where I wanted, and with whom I wanted. I could never do that if I were stuck performing due diligence on every property I purchased. So, I moved forward carefully. In doing so, I learned that although my fears weren't unreasonable, they *were* unfounded. My fears were *much* bigger than the reality when it came to outsourcing due diligence.

But if you're committed to scaling out of your land business, you *must* get performing due diligence out of your swim lane. Otherwise, you'll never experience the time, location, and financial freedom you deserve as a business owner. But you must outsource it the right way. The first part of outsourcing due diligence is to understand why the risk and liability fears are bigger than the reality. That will put

you in the right frame of mind to outsource due diligence and move on to the second part, actually outsourcing due diligence.

Over the rest of this chapter, I'll walk you through these two parts. Next, I'll share the truth about risk when it comes to outsourcing due diligence. After that, I'll walk you through exactly how to outsource due diligence with virtually no risk. By the end of the chapter, you'll be ready to experience one of the greatest experiences in the land business—never again having to do due diligence yourself.

The Truth about Risk and Liability When Outsourcing Due Diligence

Before we get into the details about how to outsource due diligence, let's address the elephants in the room: risk and liability.

Can you *really* get stuck with unsellable property? Do you *really* expose yourself to unlimited and unexpected liability if you outsource due diligence?

You can probably guess by the title of this chapter that, when done the right way, two things are true with due diligence. First, while it's theoretically possible to get stuck with a property, it doesn't happen in practice. Second, the nature of our business limits our risk.

Here's more about each of those concerns.

Worry: If You Outsource Due Diligence, You Will Get Stuck with Unsellable Properties

Truth: While Theoretically Possible, It Doesn't Happen in Practice

I've bought and sold more than six thousand properties as of the time of this writing. In doing so, I've outsourced due diligence

thousands of times. I've been doing this for well over two decades. I bought and sold land before the Great Recession of 2008, when money was abundant and investing in property and land was at a fever pitch.

I bought and sold land throughout the downturn of the economy into the Great Recession. I bought and sold land throughout the Great Recession, when capital markets froze and the real estate market cratered. I did it as the economy rebounded and even throughout the recession caused by the COVID-19 pandemic.

How many times did I get stuck with an unsellable property? Zero. I have *never* been stuck with a property. Not once.

How many times have I lost money on a property? Zero. I have *never* lost money on a property. Not once.

After buying and selling more than six thousand properties, I've yet to come across a problem I haven't been able to solve. How could that be possible? Most importantly, I stick to the Land Geek system of buying properties. The Land Geek system is designed to help me make 300 percent to 1,000 percent or more on a property. That means there's plenty of wiggle room if I need to offload a property for less than the 300 percent to 1,000 percent the model suggests. If I pay $1,000 for a property that I believe would sell for $5,000 on the open market, I could cut that price in half and still more than double my money. Sticking to the system gives me flexibility if I overlook something in due diligence that impacts my sales price. Frankly, we pay so little for the properties that we can sell them at a steep discount and still make money. My discipline of sticking with that system protects me from buying properties I can't sell for a profit.

The value of the system in limiting downside risk was on full display several years ago when a buddy and I visited some of the ugliest property I had ever seen. There were one hundred adjacent

properties in New Mexico, but it looked like a nuclear reactor to me. When I saw the land, I immediately knew I wanted nothing to do with it. My buddy, however, got excited. He turned to me and offered, "Hey, look, why don't we just split this? You buy fifty and I'll buy fifty."

I was shocked. There was *no way* I was getting stuck with that land, and I let him know it. "Are you kidding me? There's no way I'm buying this property. It's so ugly. If you sell the properties, two things are going to happen. You'll either get refund requests or lawsuits."

These properties were *ugly.* I wouldn't have wanted to camp out there for a night, let alone own the property outright. I couldn't imagine anyone wanting to buy a single parcel there, and he was asking me to commit to buying fifty of them?! No way.

Undeterred, he told me, "For fifty bucks, I'm sure I can sell them for at least $100."

I wouldn't have taken the land if *they paid me* $100. But he wrote the check and owned one hundred parcels of land for $5,000 total.

Weeks went by and I didn't really think too much about that land. And then it happened. My buddy emailed me to celebrate his first sale. The sale price? One thousand dollars.

It wasn't that I was surprised that he could sell it. Like I told him, he might be able to sell the land, but he'd end up with either a refund request or a lawsuit.

So, I replied to his email with one word: "refund."

Days later, another email, and another $1,000.

Again, I replied with one word: lawsuit.

For 100 of the next 180 days, he sent me an email celebrating a new $1,000 sale.

Eventually, I ate my crow and learned my lesson.

There's a pig for every barn, a buyer for every property.

My friend knew that, and he turned $5,000 into $100,000 in six months.

I hadn't learned that lesson yet, so I declined his offer to split the deal, costing me a cool $47,500 in profits.

Whenever someone asks me about getting stuck with property, I think of the time my buddy turned what appeared to be one hundred little pieces of nuclear reactor fallout into a cool $95,000 in profits in six months.

Worry: If You Outsource Due Diligence, You Will Expose Yourself to High Risk

Truth: Because of the Nature of the Land We Buy, Our Risk Exposure Is Extremely Limited

With no termites, tenants, or toilets to worry about, our due diligence concerns are limited. We don't have to worry about cracked foundations, moldy basements, or leaky roofs. We buy land. Raw land. And we buy most of it for less than $5,000. Thus, the nature of our risk is capped pretty low. In fact, the price we pay for most land is so low that it doesn't even make sense to use a title company most of the time. It's not worth the investment. We can get a virtual assistant to gather all the information we need from other places.

Thus, for properties less than $5,000 (with some exceptions), I generally outsource due diligence to my virtual assistant and have never had a problem. For land we buy for $5,000 or more, I use an American title company.

Of course, that's what I do and what many of my students do. Others prefer to use a title company for everything, which is fine. I'm not here to give legal advice, but I am using my experience and practice to demonstrate how low the risk is.

The big exception to the risk issue in my experience would be if you buy a property that's listed as a Superfund site, which means it's considered contaminated due to hazardous waste being dumped on the property. There's nothing you can't remedy in due diligence except for when you buy a property that's a Superfund site. To limit this risk, we suggest buying in areas where there are no Superfund sites, such as the southwest and northeast parts of Florida. If you want to go into places such as New Jersey, Pennsylvania, New York, Ohio, and Michigan—any manufacturing areas, really—you will want to include confirming at EPA.gov that you're not buying in a Superfund site.

In the end, our risk is capped, and it's capped very low. If we conduct due diligence the right way, it remains low, even when outsourced. Follow the Land Geek way of outsourcing due diligence and you can outsource confidently with virtually no added risk compared to conducting due diligence yourself.

How to Outsource Due Diligence the Land Geek Way

Once upon a time, I did due diligence myself. I was worried about outsourcing such an essential but time-sucking task. But, like I outlined in my last book, *Dirt Rich*, due diligence is really all about answering two questions after getting an accepted offer:

- Is this really the best amount to pay for the property?
- Is this truly a good deal?

When I finally realized due diligence shouldn't sit in my swim lane, I followed the Land Geek Process of Systems Building to document my

process and analyze which parts of the process required my personal attention.

If you remember from chapter 6, the Land Geek Process of Systems Building asks you to take six steps:

1. Create a list of tasks you perform.
2. Identify tasks you can eliminate, delegate, and automate.
3. Stop doing all tasks you can eliminate.
4. Record yourself performing the rest of the tasks.
5. Hire a technical writer to write out the processes that cannot be eliminated.
6. Hire a virtual assistant to take over those tasks.

When I applied that to due diligence, I quickly realized that the vast majority of the steps could easily and quickly be delegated. The only step that needed more of a transition period was the substantive evaluation of the due diligence materials. I needed to get confident that whomever I delegated that to would know what to look for, make decisions like I would, and come to me when they were unsure.

Here's what it looked like when I applied the Land Geek Process of Systems Building to outsourcing due diligence.

1. Create a List of Tasks You Perform

In this case, my first step involved creating a list of each of the tasks I performed to conduct due diligence.

In the big picture, I wrote down the information I looked for with each piece of land that I purchased:

- A copy of the deed

- The name of the person on the deed (to match the seller information)
- A clean title, free from liens or claims against the owner
- GPS coordinates
- A legal description of the property
- The property address (if available)
- A plat map (if available)
- A survey map (if available)
- Zoning information (including any restrictions, the water table, and what's allowed on the property, such as RVs, mobile homes, hunting, or camping)

In addition, I always took a good, hard *virtual* look at each property to assess the following:

- The access. (Is a property easy to get to?)
- The terrain. (Is it flat, hilly, rocky?)
- The soil. (Is it clay, sand, or silt?)
- The environment. (Is it desert, deciduous, mountainous?)
- What covers the land? (Is it sawgrass, trees, dry lakebed?)

If you're wondering, my goal for collecting all this information is to anticipate and be able to answer questions when buyers call. For low-priced property, it's not the end of the world if you don't have all the information, but it makes for an easier deal to have as much information as you can when a buyer calls, so I collected as much as I could. Of course, not all of this information is available for many properties, but this was my list of what I wanted to collect.

Next, it was time to document the actual steps I took to collect this information. At the time, I got the vast majority of information from very few sources:

- The county assessor's office
- The county planning and zoning department

- Websites, including Datatree.com/thelandgeek (for a discount), What3words.com, Earth.Google.com, ExpertGPS.com, and WeGoLook.com

When buying a property for $5,000 or more, I'd use a professional title company and get title insurance. But for virtually all properties under $5,000, those are the steps I took. Just those steps made me *very* efficient at due diligence and gave me all the information I needed to evaluate a property. I was ready to move on.

2. Identify Tasks You Can Eliminate, Delegate, and Automate

After listing the tasks I performed, I went through the list to identify tasks I could eliminate, delegate, and automate. With my due diligence, no tasks came to mind that could be eliminated or automated. My process was efficient, and the information I collected all helped me buy properties with virtually no risk and sell them fast.

While I couldn't eliminate or automate anything, I realized I could delegate almost *everything*. The only step that required my attention at that point was evaluating the information I collected. Anyone could contact the county assessor's office to gather information. Anyone could call the planning and zoning department and ask about property restrictions. And anyone could visit a few websites to collect data about the property. The CEO didn't need to perform *any* of those tasks, and I knew I had to delegate those tasks if I ever wanted to achieve the financial, time, and location freedom I desired.

3. Stop Doing All Tasks You Can Eliminate

Once I decided I could delegate almost *everything*, I stopped performing all of those tasks, only keeping the substantive due

diligence review in my swim lane.

I would delegate every step of collecting information but keep evaluating the information in my swim lane while I got comfortable delegating that to my intake manager.

4. Record Yourself Performing the Rest of the Tasks

Over the next several transactions, I documented every step of the process I took.

With some tasks, such as phone calls, you can't easily record yourself. For those, you can take notes of every step you took and then record yourself explaining them on video right after you're done. Talk as if you're speaking directly to the virtual assistant who will take over the task.

With other tasks, such as computer tasks, it's easy to record yourself. Many computers have screen recording software built in. If yours doesn't, you can download Zoom video conferencing software, start a video meeting by yourself, hit record, and share your screen while you perform the task. Explain each step you take and why. Then end the meeting and your recording will be ready within minutes.

5. Hire a Technical Writer to Write Out the Processes that Cannot Be Eliminated

With videos in place, a quick search on Fiverr.com Upwork.com, Freelancer.com, or HireMyMom.com will yield dozens, if not hundreds, of technical writers looking for work. Give the same video to three different writers and ask them to document the process in the video. Then hire the best writer to document the rest of the videos.

6. Hire a Virtual Assistant to Take Over Those Tasks

Once I had the videos and written instructions, I was ready to delegate. In my case, my intake manager was able to jump in and take over pretty quickly. Still, for the first several transactions, I worked with them to answer any questions and ensure the instructions were clear. I also talked through how I evaluated the due diligence.

Over time, I shifted from talking through how I evaluated the due diligence to asking my virtual assistant to take the first shot at evaluating the properties. I was pleasantly surprised to find out that we were pretty much on the same page from the start. With so few issues that can come up on a property, it didn't take long for me to explain my thinking on pretty much everything that comes up in the ordinary course of events.

Once I got comfortable with their decision-making, they were on their own to conduct due diligence and send it to me with their recommendation. I rarely disagreed with them. Today, they buy hundreds of properties without my needing to interfere. I trust them completely to reach out when they come across anything new that they don't know how to handle.

Outsourcing to a Due Diligence Agency or Abstractor

Although I delegate due diligence to a virtual assistant who works directly with me, it's not your only option. As land buying and selling grew in popularity, companies popped up that specialize in conducting due diligence on land transactions. Some were even started by Land Geek students.

It costs a little more money to use one of these agencies, but it's a completely hands-off solution and still *very* affordable. To put it in context, it generally costs me between $15 and $26 for my agency

to complete my due diligence as of this writing. That's still incredible value for the time you take back. In fact, even though I've trained my intake manager well, I frequently use agencies to help us out as well.

As of the writing of this book, here are three companies that offer done-for-you due diligence:

- LandVA4U.com (my personal recommendation and the company we use)
- LandMaster.us
- ParcelReview.com

Many of these companies are affiliated with American title companies, too, adding an additional comfort level for land investors. Be sure to check out the resources page on TheLandGeek.com for updated lists of companies that can help you as well as deals many of these companies give to people in the Land Geek community.

In addition to outsourcing due diligence to an agency, you can also hire a land title abstractor to conduct due diligence for higher-priced properties. This could be a good option for properties that are priced high enough to warrant additional concern but not so high that it justifies hiring a title insurance company, such as properties that fall in the $3,000 to $5,000 range.

Due Diligence Outsourcing Summarized

I've shared a lot of information in this chapter, so let's put together a quick summary to help you finally get due diligence out of your swim lane for good.

First, due diligence is simple to outsource. Follow the Land Geek Process of Systems Building just like I walked you through in this chapter and you will be able to free up your time without sacrificing

results or peace of mind. The nature of our business limits our risk and the due diligence we perform does the rest. Outsourcing this way adds virtually no risk compared to performing it all yourself. And it guarantees that you will recapture so much time to be a true CEO or just enjoy your life a little more.

With few exceptions, trained virtual assistants or a due diligence service can do everything you need for under $30 per property. If you're buying a property between $3,000 and $5,000, you might consider hiring a title abstractor for additional comfort. For properties over $5,000, it starts to become worth investing in the additional expense of using a title company.

And what about your concern about something important slipping through the cracks? At the beginning, double-check your virtual assistant's work very closely. But the issues that arise are extremely limited because of the nature of the land we buy. These aren't $500,000 houses where you could miss a cracked foundation or mold and be open to litigation. Your risk on each deal is so low that even if they miss something, you're most likely going to be OK. Even an IRS lien can be taken care of in ninety days.

The bottom line is that a CEO should not be spending time downloading copies of a deed from a county assessor's website. Your time can be much better spent focusing on CEO tasks, enjoying your life, and watching your inventory steadily rise.

Of course, as your inventory rises, you're going to need a strong system to market the properties. That's what we'll cover next.

Chapter 10

Marketing Your Properties to Maximize Profits

Imagine you've been elected to the board of directors of Coca-Cola. You're one of twelve on the board. During your next meeting, you notice the first item on the agenda is to review the company's financial budgets.

When the person sitting next to you sees the proposed marketing budget for the next year, they're shocked. They immediately question the marketing budget, saying, "Oh, my gosh, we spend $4 billion a year on marketing?! Does that seem high?! That seems high to me. I mean, is there a single person on the planet who doesn't know about Coca-Cola?! What if, for one year only, we split that $4 billion among the twelve of us as a one-time, special bonus? Surely, Coca-Cola can go a year without spending money on marketing. We already have top-of-mind awareness with everyone on the planet."

What do you think of that idea? Assuming you could take the bonus without any bad press or liability issues, would you take that $333+ million?

The answer is no, of course you wouldn't. In fact, Coca-Cola *does* spend about $4 billion a year on advertising. That's a lot of money for a company whose products are so well known. That's how important marketing is. It's so important to consistently market your products that the most recognizable companies in the world spend

billions of dollars a year marketing products that the entire world already knows about. They market everywhere their customers hang out. And they don't just place one ad and move on. They consistently run *multiple* ads across multiple platforms. On television, they often run multiple ads during the same show. Why would they do that? Because they know they have to show up consistently if they want to continue to stay relevant. They know people don't see every ad. They know people rarely respond to the first ad they see.

So, they advertise everywhere their customers are likely to be, they run multiple ads at a time, and they keep running them over and over.

What Land Businesses Can Learn from the Coca-Colas of the World

You can learn a lot about marketing your land from what the biggest companies in the world do. If companies whose products are known around the world consistently advertise everywhere they can find prospective customers, what does that mean for your land business?

It means consistent marketing is even more important for you. You don't have the same name recognition as those brands. Your customers don't even know your land is for sale. And nobody wakes up in the morning thinking, "Boy, I have an urge to buy a piece of raw land today," like they wake up craving Eggo waffles or Starbucks coffee. You have to do the work to get your land in front of buyers. You have to generate interest in your land if you want to sell it.

That's the bad news. But the good news is you don't need a $4 billion marketing budget—not even close. All you need to do is have your virtual assistants follow a simple marketing system that I've designed and refined to get you all the attention you need for just a few measly dollars.

For the rest of this chapter, I'll walk you through the exact steps that your virtual assistants need to take to sell properties as easily and efficiently as you buy them.

> "Marketing success hinges on knowing three pieces of information: (1) who you're trying to reach, (2) your message, and (3) how to deliver your message."—Adam Erhart

Strategy + Process = Advertising Bliss

When marketing properties for sale, the natural urge is to immediately run and place ads on Facebook, Craigslist, Landmodo.com, or any other number of other platforms where your buyers hang out. While that's not necessarily a bad instinct, in practice, you will waste a lot of time and money.

Instead, take a little time putting in place a strategy and process that ensures every ad you place is optimized to attract land buyers without you having to do all the work yourself. That's the only way to scale out of the land business without worrying about your inventory piling up.

For the rest of this chapter, I'll walk you through the marketing system my Land Geek students and I use to scale our marketing to not depend on us (or any other single human being). As you'll see, the system helps you (1) identify the right marketing platforms, (2) write an ad that gets buyers to pay attention and reach out to you, and (3) delegate your marketing to a virtual assistant so you don't have to do all the work yourself.

Even better, like all Land Geek systems, the system is designed to focus on process over people to ensure you can quickly find and train virtual assistants to take over your marketing efforts without

skipping a beat. That way, you don't end up relying on a single person or having to do the work yourself if someone quits. You just find a new virtual assistant, show them how to use the system, and go back to doing whatever it is you choose to do with your time. The first step to this system is to identify the platforms you need to advertise on for maximum profits, so I'll address that next.

Staying On Top of Marketing Platforms for Maximum Profit

I could list the platforms that are working best as I write this book, but that wouldn't be very helpful for you. Platforms come and go all the time. Platforms become more and less effective. At various times, Craigslist, Facebook, buy-sell groups, eBay, Zillow, Landmodo.com, LANDFLIP.com, and LandWatch.com were all high performers. Some of them still are as I'm writing this, along with several others. I'm sure some of them will still be effective whenever you're reading this. In 2015, Craigslist was the best. In 2024, Facebook was king.

I won't waste your time by just listing platforms that worked when I wrote this book. I value your time much more than that, so I'll share how I identify places to advertise my land. The good news is it's pretty simple. They fall into five categories: (1) neighbors, (2) my website and email list, (3) social media platforms, (4) online marketplaces, and (5) real estate and land-specific websites. Here's what to look for in each with some examples of sites that are working as of the time I'm writing this book.

Marketing Land to Neighbors, on Your Website, or to Your Email List

Like I mentioned in *Dirt Rich*, unlike housing or any other real estate investing strategy, raw land already has built-in best buyers: the

neighbors. Do not implement a marketing system that doesn't include sending a neighbor letter to adjoining property owners.

First, get a list of adjoining property owners from the county or online GIS maps. Next, send a letter stating something to the effect of "before we go to the open market, here is your opportunity to expand your land holdings, protect your views, and know your neighbors." Oftentimes, the neighbors buy first.

If you're to the point where you're starting to scale out of your land business, you likely have your own website and email list of leads. If not, now might be the time to consider starting both. Your website doesn't need to be complicated. A simple website with your listings and a way to get in touch with you will suffice.

Your email leads will be even more important than your website. Every time a lead reaches out, ask them for contact information so you can take the conversation off the social media or marketplace platforms. Let them know you can send them additional information as well as other properties they might be interested in. As time goes on, your list will grow and you will be able to advertise each of your properties to hundreds or even thousands of people who have either purchased or asked about property you had for sale in the past.

The beauty of marketing to neighbors, on your website, or to your email list is you don't have to worry about ads disappearing, like you do on social media or sites like Craigslist. You know your neighbor letter will be delivered. You control what posts to your website. And you control your email list. That said, the best place to advertise land is *everywhere land buyers hang out*. That's where the next three types of platforms come in.

Advertising Land on Social Media Platforms

While not all social media platforms are worth your time, Facebook has been a consistent high performer for a number of reasons. First,

everyone is on Facebook. It's consistently one of the most active websites in the world. Second, it has several features that make promoting your land easy, including investing, land, and real estate groups as well as a marketplace. Third, it has a messaging feature for people to reach out right on the platform. Fourth, it's a visual platform without restrictive character limitations.

Together, those features make Facebook very attractive for selling land. You can join multiple groups and promote your land for sale. You can post it on your timeline. You can start a Facebook page for your land business and post your property for sale. You can post it in the marketplace. You can do all of the above.

As of this writing, Facebook is far and away the best social media platform for selling land. Others have some of the features of Facebook, but no other platform has all of them. So, as new platforms come up, ask yourself whether its features make it attractive. If not, give it some time before you spend significant time or money asking your virtual assistant to advertise your land there. If you think it might be worth it, you could consider asking your virtual assistant to advertise your properties there for a little while to see what type of response you get.

Facebook Marketing Best Practices

Post far and wide. A lot of the properties we buy are in rural small-town areas, but many of our buyers will not be local, so you need to advertise everywhere you can. Post on Facebook marketplace in multiple areas. Post in local groups, real estate groups, land groups, and investor groups all over the country.

Advertising Land on Online Marketplaces

I've sold a lot of land using online marketplaces like Craigslist and eBay. Craigslist had a run as the best place to sell land before Facebook took over. Even after Facebook took over, it was still a good place to post; Facebook was just better.

eBay used to be great years ago. You could move a lot of property using eBay. Then other platforms like Craigslist and Facebook became much better (and cheaper) for selling land, so I switched to using eBay as a platform of last resort. I'd only list on eBay if I hadn't been able to move a property for a long time. But that was rare. Some properties took longer to sell than others, but they always sold. Between neighbors, my email list, and my primary advertising platforms, I usually have more than enough buyers to move through properties pretty quickly.

An online marketplace that's worth your time will generally have two features. First, it needs to have traffic. Enough people need to be using the marketplace for buying and selling that someone on the platform is likely to be interested in a piece of rural raw land. As with Facebook, local, regional, and national marketplaces will work. Craigslist is all of these. Second, there needs to be a way to communicate on the platform. While people will ideally pick up the phone or email us about the land, the truth is they are much more likely to reach out within the platform than to email or call. Of course, we will want to get their contact information as soon as possible, but we can do that in response to them reaching out on the platform.

Advertising Land on Real Estate and Land-Specific Websites

Real estate and land-specific websites won't have the same traffic as Facebook or Craigslist, but what they lack in traffic, they make up for in specificity. When people visit real estate and land-specific

websites, we know they're at least somewhat interested in buying land.

On the other hand, with these types of websites, our ads will post right next to thousands of other properties for sale. Thus, our challenge becomes getting visitors to click on our ads and not other people's ads. Fortunately, we have a system for headlines that grab people's attention, which I will share with you later in the chapter.

When looking for real estate and land-specific websites to advertise on, watch for signs that the sites have traffic. Many websites come and go, some with very little traffic. Posting ads to sites that are rarely updated could be a big waste of time and money.

As simple as it sounds, one way to find sites with decent traffic is to search Google for "raw land for sale." When you run the search, the top three or four results will often be ads. In other words, those sites that pay Google for top-of-the-page placement for the search term you entered. That's a good sign that those sites get a lot of activity. The sites immediately below the paid ads are the sites Google's algorithm believes to be the most relevant sites for your search. That's also a good sign that those listing sites generate a lot of traffic.

As of this writing, Landmodo.com, LandWatch.com, LandsOfAmerica.com, and LANDFLIP.com are real estate and land-specific websites that move a lot of land. No matter when you're reading this, however, a simple Google search for "land for sale" or "raw land for sale" can help you identify the sites that are likely to get the most traffic to your listings.

Consistency Is Key with Your Marketing—Ultimately with your ads, you just have to be consistent and put out more ads than you think you need. You don't need to be a billion-dollar company with your marketing, but you need to have a Geico

mindset. Geico shows up every day, twenty times a day. And everyone knows, "fifteen minutes or less can save you 15 percent or more on car insurance." We all immediately think of Geico when we hear that phrase because Geico is consistently showing up. And it's not just marketing on one channel, it's on every single channel. That's why you should be marketing on every effective channel—Facebook, Craigslist, and Landmodo, those are your big three, but they're not the only ones.

Promote Properties for Pennies

Advertising to neighbors, on your website, and to your email list is essentially free. Each neighbor letter costs you about $1 to send. Your website costs a few dollars a month to run. And building an email list can be as little as free. Even posting your property ads for sale on Craigslist, Facebook, and many other platforms, including on Landmodo.com, can be done for as little as free, as of this writing. In fact, Landmodo.com's free starter plan includes unlimited basic listings on its website plus a post about each of your listings on its Facebook page. Even paid plans on Landmodo.com, LANDFLIP.com, and other real estate and land-specific marketplaces that offer additional exposure to your ads won't cost you thousands of dollars. As of this writing, paid plans on those marketplaces generally run between $20 and $300 per month. For example, on LANDFLIP.com, its highest plan runs $300 per month as of this writing and includes two hundred listings. That's just $1.50 per listing for its highest-exposure plan.

See? You don't have to be a Coca-Cola executive with a $4 billion budget to capture attention for your land. You know where to ask your assistants to post. Now that you've learned the process for getting leads from great marketing, it's time to turn on the autopilot for making money while you sleep.

The Dynamics of a Good Land Ad

Now that you know where to place your ads, you need to know what to say in your ads to get them to stand out from the others. In this section, I'm going to walk you through the dynamics of a good land ad.

Before I do, let's get one thing clear. A good land ad isn't the prettiest, most poetic, or most clever ad. It's not the one with the greatest copy or the highest resolution images.

There are only two factors that make a good ad: clicks and connections.

You could have the greatest copy in the world. You could hire a $1 million copywriter. But it won't matter if nobody clicks on the ad.

And you could generate thousands of clicks to your ad, but it won't matter if nobody reaches out to inquire about the property.

So, what makes them click on the ad? And what makes them connect with you once they click?

It all starts with a good headline.

Writing a Clickable Headline

I'll bet you've bought hundreds of products, from Absolut vodka to Volkswagen cars, because of their catchy headlines. Catchy headlines get people to stop scrolling. Even better, they get people to click on an ad, sometimes simply because they hope the rest of the ad will be interesting.

Consider two examples.

Which of these headlines would you be more likely to click on: "Two Acres in Catskills" or "Don't Tell My Wife"?

"Don't Tell My Wife" is one of my favorite headlines for my business. It's been working for years. It catches people's attention. It stands out. It gets clicks. "Two Acres in Catskills" is boring. Most people will just scroll right by.

Choose a headline that catches people's attention. And don't be afraid to be controversial either. In a hotly contested political climate, you might base a headline on political slogans, like "Make This Land Great Again" to play on Donald Trump's presidential campaign slogan or "Build This Land Back Better" to play on Joe Biden's. With either of those, 50 percent of people will love it and 50 percent of people will hate it. But 100 percent of the people will notice it. And as the marketing genius Dan Kennedy famously teaches, "If you haven't offended someone by noon each day, then you're not marketing hard enough."

Once you've caught the eye—or the keyboard—of your potential customer, it's time to get them to connect with you about the land. That happens in the body of your ad.

Writing an Ad Body That Gets Buyers to Connect with You

Most land sellers write the body of their ad like they're writing a professional résumé. They list basic stats and a few buzzwords they think will get people's attention. Unfortunately, that strategy ends up with ads that are as boring as reading an actual résumé. People start reading, get bored within ten words, search for the stats, and then click away.

If you want people to reach out to you, avoid writing a résumé for your land. Instead, tell a story about the land. Yes, a story. Include all the information a résumé writer would include on a résumé, but make it interesting.

Start with the benefits of the land. It's an asset that lasts forever. It's easy to maintain. They can pass it down from generation to generation. It's a blank slate for them to use to make their dreams come true.

Let's write an opening sentence for a five-acre parcel in Colorado. In this case, the opening sentence might read, "Are you looking for land that is going to increase in value and provide you with investment appreciation year after year even in today's economy?"

Next, reference the ideal buyer for the land in the ad. For example, if you're advertising a piece of land in Florida, where people often move to retire, you might consider mentioning that the land is a long-term investment. In Colorado, you might highlight fresh air and outdoor exploration. Your wording will be different for each avatar, but the idea is to directly call out the ideal buyer for each property.

Let's continue the ad for Colorado land to make an emotional connection with an ideal buyer for this land:

> *Are you looking for land that is going to increase in value and provide you with investment appreciation year after year even in today's economy?*
>
> *This beautiful five-acre property will help you live the Colorado Dream that you have always imagined. It is conveniently located just a few miles south of Hartsel, roughly twelve miles from Antero Reservoir, which is most famously known for its fantastic fishing year-round. The shallowness of this reservoir makes it relatively warm for the location and altitude. This makes for exceptionally large, fast-growing fish. Antero Reservoir is owned by Denver Water and overseen by the Colorado Division of Wildlife. Because it is not a state park, there are no fees for fishing. Fishing is year-round, with ice fishing in the winter.*
>
> *This is the perfect property for anyone who is looking to make a long-term investment in some prime real estate or just get away*

from city life even if it's just for the weekend. Don't delay because properties like this don't come around every day!

GOLD MEDAL FISHING, BOATING: in nearby Spinney Mountain, Elevenmile, and Antero Reservoirs, and the South Platte River!

HUNTING: Pike and San Isabel National Forests are just minutes away from this property and are loaded with wildlife such as deer, elk, antelope, and moose.

HIKING, BIKING, AND SKIING: On Colorado's finest mountain trails and ski areas.

As you can see, this ad copy gives detail about the property with a story feel. It opens with a question that gets the reader thinking about long-term value. Then, it includes information about the property in a way that references activities an ideal buyer will care about, such as year-round fishing nearby, including ice fishing and fishing for exceptionally large, fast-growing fish.

At the end, the ad doesn't simply list that the property is near Spinney Mountain, Elevenmile, and Antero Reservoirs, and the South Platte River. It says, in all caps, that the buyer can experience gold medal fishing and boating there. It doesn't just mention the property being near Pike and San Isabel National Forests. It mentions, in all caps, that the buyer could be minutes away from hunting for deer, elk, antelope, and moose if they buy the property. Everything about the property and its location is presented in the context of how a potential buyer would experience the land. It calls out hunters, boaters, fishermen, hikers, bikers, and skiers by name.

The rest of the information to add to your properties is simple. Include the pictures and maps you got from due diligence when you bought the property, and your ad body will be almost complete. Next you need to price the property to sell. You might be surprised to learn what I mean by that.

Pricing a Property to Sell

Ultimately, what sells our land is when we make it irresistible with our price. To do that, you need to keep the pricing simple. Notice I didn't say low. I said simple. Way too many land investors mess this up. They give buyers ten different options, thinking one option will resonate with each buyer. In practice, the opposite is true. Complexity causes confusion. And confusion causes people to click away.

Resist the urge to give buyers ten different options. It is good for sales. In fact, a now-famous study by Columbia University psychologist Sheena Iyengar and Stanford University psychologist Mark Lepper determined that offering people *fewer* choices can be good for sales.[1] In the study, two research assistants dressed as store employees set up a display table offering Wilkin & Sons jam samples at an upscale food market on two separate Saturdays. Throughout each day, the assistants alternated between displaying six flavors and twenty-four flavors on their display table and kept track of how many flavors people sampled as well as how many people subsequently purchased jam.

Although many people assume the customers who had twenty-four flavors to choose from would sample more flavors than those who only had six to choose from, that wasn't the case. The customers with twenty-four choices averaged 1.50 flavors sampled while the customers with only six choices averaged 1.38 flavors sampled, a statistically insignificant difference given the sample size.

What *was* significant was the subsequent purchasing behavior observed by the researchers. Only 3 percent of the customers with twenty-four choices subsequently purchased a jar of Wilkin & Sons jam compared to 30 percent of consumers presented with only six flavors. That's not a typo. Just 3 percent of consumers who had twenty-four options purchased compared to 30 percent of consumers who had just six options.

As the researchers explained:

> *These findings are striking. Certainly, they appear to challenge a fundamental assumption underlying classic psychological theories of human motivation and economic theories of rational choice—that having more, rather than fewer, choices is necessarily more desirable and intrinsically motivating. The findings from this study show that an extensive array of options can at first seem highly appealing to consumers yet can reduce their subsequent motivation to purchase the product.*

So, what does that have to do with selling land? Everything. If you give your potential customers more options, they will be much less likely to purchase. Give one price in your ad. Buyers know pricing is often flexible or negotiable so if the pricing in your ad is even somewhat attractive to them, they'll contact you. Only when they contact you is it safe to offer a couple more options. Still keep it simple, but if they ask about pricing, you or a team member can give them a couple of other options.

I typically only give one price and it will be very simple, such as $199 dollars down and $199 a month over eighty-four months, which would pay me around a 9 percent interest rate on the financed amount. I like presenting prices like they are car payments because it makes it easy for buyers to imagine themselves being able to make the payments.

I also add an "anchor" to the pricing. Adding an anchor is simply presenting a higher price that you *could* charge for the property, but then crossing out the higher price and replacing it with a lower one.

Pricing on land is all over the place, and ultimately nobody knows what a piece of land is worth. And, frankly, if we didn't mind holding on to inventory for a while, we could often get higher prices for the land we sell. But the real value and recurring passive income come

from the recurring monthly payments, so we make much more money in the long run if we move through our inventory faster.

Thus, I always add an anchor price that I could charge if I wanted to squeeze every last penny of value from a property, irrespective if that meant holding on to inventory longer. I then cross out that price and reveal the actual price for the property. In this example, I might write $499 down, with the $499 crossed out, followed by $199 down and $199 a month over eighty-four months. Anchor prices have been proven to increase sales because they give customers a higher reference point and remind them they are getting a good deal.

Adding Scarcity, Urgency, Calls to Action, and Risk Reversals

You've got their attention. You've made an emotional connection with the ideal buyer. And you've included one or two simple pricing options. All that's left is to create a sense of scarcity and urgency, drop an anchor, and present a clear call to action to the potential buyer.

Creating a sense of scarcity and urgency about the property is designed to motivate the buyer to reach out as fast as possible. We do that in two ways. First, we remind the buyer that every piece of land is unique, and there's only one in the world that's exactly like the property they're reading about. Second, we let them know that buying this one piece of land is on a first-come, first-served basis. This doesn't need to be complicated. Even simple wording such as, "Don't delay because properties like this don't come around every day!" like the Colorado land example above, works well. Other phrases such as "Hurry," or "This won't last long" can work too.

In addition to scarcity and urgency, your ad has to present a clear call to action. Don't be meek here. Tell people exactly what you want them to do next. Tell them in multiple places too. It's not uncommon for one of my ads to have four calls to action. I give them a little information, and then say, "Click here to invest now." Then I give

them more information, followed by another "Click here before this property is gone." Then I give them more information, and so on.

The final piece of the puzzle is what's known as a risk reversal. No matter how attractive your property seems, almost everyone reading your ad will worry about risk. You did such a good job getting their attention, telling a story, and creating urgency that they want to buy the land before someone else does. But what if they can't get out to see the property for two weeks, or two months? What if they see the property and hate it? What if there's something wrong with the property and it doesn't fit their needs? Take away all those worries by taking on all the risk that they won't like the property. Compelling risk reversals include the following:

- Ninety-day due diligence guarantee! Love the property or we'll refund or exchange it for another property.
- We never want anyone to buy property sight unseen. So, if after 90 days you visit the land and don't love it, we'll refund or exchange it for another property.
- We have a 90-day refund and 365-day exchange guarantee. If you don't love the land within 90 days, we'll give you a refund. Need more time? You can exchange your land for another property within 365 days.

We want buyers to go to bed at night knowing that they can do business with us and there's no risk. They'll either love their land or get a refund.

With all these pieces in place, you don't need a million-dollar copywriter. All you need is a database of headlines and ad copy from your top-performing ads and virtual assistants to write and post the ads for you.

> "The person that wins is not who gets their customer to understand them best, but who understands their customer

> best and who makes their customer feel understood."—Mark Podolsky, The Land Geek

How to Hire and Train Assistants to Write and Place Your Ads

There are few feelings more freeing than never having to place land ads again. Food tastes better. The air smells cleaner. The sun shines brighter. And you're just a few simple steps away from that feeling in your business.

Your next step is to hire and train assistants to write and place your ads. There's nobody I trust more when it comes to marketing than Tate Litchfield. Tate is both a brilliant land marketer and a master of delegating who ran up against several obstacles when outsourcing his marketing to virtual assistants. He ran into turnover issues after several virtual assistants didn't work out. He ran into problems with ads disappearing, especially on sites like Craigslist, which is notorious for removing ads. And he ran into compensation issues, essentially paying virtual assistants way more than their results warranted for a while.

While there are few feelings more freeing than never having to place land ads again, there are few feelings more *frustrating* than knowing you are close to never having to place land ads but not being able to get over the hump. Tate knows that feeling well. It happens, but having systems and processes in place and a compensation model that pays for results makes it much easier to avoid.

First, keep an updated list of advertising platforms, a checklist of what elements every ad needs, and a database of your best-performing headlines and ad copy. While the platforms, headlines, and ad copy will change over time, ad elements won't. Here's a list of elements every ad needs that you can use:

- Clickable headline
- Compelling opening sentence
- Benefits of the land (in story form)
- References to the ideal buyer so they can start to see themselves enjoying the land
- Pictures and maps you got from due diligence
- Simple pricing
- Scarcity and urgency
- Multiple calls to action
- Risk reversal

Second, if you're posting to a site like Craigslist that's notorious for removing ads, consider hiring someone who specializes in that platform. After going through several writers who had trouble getting Craigslist posts to stick, Tate hired someone who specialized in Craigslist and saw much better results. It's much cheaper to pay a little more for someone who specializes in a platform but gets ads to stick than try to save a few bucks but have half of your ads disappear within twenty-four hours.

Third, match your pay to results. When Tate first got started, he paid his Craigslist virtual assistants by the hour only to see many of their ads disappear. He later shifted to a pay structure that only paid for ads that stayed on the site for more than twenty-four hours. The virtual assistant sends links to all the posts they place. The next day, another virtual assistant checks the posts and reports how many remain live. Tate then pays for the ads that stick. Currently, he pays between eighty cents and one dollar per post that sticks, which as of the time of this writing is pretty mid-range.

With these three elements in place, you can quickly cut your time managing your ad team to just minutes a week. Even with this structure, Tate only spends about ten minutes a week focusing on ads.

How to Use Artificial Intelligence to Make Your Life Even Easier and Lower Overhead

In the not-so-distant future, artificial intelligence will make our ads more effective and our teams even more efficient. For example, even as of this writing, we're testing an integration between artificial intelligence company Open AI and LGPASS to create ad copy by inputting just a few keywords and images.

The results are pretty impressive already, even at this relatively early stage of artificial intelligence. Technology will continue to make our lives easier and lower our overhead as entrepreneurs and CEOs. And, although we might be a little ways away from being able to use artificial intelligence without having a human review it, the current tools are still extremely impressive and valuable.

Soon, we will be able to just prompt artificial intelligence programs for our ads and the software will create copy and could even generate images. That will enable us to redirect the money we pay to people to create original copy for ads to other tasks, such as buying more land to flip.

Measure Your Performance

You know where to post, what to post, and how to post without you having to do it yourself. But how many ads do you need to generate a sale?

Tate and I have both found that it takes about fifty leads to generate a sale. Want to sell one property a week? Increase the number of ads you place until you generate fifty leads a week. Want to sell two properties a week? You need one hundred leads a week.

Of course, your experience might be different from ours, so I recommend keeping track of two ad performance metrics. First,

track how many leads you need to make a sale. That will tell you how many ads you need to place to hit sales targets. Second, track how many ads it takes to generate one hundred leads. That will tell you how effective your ads are. As you optimize, you should need fewer ads to generate one hundred leads. Together, those numbers will help you determine the return on your investment on marketing efforts. They will also make it easier for you to hit sales targets by asking your virtual assistants to place the right number of ads to achieve your sales goals.

Stress Test Your Marketing Systems

No matter how well your marketing works, I recommend stress testing your marketing systems. I stress test my marketing every year. When you're just getting started, I recommend doing it more frequently until your system works perfectly.

Stress testing your marketing systems is simple. Take a week off from performing any marketing activities yourself. As your systems become better, extend that time off until you can take a full month off without it skipping a beat.

That's what we do with our coaching clients. When they have a trained team in place, we ask them to stop their personal marketing efforts by taking a week off from all marketing activities. They still do the nonmarketing tasks in their swim lanes but can't do anything in regard to marketing for seven full days. If the system works, they can continue focusing on non-marketing activities and managing their virtual assistant. If it falls apart, we help them build better marketing systems. When that system is up and running, they stress test the new system. We continue this pattern until their systems work without them.

Behind the Scenes of Tate Litchfield's Marketing Machine

Tate Litchfield has scaled out of his business. He's living the dream. He works when he wants, where he wants, and with whom he wants. This is what his marketing team looks like currently:

- Three virtual assistants working full-time posting only to Craigslist
- One ad writer writing both long and short ads for each property for sale
- Two virtual assistants who post and respond to leads on Facebook
- One virtual assistant who manages a Deal of the Week promotion
- One virtual assistant who focuses on real estate and land marketplaces. (In Tate's case, that's currently Landmodo.com.)
- One executive assistant who communicates with all the marketing assistants

Anything the assistants need goes to Tate's executive assistant. She answers anything she can and only reaches out to Tate with something she can't handle, which is very little. She also puts together a weekly report for Tate. Every Friday, Tate spends a few minutes reading the statistics for the week to see whether they are on target and determining whether any adjustments need to be made.

How good would it feel to never have to place an ad again? While it can take some time and effort up front, you're just a few systems and people away from that being your reality.

Now you have your systems. All you need is to hire and train your virtual assistants, stress test your systems, adjust as necessary, and then watch the leads roll in on autopilot.

Chapter 11

How to Qualify Buyers on Autopilot to Double Your Profit

Jon and Valari Burnett had succeeded for years due to them both having strong work ethics. While that served them well in many ways, it caused them to delay delegating to VAs for more than a year after they started their land business in July 2017.

For the first year, Jon and Valari worked diligently to build their land business in a way that grew profits while not burning out Jon, who was still working his full-time job. They dedicated two hours a day to their land business, Monday through Saturday. During the week, one of those hours was Jon's lunch break, when he'd drive to Starbucks and work for an hour. The other hour was the hour after the kids went to bed. By 8:00 p.m., Jon and Valari would stop working on their business.

Working just twelve hours a week was more than enough to help them achieve their primary goal of helping Jon quit his day job, which he achieved in March 2018. A few months later, however, they started hitting a ceiling because they were still doing all the work themselves. They were making good money, but their business was entirely dependent on their efforts.

In October 2018, Jon attended a three-day live training course we conduct called the Land Geek Bootcamp to continue to refine their business. Our boot camps are attended by a variety of land business

owners; some just starting out and others who have been in business for years. Jon and Valari were in a somewhat unique position. They were more than a year into their business and hadn't let go of *any* work. They were still sending out every mailing. They were still answering every phone call. They were still placing every ad.

If they stopped working, their business would stop working. When Jon describes to me what his business was like at the time, it reminds me of what my business was like that day Ori told me to not call myself a business owner. Like me, Jon was making good money buying and selling land, but he wasn't a business owner. Also like me, Jon heard some harsh words from the more experienced land business owners at the boot camp.

Those three days would change the entire trajectory of Jon and Valari's business. When he left the boot camp, Jon got to work, systematizing, delegating, and automating his business to operate without him. As he did, he realized he hadn't really been that great an employee after all. For example, the lifeblood of a land business is deal flow. That requires mailing offers. The more offers you send, the more deals you close, and the more money you make.

But the person in charge of lists and mailings in Jon's land business for the first year—Jon—wasn't very good at it. He hated sending mailings and often procrastinated doing so. Here's how he described it:

> *I hate, hate, hate mailing and putting together lists. It was something I was doing. There would be gaps where I would do it and then there would be a gap. Then I'd do it again, and then there would be a gap because it wasn't something I was excited about. I kept on pushing it off and pushing it off.*

Could you imagine hiring someone with that job performance to take care of your lists and mailings? If you asked Jon today, he would

never hire someone like that. When we're the person doing the work, we don't often think of it this way, especially when we're just starting out. We think of the "free" nature of our work and suck it up. After leaving the boot camp, Jon had a new perspective and decided to start letting go of tasks he didn't enjoy. Naturally, mailing and putting together lists were two of the first tasks to go.

How did it go? Here's how he described it:

> *After I started delegating it, we would mail every single week without fail. That was an important thing for me to do because, even though there was an added cost, there was an opportunity cost that goes on the flip side of that.*

Today, Jon and Valari have hired between thirteen and fifteen virtual assistants to help them with their multimillion-dollar business, which allows Jon to focus on his role as CEO. They are true business owners, only keeping the tasks they want to perform in their swim lane.

Even better, Jon's phone no longer rings all day. He no longer places ads. He no longer worries about deal flow drying up if he gets sick or doesn't want to work one day, week, or even month.

For Jon, much of that freedom came when he hired a sales assistant to prequalify buyers and process sales. Before hiring a sales assistant, Jon spent hours and hours communicating with people who would never buy a piece of land from him. With Facebook, for example, it typically takes sixty to seventy leads to find a buyer for a property. With Craigslist, it typically takes thirty to fifty. That means Jon used to communicate with between thirty and seventy people for each piece of land he sold.

After hiring his sales assistant, he's now handed the top three to five candidates only. His sales assistant does all the work answering preliminary questions and identifying the serious buyers. Jon just comes in at the end to close the sales, freeing up hours of his time

to get more property into inventory or just spend more time with his family.

Why Hiring a Sales Assistant Is the Next Step to Scaling Out of Your Land Business

Imagine going from thirty to seventy calls per property to only three to five, like Jon and others experience by hiring a sales assistant to prequalify leads. How much time would that free up for you? What would that make possible for your business? What about your personal life? If you're like most of my students, that time would be life changing.

In the simplest terms, high-profit land businesses are based on two transactions—buying and selling land. While that might sound overly simple, the truth is our businesses are fairly straightforward. We buy land and we sell land. Buying land involves building a list of properties to target, sending mailers, conducting due diligence, and closing the purchase transaction. Selling requires marketing the properties for sale, prequalifying potential buyers, and closing the sales transaction. Pretty much everything we do in the land business falls into one of those categories.

If you implement the steps I have walked you through so far, you will have

1. hired an intake manager to automate deal flow and 10x your inventory,
2. outsourced due diligence with virtually no risk, and
3. outsourced marketing and ad writing to generate a steady flow of potential buyers for your properties.

In other words, the only day-to-day activities you have yet to move out of your swim lane are prequalifying potential buyers, closing

sales transactions, and completing higher-level business management activities.

Once your sales assistant takes care of prequalifying potential buyers and handing you only the top potential buyers, you'll be left with only higher-level activities to handle, like closing the sale and big-picture CEO activities.

Hiring Your First Sales Assistant

Because your sales assistant's primary role will be communicating with potential buyers, make sure they speak English fluently. They do not need to be U.S.-based because they typically won't be speaking on the phone with clients, but clear communication skills are key because they will be communicating over email with potential buyers. Some high-performing sales assistants will end up taking over closing calls with buyers, in which case being U.S.-based is important. Getting on the phone with potential buyers to close deals is typically something you delegate to your next hire, the acquisition manager, so being U.S.-based isn't critical with your sales assistant in most cases.

A good sales assistant requires a little more skill than someone whose main responsibility involves placing ads that are written by someone else. They need to answer questions promptly from people who respond to ads and convince people to have their email address added to your buyers list. The best sales assistants are self-starters, hardworking, and persistent, with great attention to detail.

At first, we will still be the ones to get on the phone with buyers to close the deal after they are prequalified. Over time, when we gain more confidence in our sales assistant, we can delegate some or all of those conversations to them. However, those conversations typically become the responsibility of your next hire—an acquisition manager, which we will discuss next—who takes the rest of the day-

to-day business operations tasks out of our swim lane, leaving us only responsible for the highest-level decisions, strategy, and supervision.

The Ego Test to Weed Out the Wrong Candidates

As any business owner knows, turnover can be expensive because of the time it takes to find and replace a team member. The sooner you can identify whether a candidate is a good fit, the better, because it limits all the time you would need to spend getting them up to speed and answering questions.

Because finding the right sales assistant is truly life changing, running a business that goes through sales assistants quickly can be pretty frustrating. Unfortunately, many land business owners go through a few before finding the right fit. Even then, there can be some turnover with sales assistants if they don't have the right demeanor and work ethic. In fact, because our systems and processes are so strong and easy to follow, demeanor and work ethic are even more important than experience or most other skills when it comes to sales assistants.

That's why it's so important to do whatever you can to find a candidate with the right demeanor and work ethic. Unfortunately, this is where many land business owners go wrong. They place an ad or get referred to a potential candidate, interview them, find them likable, and hire them. Weeks later, they realize the candidate doesn't like to work very hard and is terrible with follow-up.

Primary Sales Assistant Tasks

- Checking Craigslist, Facebook, and Any Other Platform Where You Advertise
- Answering Questions from People Who Respond to Ads

- Collect Email Addresses from Potential Buyers to Add Them to Buyers List
- Schedule Call with CEO (or Acquisition Manager) to Close Sales

To avoid getting stuck with someone with the wrong work ethic and demeanor, I recommend giving every candidate what I call the Ego Test during the hiring process. Here's how the Ego Test works: Reject every candidate who replies to your sales assistant ad. Yes, every candidate. Reject them. Just reply and tell them you don't think they are a good fit for some legitimate but ambiguous reason you don't think they can handle the job. Watch what they do next. The vast majority of them either won't respond or will reply politely and thank you for your time. Those candidates likely don't have what it takes to succeed as a sales assistant.

A few candidates we reject will reply to tell us we are making a big mistake or ask us to reconsider. We like that. We want a response. We want to know they can handle rejection and be persistent on follow-up.

> "I see relief on the horizon."—Mimi Schmidt, after she hired a sales assistant.

Setting Expectations and Aligning Your Interests

If your candidate passes the Ego Test, the next obstacle we need them to push through is understanding the reality of their first year as a sales assistant. As with many roles in the real estate world, sales assistants get paid well but generate income purely based on

performance—usually 80 percent of the down payment plus a small bonus when deals close. In addition, in our company, some U.S.-based sales assistants earn our trust over time and start taking over some phone calls to close deals. With those sales assistants, we pay them 18 percent of the monthly payment collected from each sale they close for us as long as they are still working with the company. In those cases, we do not pay the closing bonus, only the percentage of the monthly payment collected.

As sales assistants build up their deal flow, their income begins to add up, especially for those who graduate to closing deals on the phone. For example, by the second year, high-performing sales assistants who close deals on the phone can make $2,000 to $5,000, or more, in passive income from the monthly payment component of their compensation alone.

But the truth is the first year will be hard, and your sales assistant won't make much money. They might need to work weeks or even months before a substantial number of deals start to close. But sometime around the end of the first year, as their transactions add up and they start closing deals, they will start to make good money.

This compensation model works because it aligns your interests with theirs. They make money when you make money. The better they do, the more they can make. But because it can take a while before they start earning money, it's best to hire sales assistants to start on a part-time basis. That way, talented sales assistants don't *have* to make money right away to pay their bills. Advertise the opportunity as a part-time position and encourage candidates to take the position if they want unlimited earning potential but are both willing and able to not make much money for a little while. Encourage them to not quit their other job until they build up enough income with you that they don't need the other income to pay their bills.

Sales Assistant Compensation Plan

Eighty Percent of Down Payments Collected
+
A Small Bonus for Every Lead They Send That Closes

Structuring the Workweek for Success

Once you find a candidate with the right traits to do well, all that's left is making sure your candidate can work the right schedule to do their job well. While most sales assistants will start part-time, it's important to structure their workweek in a way that works for the reality of land businesses. After all, if you've been in the land business for any amount of time, you know two things. First, buying and selling land is a seven-day-a-week business. Potential buyers reach out every single day, even weekends. Second, responsiveness is critical to our success. The faster we respond to potential buyers, the faster we prequalify them, the faster we can sell land, and the faster we can build up that sweet, sweet passive note income. If we wait five days to respond to an inquiry, the buyer takes a week to ask another question, and so on and so forth, transactions can take weeks or even months longer than they need to, all because of the downtime between emails back and forth.

Avoid hiring a sales assistant who can't structure their workweek to fit the reality of the land business. That means avoiding hiring a sales assistant who can only work weekends. Instead, look for someone who can check in every day for even a couple of hours. Have them work in sprints, working two or three hours each day to follow up with potential leads, add emails to your buyers list, and send prequalified leads to you so you can close the deals.

Giving Your Sales Assistant the Tools to Succeed

Sales assistants will spend most of their time communicating with potential buyers. Their communications will start over email or through sites like Craigslist or Facebook with the goal of moving those conversations to email.

Of course, as with the other virtual assistants, use the Land Geek Process of Systems Building to record and document how to perform each task you will ask them to perform, including how to communicate with potential buyers on Craigslist, Facebook, and other platforms you use to market your land; how to email potential buyers; and how to add buyers' email addresses to your email list.

In addition, because many buyers ask similar questions, create a database of scripts you have used in the past to respond to the most common questions. This can be as simple as creating a Google Doc of proven responses to the most common questions for them to copy.

Finally, they will need access to all the platforms they need to do their jobs well. Because they will be emailing buyers, I recommend setting up a unique email address for you to share with them. That way you can easily monitor what is sent and received.

The Light at the End of the Tunnel

Can you see the light at the end of the tunnel yet? With your sales assistant in place, you should begin to see it shining in the distance. That's because, by this point in the process, you have very little left to do in your business. With the intake, due diligence, marketing, and lead prequalification all outsourced, you only have four tasks left in your now shallow swim lane:

1. Doing county research

2. Closing sales
3. Managing your virtual assistants
4. Completing high-level CEO strategy

Those four tasks should take you less than ten hours a week, with closing sales and managing your virtual assistants taking up the bulk of that time.

Even better, you're just one more virtual assistant away from offloading sales, managing your virtual assistants, and, over time, even county research.

That'll get you down to working just a couple of hours a week in your land business. If that sounds like a life you'd like to live, keep reading. That's what we're going to talk about next.

Chapter 12

The Final Step to Achieving a Two-Hour Workweek

Mark Livingston works a full-time job as a C-suite accounting executive for a large building products company. He spends his days analyzing business models, reviewing financial statements, and handling the high-level demands of a worldwide company that's been in business since before the Great Depression of the early twentieth century.

With that demanding a job and that level of sophistication, many people would be surprised to see him buying and selling raw land. They'd assume he had neither the time nor the desire to handle all the tasks it takes to build a profitable land business. But if you've read this far, you can probably guess how he did it: he built his business using virtual assistants.

When Mark first learned about buying and selling land, he loved the concept but couldn't justify spending the time it would take to build it up. His corporate salary, plus the value of his time alone, made the idea of conducting due diligence for a $2,500 piece of land or responding to fifty inquiries to sell that piece of land for $10,000 not very attractive. Even working ten hours a week would be pushing it for Mark, at least over the long term. He could work for a short period of time to build up his systems and processes but needed to have a team in place to run the day-to-day tasks in his business over the long term.

That's when Mark met Nick Bond, a young, hungry land investor who was willing to bet on himself to help Mark grow while also doing his own deals on the side. Nick had recently graduated from college and had less capital than Mark. So, he couldn't buy and sell as much land as Mark, but he *could* earn significant performance-based pay by helping Mark offload the higher-level tasks he was still performing, such as county research and team management.

It was a match made in heaven. Nick was doing well on his own but was limited by his access to capital. Meanwhile, Mark did well getting started but was limited by his time. So, the two of them joined forces, each of them benefited greatly, and Mark's down to working just two hours a week. Take that Tim Ferriss, author of *The 4-Hour Workweek*! We've created the two-hour workweek.

Primary Acquisition Manager Tasks

- Managing the Intake Manager
- Overseeing the VAs Handling Due Diligence
- Managing the Marketing VAs
- Managing the Sales Assistant
- Closing Deals
- Managing and Improving Systems and Processes
- Handling County Research

Achieving Your Very Own Two-Hour Workweek

At this point in the land business, you're in a similar position to Mark. You might not have the same C-suite salary or time limitations but, in the land world, you're closer than you think.

You have delegated your intake, due diligence, advertising, and lead prequalification. You have likely built a steady flow of passive monthly note income. And you know all the systems and processes needed to buy and sell land on autopilot. If only you could offload the last few tasks that require your attention on a day-to-day basis.

That's where your acquisition manager comes in. In short, your acquisition manager will take over all the day-to-day tasks that a CEO has no business performing. At first, that includes managing your other team members and closing sales. Once they're comfortable with those tasks, they graduate to conducting county research—the last non-CEO task we move out of your swim lane.

With those tasks out of your swim lane, all you need to do is manage your acquisition manager and conduct high-level strategy to continue to optimize and scale your business.

Don't worry, you don't need a young land investor to come into your world like Mark Livingston experienced with Nick Bond. That's certainly possible, especially if you join me in Flight School or one of our boot camps. You'll meet a lot of people in the land business there. But you don't need that to happen to find and train an acquisition manager to cut your workweek down to two hours.

That's because total freedom begins the moment you hire your acquisition manager. Your acquisition manager takes over all the day-to-day tasks both you and your sales assistant perform. When they're fully trained, they will manage your entire business for you. All that'll be left when they're up and running is you, the CEO. From due diligence to county research, your acquisition manager will perform just about every task—allowing you to finally work only when you want, where you want, doing only what you want, and with whom you want. The rest of your time can be spent living your best life.

Timing Your Hire and Aligning Your Interests

Before you hire an acquisition manager, make sure you have at least thirty to fifty parcels in inventory—ideally, closer to fifty. You might also want to start thinking about funding sources outside of your own deal flow, such as other people's money, to help accelerate your deal flow after they join. (I'll talk about that in part 4 when I share how to go from two hours a week to two hours a *month* while continuing to grow your business.)

This way, your acquisition manager can start closing deals and making money as soon as they're trained, and you can start funding even more deals for them to close. The last thing you want is to spend time training someone who has nothing to sell or to have them burn through inventory faster than you can acquire more parcels.

Like sales assistants, acquisition managers get paid purely based on performance, in this case taking over the 80 percent down payment commission you were giving to the sales assistant who the acquisition manager replaces. However, instead of the small bonus at closing, they get 18 percent of the monthly payment collected from each sale they close. I recommend paying them for every deal they work on from the start—even when they're shadowing you and you're doing most of the work. This will help them build up their income faster and still be paying them for production. But here's the kicker: if they leave the company, they only get three more months of payments. This incentivizes them to stay and perform.

Even with a healthy inventory, steady deal flow, and paying them from the start, the first year will still be hard. They will make some money quickly by selling off existing inventory, earning commission from down payments, and increasing deal flow. But it will take some time for the deals to add up. After the first year or so, high-performing acquisition managers can relatively easily earn well over $100,000 in annual compensation.

Acquisition Manager Compensation Plans

Eighty Percent of Down Payments Collected
+
Eighteen Percent of the Monthly Revenue Collected from Each Sale They Close

Hiring an Acquisition Manager

Because your acquisition manager will handle high-level tasks, including closing sales with buyers, the ideal candidate will be U.S.-based. You ideally want someone who has savings or is willing and able to live a simple life for up to a year for the substantial upside potential.

And if Nick Bond doesn't happen to find you? Don't worry too much. Scott Todd found his acquisition manager on Craigslist—a realtor who had sales experience and wanted something more and different. Now she's making a six-figure income as Scott's acquisition manager. But Craigslist is an anomaly. It's worth placing a job posting, but our most successful students find their acquisition managers through word of mouth. Local real estate groups could be a good place to start asking around. I'd also suggest diving into the Land Geek community and letting people know you're looking for an acquisition manager. That's a great place to start because people will be more likely to understand the business model.

Your acquisition manager needs to have an entrepreneurial mindset to succeed. They need to see buying and selling parcels as *their* business, even though they're working within your business. After all, they are coming into a business with systems, processes, deal flow, and unlimited earning potential, but they don't have to put in any money of their own. Other than having equity in the business

and having to invest their own money, that's essentially how a franchise operates. After a tough first year, they can start building significant income, both actively from down payment commissions and passively, earning 18 percent of monthly payments as long as they're still working with the company.

Next, the people skills. Because your acquisition manager needs to manage your VAs, they need to have some people skills. They need to look for ways to motivate, reward, and recognize other team members, such as by suggesting small bonuses for work that goes above and beyond. They also need to have good attention to detail to double-check the other team members' work and provide constructive feedback as necessary.

Of course, as the liaison between you and the other team members, as well as the person in charge of communicating with buyers, your acquisition manager needs to have superior communication skills.

Additionally, because we use software to scale and streamline many parts of our businesses, they need to be comfortable with tech. For example, we use LGPASS for several parts of our business including:

- Formatting, filling in, and printing out offer letters, contracts, and closing documents
- Organizing paperwork
- Verifying addresses
- organizing deeds, promissory notes, purchase sale agreements, and land sale contracts; and
- managing our internal team workflow and communications.

We also use LGPASS to send checks to sellers and pay property taxes. Plus, we use GeekPay to service our notes, including:

- Automatically charging customers on their due date
- Calculating interest, principal, and services fees

- Providing customers with a dashboard where they can log in, view their balances, and make payments with ease
- Providing downloadable reports at the end of the year that we can just send over to our accountant
- Managing collections messages without having to rely on an army of virtual assistants

While the software is incredibly simple (Scott Todd and I designed LGPASS and GeekPay ourselves), make sure you let people know you need someone who is comfortable with software and who has good attention to detail and organizational skills, as those skills are critical to being able to get you out of the business.

Finally, your acquisition manager needs to be trustworthy. You'll have to give your acquisition manager limited power of attorney to sign deeds and buy properties in some settings, such as at auction. The acquisition manager will continue to keep track of their transactions in LGPASS, which you should go over with them during your leadership meetings. But it's still important to find someone with a history of trustworthiness when hiring an acquisition manager.

Training Your Acquisition Manager

As a full-time team member, your acquisition manager will assume a lot of responsibilities, including the following:

- Managing the intake manager
- Overseeing the VAs handling due diligence
- Managing the marketing VAs
- Managing (or replacing) the sales assistant
- Closing deals
- Managing and improving systems and processes
- Handling county research

I suggest they replace the sales assistant as soon as possible, for a couple of reasons. First, you already have people in place to handle everything else, short of closing deals, managing VAs, and handling county research, which you handle in less than ten hours a week. Second, your acquisition manager should be able to take over sales assistant tasks pretty quickly. They're only part-time, and you have systems and scripts in place for pretty much everything they do. Third, as soon as the acquisition manager can start qualifying leads, they can start to earn the 80 percent down payment commission.

After taking over for the sales assistant, the rest of their time should be spent training on the other tasks, such as managing the other VAs, closing deals, and managing and improving systems and processes.

The last task they should take over is handling county research. Identifying the right counties is the life blood of the land business. Finding the right counties is like printing money. On the other hand, buying up a bunch of properties in the wrong counties is like burning it. Make county research the last thing you hand over to them and make it a slow, gradual transition. When I first hired an acquisition manager, we spent a lot of time evaluating counties. Every week, I'd choose a county and ask him to do a write-up. He'd give me his thoughts on each county, whether it was a good one or bad one, and why. I would check his work every week and explain whether he was right or wrong and why. We did that for months and months until I regularly had no disagreements with his reasoning. Once I was comfortable with his analysis of the counties I gave him, I had him start picking counties on his own. Only after he regularly picked quality counties did I have him completely take over county research.

For each task that requires them to think and act like you, take a similar approach to the one I took with my acquisition manager before handing over county research. Start by working together in tandem. Take managing other VAs, for example. With this

responsibility, you might start by inviting your acquisition manager to your meetings with other VAs. After each meeting, ask the acquisition manager for their reaction, feedback, or suggestions. After you're comfortable with their reaction, feedback, and suggestions, have them take over leading the meetings with you attending and observing. Give your reaction, feedback, and suggestions after the call. When you're comfortable that your acquisition manager can handle them alone, have them take over the calls without you.

Working in tandem through each task your acquisition manager will take over from you could be one of the best time investments you make in your land business. Combined with your systems and processes, which handle everything in your business that doesn't require judgment, you could be just a few short months away from freedom by working through all the judgment-heavy tasks in tandem with your acquisition manager.

Progress over Perfection

If, on the other hand, the idea of training an acquisition manager scares you, don't worry, you're not alone. A lot of people in the land business feel the same way. They're good at training virtual assistants to take over tasks that don't require much critical thinking. But the idea of training someone to take over all the judgment calls scares them. What if they make the wrong call? What if they miss something in due diligence?

The truth is one reason this process works so well is that it builds in checks, balances, and guardrails. Like we talked about in chapter 9 when we talked about outsourcing due diligence with virtually no risk, the nature of our business makes it so our downside on any one decision is very limited. Our systems and processes make it very easy for us to double-check everything our acquisition manager does. And if we train them over time and work in tandem to slowly

transition anything that requires a judgment call, our risk remains very low. We very gradually hand over the reins. Even after handing over the reins, we still meet with our acquisition manager regularly—that's how we spend the bulk of the two hours a week we continue to work in our business after hiring our acquisition manager.

But nothing will be perfect. Small things will go wrong, like they do with anything. That's the bad news. The good news is it doesn't need to be perfect to change your life. And in the next chapter, I'll help you anticipate and handle the most common problems when scaling out of your business, so you don't end up at Arkham Asylum or pulling out your hair in frustration.

Chapter 13

Handling Common Problems So You Don't End Up at Arkham Asylum

If you've never heard of Arkham Asylum before, let me preface it by saying that it's not a place you want to go. Short for "Elizabeth Arkham Asylum for the Criminally Insane," Arkham Asylum was made famous as the psychiatric hospital serving Gotham City in the DC Comics comic books.

When building a land business, you need to be ready to handle the problems that inevitably arise if you want to steer clear of ending up in your own version of Arkham Asylum. To do so, you need to first make sure you are approaching problems with the right mindset.

Adopting the Right Mindset to Keep You Sane

Keeping you out of Arkham Asylum starts with accepting four truths.

1. Even When Implementing Proven Systems Like the Land Geek Systems and Processes, You Will Experience a Learning Curve

You will make mistakes and learn from them. You will learn what systems and processes work best for you and what you might want to tweak to improve them. Over time, your systems will become

better and better, and your business will run smoother and smoother.

But in the beginning, it can be frustrating. And it can be easy to give up in frustration when you go from doing everything well—albeit doing everything *yourself*—to making mistakes as you try to implement new systems that allow others to take over.

2. Even as a CEO, You Will Have to Work with People

In the next chapter, I'll talk with you about some of the software we use to automate many of the tasks you need to perform to run a high-profit land business. Even with that software, some tasks can't be automated. You will need people to perform some tasks. And people are complicated.

For example, even the most diligent workers get sick, have complicated family lives, find new jobs, and make mistakes—especially as you work to implement and improve systems. This complicates your business. You need to be prepared to work with people.

3. You Will Never Stay Sane If You Are Always Pointing Fingers at Others

As the business owner, I know I'm always the one who's most responsible for being in the position I'm in with any team member. If they're not doing a good job in the beginning, it's on me. I've failed them in some way. Maybe I hired the wrong person. Maybe I didn't train them enough. Or maybe I wasn't clear in my instructions.

If I learn that my training wasn't clear or correct, it's on me if I don't correct it. And if they continue to perform inconsistently or poorly after all those efforts, it's on me if I don't let them go.

The sooner you recognize that you are responsible for your circumstances, the easier it will be to maintain your sanity.

4. Nobody Benefits When Someone Is Working for the Wrong Company

Keeping someone you know to be a bad fit doesn't benefit anyone. Not you. Not your other team members. Not land sellers who need you to help them get out of land they don't want. Not buyers who want to find the right piece of land to hunt, fish, hike, or build their dream home. Nobody. Not even the employee.

For example, if you have to spend too much time or attention dealing with a team member who isn't performing or has a poor attitude, that's time you can't spend on CEO tasks. Other team members will have to pick up some slack from the underperforming team member. And the team member who is a bad fit will spend all day messing up with little hope for improvement because they are clearly a bad fit. Nobody has fun in that environment.

If you accept these truths, you can avoid many of the most common frustrations land investors experience as they try to transition to a CEO role. Even worse, you might give up on becoming the CEO altogether and go back to doing all the work yourself again. But if you ever want to experience what it's like to never have to write an ad again or conduct due diligence or—even worse—*scrub lists*, you *must* push through. You *must* accept the temporary discomfort of working through people problems to achieve the euphoria of what true freedom feels like. You must adopt the freedom mindset that we're working with people and people are complicated. You must adopt the investor mindset that twelve to eighteen months of work can free you up to barely have to work again.

Remember, this is an investment. To make a good investment, you need people with certain qualities. You can find and train these people, but when you're first getting started, they *will* make

mistakes. You will too. Common problems will still arise. And when they do, you have two choices. You can push through with a freedom and investor mindset, or you can get fitted for a straitjacket. Here's how to do the former and avoid the latter.

The Five Causes of the Most Common People Problems

When it comes to managing people, the vast majority of problems can boil down to five big issues:

1. The virtual assistant wasn't properly trained.
2. The business owner assumes the virtual assistant is superhuman.
3. Communication needs to be improved.
4. The virtual assistant doesn't understand the bigger purpose of their work.
5. The business owner or manager doesn't lead by example.

You can trace almost all people problems you will encounter as you scale out of your land business. For example, if a team member performs a task wrong, one of these three reasons could be the problem:

1. They weren't trained. At best they were just handed a checklist.
2. You assumed the virtual assistant could get more work done in ten hours than most people can do in forty.
3. Your instructions were incomplete or unclear.

If a team member seems to have an attitude, it could be due to one of these reasons:

1. They are frustrated because they feel as if they don't know how to succeed.

2. Their supervisor has an attitude toward them.
3. They don't feel as if you are open to helping them achieve their goals and that you only view them as a production machine.

We could do this exercise with almost every common problem you will encounter, and the source of the problem will almost always trace back to one of those five big themes. So how do you solve these problems? Incorporate five simple principles into everything you do in your land business at every level.

1. Provide Training

Maintain a thirty-to-one ratio between training. If it takes you 5 minutes to do a task, you need to invest 150 minutes in training with this person.

2. Show Empathy

Even more important than training is how you handle your people. You need to treat each of them like a person. They're not just a cog in the wheel. Communicate with them. Understand their world. Get to know their culture.

For example, many virtual assistants will live and work in the Philippines. Make sure you know all the major holidays there. Give them that time off. They're also very family oriented. Let them know that you honor their holidays. Simply saying, "I know this is a holiday. I don't expect you to work" goes a long way toward building loyalty and having them work even harder for you.

3. Communicate Clearly

Part of what makes the Land Geek Process of Systems Building so effective is that the process itself requires you to create written and recorded instructions for team members. This cuts down many of the most common communication problems when delegating or outsourcing.

However, as business owners, we need to be aware that what comes second nature to you will not come second nature to your team members. When something comes up that doesn't fit the exact process you set up, your team members will either ask for help or make their own judgment calls.

If they ask for help, make sure you explain what you want along with why you answered that way, so they get a better understanding of your thought process. Then follow up with an email so they can have something to refer back to other than their memory. Finally, consider whether you need to update your process documents to include this scenario in case it comes up for them or someone else in the future.

If they make a judgment call, that shows initiative, which can be a positive attribute. But everyone is different. They might have done something you wouldn't have done. Ask them about their reasoning so you can understand what led to the decision before you talk with them about what to do if it comes up next. Again, follow up with an email and consider updating your process documents.

Also clearly communicate what is expected of them from a culture perspective. Let them know, "Our culture is this. This is what we believe. These are our standards. This is why we're doing this. And in order for all of us to work well together and all profit together and be successful together, these are the things I have in place. While we support each other in many ways, we do have boundaries. We're not a family. We're a team. And a good team has star players and

players who are still learning and improving their craft. Both of those types are welcome and important, but I want you to be a star. But just like a team, if someone's not performing and not improving, they get cut. And that's it. That's our expectation. This ensures everyone can be successful and work in a positive culture."

So many problems can be solved through clearly communicating expectations, especially with performance expectations and consequences so people know what they're getting into by accepting a job.

4. Provide a Sense of Purpose

When assigning tasks, don't just talk about "what" they need to do but also why it's important and how their work fits into the bigger picture of your business. This will help them understand the greater purpose behind their tasks and make their work more than transactional.

Also make sure they understand the purpose of your business as a whole—your personal why, your family why, and your community why. For example, instead of saying, "We need to increase our mailings by 20 percent," you might say, "Let's see if we can help even more landowners offload property that's holding them back by increasing our mailings by 20 percent starting next week." That small piece of context reminds your team members that your entire business is about more than just numbers.

Finally, make sure to ask your team members about their "whys," too, so you know how to better motivate and reward them over time.

5. Lead by Example

Few things destroy teams more than inauthentic leadership. If you don't want your team to gossip, don't gossip. If you want them to have a positive attitude, demonstrate a positive attitude, even when you are frustrated. If you want them to care about you and your goals, show them you care about them and their goals.

Deciding When to Fire Team Members

I find that 99 percent of people are decent, hardworking people who want to do a good job. You just need to help them be their best selves. And by communicating your business philosophy, defining their purpose, explaining why you're doing this, and having little conversations, you can avoid the big conversation. But even with all of your systems and processes in place, there will come a time when you need to let someone go.

For example, I'm very, very patient, especially at the beginning, and my team members appreciate that. That's why I am willing to invest in training at the thirty-to-one ratio level. That gives me plenty of time to assess their abilities, attitude, and work ethic. If they are still doing the tasks wrong after the thirty-to-one ratio of training to task performance has been satisfied, however, I would fire them fast. At that point, I remind myself that nobody wins if they stay longer than they should. Then I let them go.

I also fire people as soon as they break culture or integrity issues. For example, if they say that they're going to get something done by a certain date and they don't, that's a broken promise. It shows a lack of integrity. So does gossip—if an acquisition manager is talking badly of someone on the team, it's grounds for firing.

Firing is uncomfortable, but it's necessary to protect the business. It'll be much more uncomfortable to tell your star team members

that you have to let them go because you didn't fire an underperformer fast enough and don't have enough revenue to support the whole team.

Thus, set your nonnegotiables and fire fast when people break them. Failure to perform after sufficient training should be one. Breach of integrity and culture should be another.

Firing someone is not fun, but you have to get comfortable having uncomfortable conversations if you ever want to become a true CEO of your business. If not, you will never be able to rely on people to do the work, so you don't have to. You don't have to love having these conversations, but you must have them. If you're uncomfortable, you can start the conversations by saying, "I feel uncomfortable. I take no joy in this conversation, but I have to bring it up for the sake of the business because if I don't do it now, then my resentment is going to build, and the entire business could collapse. Unfortunately, we have to go our separate ways."

You can also be kind and generous on the way out. For example, I typically continue their pay for three months to help them land on their feet. But I have the conversation, let them go, and find a replacement. Having systems in place makes finding replacements much easier. That's why the Land Geek Process of Systems Building is so important.

Handling Whatever Problems Remain

Incorporating systems, training, empathy, communication, and a sense of purpose into your organization while leading by example will solve or avoid the vast majority of problems. Your team will know what to do, why it's important, and who to ask for help. If people fail to catch on after all that training, you will need to let them go. If they breach your trust, you will need to let them go.

Typically, any remaining problems will fall into one of those two categories—subpar performance or lack of trust. Someone's performance may become poor or inconsistent over time, or they may start to miss deadlines after initially performing well. When something like this happens, I will talk with them about what's going on to determine whether there's a reasonable explanation. In this context, a reasonable explanation might be that another team member isn't getting their tasks done, or done on time, or some piece of technology they used no longer works.

If there is a reasonable explanation, I will try to help them resolve it. If not, I might give them one chance to bring their performance back to where it needs to be consistently if I think our conversation might get them back on track. But if I don't gain confidence that their performance will immediately improve, I will let them go for the good of the business.

You have to protect your business from team members who can't or won't pull their weight. Give them all the tools they need to do their job well. If they still can't or won't do it, you need to let them go. Otherwise, it's only a matter of time before you're checking into Arkham Asylum.

Part 4

Automating Your Way Out of Your Business

Chapter 14

Going from Two Hours a Week to Two Hours a Month

Picture this: You're kicking back in your favorite chair—or riding your Peloton, or fly-fishing in Costa Rica—while in the background, you hear the pleasant, steady sound of a machine. At regular intervals, the machine deposits money in your bank so that every time you log in online, you see the numbers rising and rising.

The machine is there. You've built this machine: a passive income robot that will save you more time and make you more money than you've ever dreamed of.

You have the most important systems and processes in place.

You have the people in place: virtual assistants, sales assistants, and (when you're ready) acquisition managers.

In this chapter, I'll walk you through the technology you'll need to have in place. Because supporting content automation is crucial once you have your team set.

Implement those automations, and you'll go from two hours a week to two hours a month. Everyone will be on the same platforms. You're putting together your people, processes, and software to create one seamless process that doesn't need you to run. And that

means you're one step closer to becoming completely replaceable with people and automation.

The Only Two Types of Tech Tools You'll Need

We're living in the best time ever to be an entrepreneur. The tech is just getting better and cheaper.

Whenever I look online for the latest tech tools, I feel like I'm at a county fair, with bells and whistles everywhere. Snazzy financial software here; zippy communication platforms there. Pop-ups instead of people are offering me freebies—but before I know it, my pockets are empty, my head's spinning, and I'm back where I started without even a fried Oreo to show for it.

I started in Excel, switched from Slack to Smartsheet, and as I write, Airtable is the hot thing. Many of you are just like me, bouncing around from software to software, getting lost in the trends, the need to constantly update, and the pressure to keep up with changes. We're chasing helpful new features, ease of use, and shiny object features we don't really need just to save a few bucks.

And we can easily make those bucks work for us exponentially by reducing our tech needs to the only ones that will really help our business. Simple beats complex. We don't want to get lost in the technology. In fact, if you're a techie-type person, you could give yourself a headache wrapping your brain around all the possibilities. If you're *not* a techie, take a deep breath. You can use this to your advantage because you really only need two types of tech tools, and you don't even need to know how they work.

1. Management Tools

The two main components of a thriving, dirt rich business are management and acquisitions/sales. First, we have management.

Under the "management" silo fall things like business administration, inventory, task management, human resources, and accounting.

Some people can (and do) manage all these numbers in a gigantic Excel spreadsheet. Or better yet, they have their virtual assistants manage it. This is fine, but it could be worthwhile looking into the other main tools on the market. Here are the criteria to look for:

a. They Do the Job, and Nothing Else

Remember, you don't need the all-in-one Swiss Army knife. You just need a tech tool that does the job and doesn't have fancy bells and whistles on top of it. Learning how to use a complicated system, or training your virtual assistant on it, is a total waste of time. Look for something that fulfills what you lack. Again, Smartsheet and Airtable are good places to start your search.

b. They Don't Constantly Update or Upsell

I don't know about you, but I get really frustrated when my tech tools update to a new version every month with a bunch of new features I didn't ask for. Worse yet, sometimes they take away or heavily modify features I was perfectly happy with. Additionally, these are generally the same types of software that ask me for an upsell—"Add this integration with Google for only $2.99 a month!"—every time I log in. Apparently, the adage "If it ain't broken, don't fix it" isn't part of the curriculum at software development school.

This is probably why Excel has been a mainstay of so many businesses for so long. It does what it's supposed to do. It doesn't sweep the rug out from under you just when you're finding your footing.

2. Acquisition and Sales Tools

Besides managing your business, you have to acquire land, do due diligence, market that land, and sell it for a positive return. These

are the sorts of tasks that you delegate to your intake manager as soon as you can. Remember, by this point we're looking at a two-hour workweek due to our diligent delegation. Putting the right tools in your employees' hands will get you to the two-hour work month.

Gone are the days when we had to do all this through Excel and snail mail. Not that I'm particularly nostalgic about that. Today, there are digital, cloud-native tools to help with every part of the acquisition and sales process. The more automations we have, the better. Here's what to look for in an acquisition and/or sales tool:

a. The Same Two Criteria as the Management Tools

Even though these tools handle a different part of the job, they still need to do the job and nothing more. Developers run the risk of adding too many unnecessary features here too. Whether it's a marketing tool that also offers marketing services at a premium rate, or a payment management system that keeps nickel-and-diming you, it ends up wasting your time and money.

b. The More Closely Designed with Our Industry in Mind, the Better

What a time to be alive! Today, there are dozens of tech tools built specifically for land acquisition and sales, not just tech tools for other purposes that can be adapted for our business. In fact, I built a couple of them. More on that later.

Find tech tools relevant to the land business. If it says so on their sales page, or you see it recommended on these pages, then check them out. Every industry has ins and outs that can't be facilitated by every single Swiss Army knife tool, even though they try. This is why land-investment-specific tools should be prioritized . . . especially the ones I offer. But before we walk through the Land Investment Business of the Future exhibit, a quick piece of encouragement:

A Note on Automation

Whether you're a techie or rather tech-averse, these tools have the promise to get you to the two-hour work month. However, it's not just about getting the right tools in your hand. It's also about your mindset. Remember the Warren Bennis quote from earlier about the man and the dog running a factory together?

Back in ye olden days, when people dreamed about the future, they dreamed of automations making our lives easier. Smarter people than me even posited that machines would give people the two-hour workweek, thanks to their ability to save time on important tasks. What happened instead? That overbearing boss we talked about at the start of this book simply demanded more! If machines could help us make five hundred widgets a day instead of fifty, then the factory's owner could simply raise the quota and reap the profits for themselves. And that's exactly what has happened, if you take a look at the gap between a starting employee wage and a CEO's wage over the last 150 years.

However, you and I can get the dream back. We can get to a two-hour workweek, and then a two-hour work month—if we let ourselves.

Automation only works if we allow it to. It will only save us time if we deliberately choose to work less. Millions and millions of people use tools like the ones I've described every day and delegate so many tasks to their employees, and they *still* work seventy-two-hour workweeks. Yikes. It's really up to us to live the dream.

To get to the two-hour workweek, you actually have to trust other people and delegate tasks to them. It requires the difficult and sometimes awkward business of dealing with people. However, it can save you thirty-eight hours a week . . . or more.

To get to the two-hour month, you have to *trust the tools*. Furthermore, you can't get greedy. Just because you have

automations saving you time doesn't mean that you'll use that time for your personal pursuits. Most of us feel tempted to check up on other areas of the business, micromanage our employees, research breaking into a new vertical, the list goes on and on. Learn the art of silencing your phone and staying away from your email inbox, and you'll be well on your way.

Four Tools to Run Your Land Business

With all that said, I want to share the tools I currently use for each main task in our business. Note: By the time you read this, I might have changed what I use, adapting with the times. Because of this, I keep an updated list on the Resources tab of TheLandGeek.com.

Admin and Task Management

For all the administrative goodness, we use Airtable. Again, we've bounced back and forth between a few different apps, but that's where we are right now. Airtable has a collaborative calendar, task lists, spreadsheets, and a highly configurable interface for every member of your team. With this tool, you can ensure that everyone only sees what they need to see, and they know exactly what you need from them.

You can also use it to host standard operating procedures (SOPs) to continue to delegate and outsource your tasks, and make sure they're done correctly every time. Plus, these SOPs can be updated as your business grows and adapts.

Airtable also has the ability to keep track of your inventory and where each parcel is in the pipeline. We even use it to develop and launch ads. Though it pains me to say it, Airtable has the potential to usurp good old Excel for us. Funny how we get attached to computer programs! Still, unless Airtable suddenly stops fulfilling the

criteria I mentioned earlier, the team and I will use it for a while to come.

Due Diligence

We covered due diligence in greater detail during chapter 9, but I'll list some of the tools I've used in this domain for you. I personally outsource due diligence on properties under $5,000 to a virtual assistant, and I've never had a problem. This often costs $26 or less for complete done-for-me due diligence because I automated all of my processes.

To gather information about properties, I use datatree.com/thelandgeek (for a discount).

To find a good technical writer to help me write SOPs, or a good virtual assistant, I recommend starting the search on Fiverr.com, Upwork.com, Freelancer.com, and HireMyMom.com.

Lastly, if you want a done-for-you solution, begin your search at ParcelReview.com, LandMaster.us, and LandVA4U.com/thelandgeek (for a discount).

Acquisitions and Sales: LGPASS and GeekPay

I combined the last two pillars, acquisitions and sales, because there is some overlap between the two. Plus, the tools used to facilitate them were built by yours truly and my amazing team at TheLandGeek.com.

Simply put, LGPASS connects landowners to land buyers, contains automations and done-for-you paperwork, and helps people using this system scale more quickly. As I began scaling my own business, I kept track of all the automations I was using. Additionally, I wrote

down all the shortcuts, tips and tricks, and everything that made the work quicker and easier.

As the time came to turn around and teach others how to do what I do, the concept for LGPASS was born. I bundled everything together into the first version of this tool. I also added new features after a lengthy vetting process: If it was just bells and whistles, it would stay on the cutting room floor. If it helped land buyers make money and scale their business more quickly, it would stay. The litmus test for this was whether I found it helpful for my personal use.

LGPASS helps you:

- Complete and organize all the necessary paperwork for the business.
- Verify addresses.
- Communicate with landowners.
- Delegate tasks to your team members so you can focus on growing your business.

You can try it for a month without any obligations, and cancel anytime, no questions asked.

GeekPay helps with the sales piece. As you know, I don't always sell parcels for full price in cash. Sometimes there's a payment plan. In this instance, I hold on to the property until monthly installments are paid to the full value of the sale, and then turn it over.

If you're anything like me, some of the most common note servicing tools make you want to pull your hair out. Either they're missing a key feature you need, or they keep adding a bunch of extra features and upsells you're not interested in. Don't even get me started about one company I found who wanted to charge a $40,000 setup fee.

But until GeekPay, I dealt with them. After all, the alternative was to spend my weekends manually plugging values into a spreadsheet,

spending half a day reminding myself how to do a missed payment formula, and getting sidetracked whenever someone called in with a question.

Eventually, enough was enough. If I wanted software that could

- automate payments;
- calculate interest, principal, and service fees;
- automate collections messages (to circumvent paying another virtual assistant);
- give customers an easy-to-use dashboard with all the info they need;
- create downloadable monthly and annual reports for my accountant; and
- give me the support I need if there's a problem.

I soon realized I needed to build it myself. That is, work with my development team to build the perfect tool for servicing notes. I can say that with the utmost confidence because I use it for all my notes. That is, my acquisition manager uses it, and they assure me it's working like a charm. You see, I'm only trying to work two hours a month.

Ninety-five percent of the techie work is done between Airtable, LGPASS, and GeekPay. I've also set it up so that whenever I use a new tool, I quickly train someone else to use it with thorough documentation and make it part of their weekly or monthly workflow. Because of this, I spend most of my time in Airtable or on a Zoom call with my intake manager or virtual assistant, with occasional forays into the other two tools. But again, that's only for a few minutes each week.

Structure your own business in this way. Train yourself on every new tool you find and pass it off to a manager or assistant. This way, the automation increases while your workload diminishes. Then, you get

to spend all day just watching the machine work, while hanging out with a dog. At least, I think that's what Warren Bennis meant.

Take Hold of Your New Free Time

Where are you going to go first?

I highly recommend Bali, or Scottsdale, Arizona if you want to stay stateside. With delegation and automation, you'll spend more time planning the trips of a lifetime than managing your business. With a bit of work on the front end, it actually does become an automated, profit-generating machine for you. Every time you look at your bank account, you'll see a bit more money in there. As it grows and scales, you'll have the capital to invest in your passions.

If it's not traveling, what is it? Really, imagine what it would be like to work just two hours a month. You could devote time to mastering a martial art, or painting, or becoming the world's foremost authority on stamps. All you have to do? Build the machine.

Should You Switch Tools?

As I said, by the time you read this, I might be using additional tools to GeekPay and LGPASS, or even different tools. Maybe in the 2030s, I'll be having my monthly syncs in the Metaverse, or the Matrix, if the machines rise up.

How will I know when to make a switch? And how should you know whether it's time to switch? I use two simple criteria:

a. The Pain of Switching Becomes Less than the Pain of Sticking with the Current Tool

Oftentimes, switching to a slightly better tool isn't worth it. You have to update all your SOPs and train your team on it, not to mention whatever sign-up or implementation fee the toolmaker charges you.

It takes a bit of intuition to know when it's actually far less painful to switch, but honestly . . . most people need to stick with what they have longer than they do.

This is why we choose tools that do the job and nothing more, not ones that continually show off their new bells and whistles. When you get the right tool in your hands, it can serve you for your entire career, or at least until you know the wheel really has been reinvented, as in the case of Airtable. Still, if you can honestly say that it's too painful to keep a tool (and it's not just shiny object syndrome), then make a switch.

b. It Promises to Give Me More Time or Money, and the Results Are Actually There

Every techie tool under the sun promises to save you time or money, or to help you generate six figures of revenue in your first year. I think it's part of the memo they hand every software developer, along with their certificate: "Make huge promises that only help 1–2 percent of real users."

However, every once in a while, something comes along that has demonstrable benefits in this area. It's worth saying that in my entire career, I've only switched primary tools a handful of times. Almost every time it was due to seeing and hearing wonderful results from real people, often people I knew. The other times? It was because I built exactly what I needed for myself.

Yes, that's another shameless plug for LGPASS and GeekPay. Download them, get a free trial, and see how much they can change your life.

Chapter 15

Using the Third Leverage Point—Other People's Money—to Scale Big

You've implemented systems to help you leverage other people's time. You've leveraged software to simplify and automate tasks. Thanks to those two leverage points, your swim lane should look pretty empty. All that's left in your swim lane is to meet with your acquisition manager, make CEO-level decisions, engage in big-picture strategy, and decide what to do with all of the time you freed up by leveraging software and other people's time, which I'll talk about in the next chapter.

Now that you're *truly* the CEO of your land business, however, let's talk about the third leverage point that allows you to continue to scale your business without dragging you back into the business on a full-time basis: other people's money.

As you have no doubt experienced by now, once you've built a land business the Land Geek way, finding land to buy is almost never a problem. You can mail more frequently. You can conduct larger mailings. You can target more counties. The list goes on. At this point, with systems, software, and a team in place, what typically holds people back is having the cash on hand to buy additional properties. That's where other people's money comes into play. The sky's the limit for your land business when you can leverage other people's money the Land Geek way.

Why Other People's Money Is So Valuable

Imagine you're looking to invest in an apartment building in Houston, Texas. You've identified one for $20 million with a management team in place so you won't have to *directly* worry about termites, tenants, or toilets. The return on investment looks strong. How do you go about buying it? And what can you expect for a return on investment?

I could write an entire book about investing in commercial real estate—and many people have—but from a high-level perspective, you'd be lucky to generate $1.4 million in net operating income per year on a $20 million building. That means you need to come up with $20 million in cash to make $1.4 million a year. (If you financed it, you'll need a $6 million to $8 million down payment and use a big chunk of the $1.4 million to pay your mortgage.)

But most people don't have $20 million laying around. They put together a syndicate of sophisticated investors, called "accredited investors," to come up with either the full purchase price or the down payment. That syndicate then competes against other syndicates for the deal, all for the opportunity to make $1.4 million a year, collectively. To attract this level of investor, you typically need a team of lawyers and accountants to prepare detailed financial analyses and offering documents. And to increase the return, you need to raise rents, renovate real estate, and invest additional time and money to improve revenue and reduce expenses.

If your brain isn't spinning at this point, you must be superhuman. Using other people's money for most commercial real estate transactions is a big headache. To make money, you need a team of professionals, a bunch of money, and lots of time and effort. It's a full-time job.

Contrast that with scaling a land business using other people's money.

When you've built an efficient operation that leverages software and other people's time, using other people's money to scale your business is a no-brainer for many reasons.

First, you don't need to find and convince a group of "accredited investors" to give you money. You can get money from any number of sources. (And please don't harass your family and friends. You don't need to do that either. I'll share several ways to get money later in this chapter.)

Second, you don't need a team of lawyers and accountants to prepare mounds of documents about each parcel of land. As I'll explain below, you only need two simple forms to document your deals.

Third, unlike commercial real estate where the money drives the deal, the opposite is true with land investing. You don't need a syndicate or bank to analyze complicated financial projections for a deal to work. You don't need millions of dollars to do a deal. You don't need to spend months convincing people to give you money before you can make an offer. You can typically get all the money you need with a few simple phone calls or clicks of your mouse. Your land buying opportunities drive the deal. You stay in control.

Fourth, using other people's money doesn't complicate anything about your land business. Of course, as you scale, you certainly *could* decide to grow into more complex land deals, such as buying and subdividing larger parcels. But most land investors just use other people's money to send more parcels through their business.

Fifth, using other people's money doesn't require you to give up any equity or even a significant percentage of your revenue generated from using their money. You can safely borrow plenty of money to scale your business.

Finally, it almost doesn't matter what interest rates you pay when you borrow money to scale your business. When you run your

business the Land Geek way, you make a 300 to 1,000 percent return on your investment. You could pay a 10, 20, or even 30+ percent annual interest rate on your money and barely even notice a difference in your profits.

And when you start to approach having fifty or more parcels in inventory, you're likely ready to use other people's money to scale even more.

How to Get Other People's Money to Safely Scale

To safely use other people's money the Land Geek way, everyone needs to win. You need to win by making more money and putting more land through your business. Your team needs to win by being able to make more commissions for buying and selling more land. And the people whose money you're using need to win by getting significantly better returns than they could otherwise get with their money.

If everyone wins, you will almost inevitably achieve a consistent flow of money into your land business. The people whose money you use will want to give you more and more because it makes them more and more. Your team members will want to use more and more money to buy and sell more land. And you will make more and more money while helping other people make money.

So how much money should you borrow? Well, it depends on your average purchase price. For example, $50,000 buys a lot of raw land if your average purchase is $2,500. One of the simplest ways to get started is to get a line of credit in place that you can tap if you need to and then increase your mailings to increase your deal flow. As you get a sense of how much money you need to grow, then you can consider other opportunities to borrow money, such as offering friends or family the opportunity to make a higher interest rate than they would just leaving their money in the bank.

Like I mentioned above, don't harass family and friends for money if they're not interested. But I'm of the mindset that I'm doing them an incredible favor if I offer them the opportunity for a significantly higher rate of return on their money. They're making 0 percent in the bank. I am offering them 10 percent a year on their money, almost risk-free because it's backed by raw land that I've been able to sell very easily for years. On top of that, I offer them a security interest in my land portfolio in case anything goes wrong using a simple form called a UCC financing statement, or UCC-1 form. That allows them to file a lien on your portfolio if you default.

When I show my family and friends how secure their investment is and offer to execute a UCC-1 form, they happily lend me money. All I need to do from there is fill out a simple note and get the money transferred. It's really simple. In fact, the hardest part is often starting the conversation. That's why I never ask anyone for money. Instead, I say something to the effect of the following:

> *I've been buying and selling land for a while and having tremendous success. My biggest challenge is coming up with enough money to buy all the land I find to put through my system. Do you know anyone who might have some cash in the bank earning nothing?*
>
> *I can pay them an 8 percent (or 10 percent) annual interest rate on their money, make quarterly interest payments, and pay back the entire loan plus interest in three to five years. I can show you exactly how it works. It's virtually risk-free and can even be secured by my land portfolio. Do you know anyone who might be interested in that?*

When you start a conversation like this, a few things happen.

First, they will often ask you how much money you're looking for. Frankly, if you're borrowing money at 10 percent interest to earn 300 to 1,000 percent interest and have the deal flow to support it, I'd

borrow as much as possible. In this case, I'd mention both a minimum and a maximum, keeping the maximum no more than 50 percent of the value of your portfolio just to stay conservative. When you're just starting to use other people's money, I'd suggest starting smaller and growing until you hit a maximum of 50 percent of the value of your portfolio. Saying something to the effect of, "I have an opportunity to buy a lot of land and sell lots pretty quickly, so I'm pretty flexible. For now, anywhere between [low] and [high], or even higher would be fine. Why? Can you think of someone who might be interested in earning that much interest on their money?" would work. Make sure you end with asking that question again, about whether they can think of someone who wants to make a lot of money. This continues the conversation.

Next, they will often *volunteer* their own money. This is why I never ask my friends and family for money. I ask them if they know anyone who wants to make a higher return on their money. I let them make the connection to their own money.

Finally, they will sometimes offer to refer me to other people they know, sometimes in addition to volunteering their own money. If they do, ask them to make an introduction to you to keep the momentum going.

Another way to ask people for money is to *not* ask for money. Instead, reach out to people to catch up and express genuine interest in what they're doing. Email people you haven't spoken to in a while and reignite your relationship. Ask them how they're doing and what's new in their life. When they ask you what's new with you, tell them about your land business and how well you're doing. If they get excited about the land business, schedule a time to get on the phone, Zoom, or meet in person to catch up some more. If their excitement continues, tell them you are raising money from friends and family who want to earn a higher return on their money than through traditional interest rates. Walk them through the process and ask them if they know anyone who would be interested

in investing $5,000, $10,000, or even $15,000 secured by your portfolio and go from there. Many times, you'll leave those meetings with a new source of money, and they'll leave excited to earn even more interest on their money. Everyone wins.

Wherever the money comes from, execute a promissory note, set a repayment schedule, and, if necessary, execute a UCC-1 statement and you're good to go. Worst-case scenario, you can even offer to sell property to pay them back if needed and even use the Land Geek community to liquidate property if you get in a bind. Our community is full of land investors looking to buy property. Wholesaling properties you've bought using our systems to others in the Land Geek community is often very easy. You're always going to find people in the Land Geek community who have more money than time and would love to acquire some properties at a wholesale price to save some time. They understand what you're doing. They see how profitable it is. And they often have other funding sources to tap when a wholesale deal comes up.

Other Places to Find Money

Lines of credit and friends and family aren't the only places to find other people's money. You have so many worthwhile options, especially when you are making 300 to 1,000 percent returns. Of course, although even high interest rate loans barely impact your return, my order of preference is to prioritize the lowest-interest rate sources and work my way up to higher ones. Here are several additional places to find money, generally in the order of the lowest to highest interest rates. But, the truth is, when you are making 300 to 1,000 percent returns, a few percentage points here or there doesn't make much of a difference:

- Home equity lines of credit, or HELOCs
- Life insurance policies
- Loan secured by a stock portfolio

- Friends and family currently earning little or no interest
- More sophisticated friends and family
- Professionals in your community who don't know you but understand real estate and investing
- Business or personal credit lines
- Peer-to-peer lending
- Personal loans
- Credit cards

Again, while the interest rates for some of those sources could get pretty high, it really doesn't matter what interest rate you pay when you make 300 to 1,000 percent on your money.

You can also present some of these, such as HELOCs, personal credit lines, loans secured by stock portfolios, or life insurance policy borrowing, to individuals who express interest in lending you money but don't have money in the bank.

They might say they would love to but don't have money in the bank. You can help them identify places they can find money and offer to pay them a certain percentage above whatever they would have to pay to borrow the money. Sophisticated investors do this all the time. It's called interest rate arbitrage, where you borrow money at one interest rate and lend it to someone else at a higher interest rate.

It takes a mindset shift to both ask for money and get comfortable paying what seems to be high interest rates but doing so can quickly scale your income when you've already leveraged software and other people's time to build a solid land business.

Other People's Money Borrowing Terms

Here's a general deal structure when borrowing money from friends, family, and others in your community:

- Annual interest rate paid: varies
- Repayment term: three to five years
- Quarterly interest payments
- Quarterly or annual principal payments or a balloon payment at the end of the term

When borrowing from banks, peer-to-peer lending websites, or other commercial sources, your terms will often be dictated for you and require immediate monthly principal and interest payments.

My Favorite Way of Raising Capital

If you're uncomfortable asking people for money, there's a viable alternative strategy that is going to hurt emotionally but makes a ton of sense financially. That's selling notes or partial notes.

Why is this my preferred method of raising capital? As a land investor you've assembled a unique set of skills to learn how to make raw land cash flow. Once you've cracked the code for marketing you realize quickly why you should never wholesale a raw land deal again. That is, you have the skill set to constantly sell property at 800-1000% returns on investment and then within 12 months you have an exit strategy to do it all over again without having to hurt your credit, deal with potential partners or investors and take on high interest or unwanted debt.

The other reason I love the method of selling notes is that cash deals are unreliable, but everyone at some point runs out of money when selling on owner financing terms.

Here's a quick story:

A land investor coaching client found themselves in a situation where they were inundated with accepted offers, but running low on cash because they were selling all their properties on owner financed terms deals for the passive income.

The client asked if they should wholesale property or get an investor involved. After running through a pros and cons list of each option we presented the creative option of selling notes to raise the capital needed to fund the acquisition at 20 cents on the dollar quickly and without having to use any third parties.

We asked how much money they were looking to raise, and they said $25,000. We then went through the process of explaining how to raise the money quickly and easily by selling off a handful of notes with the properties attached to them.

The deal made sense for them because the passive income they were forfeiting on the short term would be doubled by the new acquisition they would be making. The velocity of money was what made this deal the smart move.

If you are interested in how the math works and are interested in going deeper into this lucrative process of capital raising to increase your passive income without debt, then go to www.thelandgeek.com/notes.

Setting Smart Limits

As enticing as it can be to use other people's money to scale your business when you can turn interest you pay on various loans into 300 to 1,000 percent gains, it's smart to avoid going too fast or too big when starting to use other people's money.

First, it can take up to ninety days for you to start generating a return on your borrowed money. Thus, if you have to start paying back a large loan before you start generating a return, you could end up in a cash crunch and have to liquidate property at a discount. This is a possibility if you start by borrowing a lot of money from a bank, peer-to-peer lending website, or other commercial source that requires immediate repayment. If you need to make immediate repayment, make sure you have the cash coming in to last you until you start generating returns on the borrowed money.

Second, even if you don't have to pay back the money right away, some things in the world are unpredictable. If deal flow slows down because something tragic happens in the world, with your team members, or in your house, you could end up having to liquidate

some properties at a discount to pay back the loan. Limit your potential downside by borrowing no more than 50 percent of your land portfolio's liquidation value. That way, if something goes wrong, you won't be left without an income by having to liquidate your entire portfolio (and your entire cash flow from the notes).

I'm a big proponent of using other people's money to scale your land business. It can unlock tremendous profits in your business. But be smart about it, especially as you are getting started. You *have* to know your cash flow before you start leveraging other people's money.

Making the Shift

As I mentioned above, it takes a mindset shift to start using other people's money to grow your land business. But it's the next logical step after you've already leveraged software and other people's time to scale your business. Your job becomes that of a CEO. And CEOs focus on high-level business activities, like further improving systems and identifying additional ways to scale. And finding safe and financially sound funding sources to scale your business using other people's money can be one of the more lucrative ways to do exactly that.

Remember, when you have built a system that regularly returns 300 to 1,000 percent and can confidently pay above-market interest rates, you aren't *asking* people for a favor when you're borrowing money, you're *doing them a favor*. Everyone wins.

There's an old adage when raising money:

- Ask people for money and they give you advice.

- Ask people for advice and they give you money.

Chapter 16

Achieving Total Freedom

When pursuing total fulfillment in life, it's not enough to just solve your money problems. Now, don't get me wrong; having money is great. I've never met anybody who complained about having too much of it. If you have, there's a good chance they're out of check with reality.

It feels fantastic to be free of stress about getting the bills paid, making ends meet, or having the items you want. Having enough money is a cause for celebration in itself. However, everyone who's gotten to the place of financial freedom will tell you this: it's never enough.

That's why freedom in my book involves both financial freedom and freedom of time. In other words, we need to have enough time and enough money, not just one or the other. Let me illustrate what I'm talking about by considering life with an abundance of one, but not the other.

Money without Time

If you have plenty of money but don't have control of your time, it'll only be a matter of time (pun intended) before you're miserable. That's why many high-powered C-Suite executives, doctors and lawyers can be miserable. They have all the money in the world, but

no time or flexibility to do what matters most to them (you know, solo-economic dependency).

The consequences of money without time can be devastating. Many of these high-powered professionals suffer from a lack of deep, meaningful relationships. Few of them have thriving marriages or solid connections with their children. Many of them struggle with physical and mental health problems as their careers progress.

Plus, the increase in pay usually comes at a cost of its own. This could be in the form of debt, or the expectations of a costlier lifestyle. Many high earners end up with "golden handcuffs," an obligation to make more money in order to pay off loans or keep up their lifestyle. This leads to more work and more burnout.

Time without Money

On the other end, if you have plenty of time but no money, you will likely struggle to find deep fulfillment in life. This is because you won't have the freedom to do what you want with that time. You'll have to go without things you want or eat into all your free time to earn enough money to pay the bills. That's why so many people are working second or third jobs or starting side hustles to catch up.

Many people discover the challenge of time without money later in life when they retire. Perhaps they didn't invest the way they should have during their career, and now they find themselves with massive amounts of time on their hands . . . but a thin budget.

This can lead to some of the most difficult years of one's life, and yes, even health problems from all the stress and anxiety. It's a pity when somebody makes it to the end of their career, but they have trouble making ends meet, much less the ability to go after their dreams.

So, what do they do? Many of them go back to work for whoever will take them.

People also have time without money during the start of their career, or during their time as students. They don't have a high-powered job quite yet, and despite the fact that many students claim to be extremely busy, they're really not.

My advice to them? Start a land business!

Time AND Money

If you can solve *both* your time and money problems, *that's* when you can live a life completely of your own forging. And that's why so many land business owners are using the Land Geek system to scale out of their business after they've built it up.

As they build up their business, they begin to solve their money problems. They're doing a lot of the work themselves, but they are learning the business and creating recurring revenue from their note portfolio.

Then, they begin to scale out of their business using the same tactics I shared with you in this book to begin to solve their time problems too. In a matter of months, they begin to shift time-consuming tasks out of their swim lane. They eliminate tasks that no longer need to be done at all. They delegate tasks to virtual assistants who can perform those tasks just as well as they can for a few dollars. And they automate repetitive tasks that can be taken over by software like GeekPay or LGPASS (seriously, go check them out!).

Once they get rid of their time and money problems, they have the opportunity to do whatever they want.

A Thought Experiment

Now, let's personalize this because it will give you the motivation to build your business . . . and then start training yourself out of it. Visualize what your life will look like when you have freedom in terms of both time and money. You need to keep this vision close to your heart, especially in the bumpy early stages of any business.

What would you do if time and money were no object?

Want to pick up and travel around the country or world? You can do that. You could make it your mission to visit as many countries as possible, or every state in the U.S. You could buy a home away from home in the tropical paradise of your choosing, or a ski lodge in the Alps or Scandinavia. You could go to every museum and see all the greatest works of art. Or you could devote yourself to learning languages and having adventures off the beaten path, away from tourist traps.

Want to volunteer to support causes that are important to you? That's possible for you too. Imagine being able to serve full-time at a charity that helped you or your family back in the day. Talk about giving back! Now, imagine being able to write a blank check to the nonprofit organization of your choice, and having the time to help them use that money well. You could leave a fulfilling and impactful legacy with your life because your time and money are taken care of.

Lastly, perhaps you want to spend more time with aging parents or your children. You have that freedom! Far too many people regret a lack of time spent with their parents before they pass on. That doesn't have to be your story. Others regret a lack of relationship with their own children, feeling like they "missed" their childhood because they were too busy. You have the chance to become a fully engaged parent and make lifelong memories with them.

Doesn't all that sound awesome? Figure out what you would do with time and money, and write it down. Put it somewhere you can see it, so you have the motivation to push past the obstacles and build a dream land business.

Also, there's a caveat. You have to understand that freedom is a double-edged sword. There's a downside to finally stepping off the hamster wheel that very few people recognize or feel adequately prepared for . . .

The Crisis Nobody Talks About

We've talked about the deep benefits of having time and money, but there's a downside that we don't always realize ahead of time: our culture doesn't set us up to move further along Maslow's hierarchy of needs very well. Let me unpack what all of that means and make it incredibly practical for us.

Abraham Maslow and His Fancy Triangle

Abraham Maslow was a psychologist who specialized in the areas of psychological health and self-actualization. His work is incredibly impactful and far-reaching, more than you might even realize. Any time you read what is known as a "self-help" book or read about human motivation, either his name will be dropped, or his presence will be felt.

Maslow, the maestro of motivation, left us with an important diagram, known as the hierarchy of needs. The sultan of self-actualization posited that humans will categorize their motivations by five primary innate needs, with each building atop one another: Physiological, Safety, Belonging, Esteem, and Self-Actualization.

- Physiological needs are your basics like food, water, and shelter. We go after these first because we won't last very

long without them.

- Safety needs include surviving not just the daily circumstances, but also special disasters and attacks. Essentially, once our belly is full, and we have a roof over our heads, we make sure we're safe from getting attacked from wild animals or displaced by a flood.
- Belonging needs sit higher up the triangle, and mostly consider the social world. Everybody needs a friend, and once we're feeling safe and warm, we have the energy to start making them.
- Next come Esteem needs. Beyond just making friends, we want to have achievements and accomplishments. Enter things like succeeding in a sport or becoming Employee of the Month.
- Finally, we have Self-Actualization. If everything else is taken care of, we feel the freedom to look deep inside ourselves and go after our potential. This is where we pursue hobbies and creative endeavors, and really stop to think about who we are and where we're going.

For the most part, each need builds upon the last. We need to fulfill one before we really feel free to pursue the next. Nobody cares about making friends when they're starving, and nobody takes up full-time painting if they're afraid their house could burn down tomorrow.

Our culture doesn't necessarily prepare us for full-time self-actualization. It prefers that we stay in our cubicle, working hard to maintain physiology and safety. Maybe we'll have time to make friends on the weekend, and if we're lucky, they'll give us a gold watch after forty years on the job to cover our esteem needs.

But nobody on their deathbed says, "I'm so glad I always had water!" or "I was so happy to be safe all the time." Perhaps some will feel glad about their friendships and deep relationships, and almost nobody will care about all the awards and achievements

gathering dust in their hallway. The question will remain, however, "Did I fulfill my true potential?" Did I leave a legacy? Am I fulfilled?

When we're running the rat race, we don't have time to consider these questions, far less the emotional energy. But when you build a successful land business and start working less and less, you feel the impending existential dread creep in.

I know, this is pretty deep for a book about business. But bear with me because it will save you loads of trouble.

When you scale your business and have all the time and money you need, what will you do? Most people hit a crisis here. All their basic needs are taken care of, and now they have self-actualization staring them in the face 24/7. And if you stare long enough into the abyss, the abyss starts to stare back!

It will feel ridiculously uncomfortable to not have any obligations. When you don't have to do anything, and you don't necessarily feel useful anymore, you'll have a ton of time to think and reflect. The urge will be to fight against this and plunge yourself back into the affairs of the business. That way, you don't have to tackle this greatest of human challenges head-on. You can also distract yourself with a million and one trivial pursuits.

Or you can venture forward into figuring out who you really are. Who are you, once you remove all the striving from the equation?

I'm excited to find out. One of the coolest parts of helping people with these businesses is watching them undertake the journey of self-discovery and self-actualization, but they have to be ready for it. I have to encourage people not to distract themselves with more work once they achieve that freedom, and to take the time to discover who they are.

Stories of Self-Actualization

We'll close out this chapter with testimonies from real people who've done the work to build and scale their land business, and then delegate away all but the most essential tasks. They believed the promise of a two-hour week, and then a two-hour month, and they did the work.

Because of this, they faced the challenge of self-actualization. Some people reported feeling guilty in the mornings because they knew everyone else was going off to work while they had a blank slate ahead of them. Others simply felt elated to get a good night's sleep and spend all of their time doing what they wanted. Regardless, they had to determine who they really were, what they really wanted, and pursue those things.

Some people took the time to develop relationships with their family, others paid the help they received forward, and others gave back to those who had helped them along the way.

Family Bonds

Roberto Chavez could hardly believe it when his business started taking off. I keep telling you people, the systems work! But that's neither here nor there. Here's what he had to say about his experience:

"The fact that I have time to wake up at whatever time I want to and do whatever I want to, go with whomever I want to: it's liberating." He continued, "You no longer have to worry. You don't feel that weight of having to go to work. It's been an amazing ride; I only wish I'd heard of this business and this community two or three years ago."

Now, he spends much more time with his family. He's working on getting back those years when he was far too busy making money

for someone else. He already feels the benefits of his new lifestyle.

Jon Burnett was a family man, or at least he wanted to be. With multiple children, he recalled feeling guilty at the end of a long workweek because he didn't get to spend the time with them that he knew they needed. While they grew up before his eyes, he wondered if he really knew them. How would they remember their childhood?

Thankfully, he found out about this business and went all in. It took a little while, but soon he found himself with dozens more hours in his week. I talked to him recently, and he worked out the math: he now spends 75 percent more time with his kids. He knows they feel like their dad is there for them, and that means absolutely everything.

Finally, I want to share the story of Tate Litchfield. One of the best ways we make family memories is through trips. If we're fortunate, we can all recall vacations we took when we were young with our family. Those memories stay with us forever. However, almost nobody gets away as much as they'd like to.

When Tate began achieving freedom through the land business, he started planning several vacations every year, and never looked back. He enjoys getting away to places without any cell service with his children. He also gets to go on long fly-fishing trips, something he enjoys.

Pay It Forward

When people achieve freedom through the land business, they have to decide what to do with their time. While I advise against people going back to work because they feel like they have to, some people go to work because they want to pay their time forward. That's the story of Scott Bossman.

Before he tried his hand at land, he was a full-time physical therapist. He really enjoyed his work, but he felt the tug from the golden handcuffs. Within three years, he replaced his physical therapy income with the near-automatic revenue from land. He still works a day or two every week in the world of physical therapy because he wants to. He doesn't have to, but he enjoys helping people rehabilitate their limbs and achieve the freedom of movement —in fact, that's why he got into it in the first place.

Mike Zaino started his land business journey with a significant amount of debt: $45,000. In the very first year of the trade, he managed to pay off all his debt and marry the love of his life while paying for his wedding in cash. Before the land business, he was a firefighter, but he still serves on a regular basis. His land business helped him get out of debt and build a more prosperous, peaceful life.

Giving Back

Lastly, having the freedom of time and money enables people to pursue charity, not just through donations but also through service. Scott Todd is an example of this. He started working in his land business about thirty hours a week, and it was making him the living he needed. However, that was only half the battle. Through training and automation, he achieved the dream of working two hours a month.

What did he do with all that free time? He learned how to fly planes! His flight instructor said he was one of the fastest students to earn their pilot's license. However, since Scott's business was so streamlined, he had the time to learn. He also had the money to purchase an airplane of his own.

What did he use it for? Scott joined an organization that performs dog rescues. Now, he regularly flies out and rescues dogs, saving their lives and getting them connected with good homes.

I love that example because it's not something you would normally think of, but it's just one of the many possibilities open to you after achieving total freedom. How will you overcome the challenge of self-actualization and fulfill your potential, once the barriers of time and money are removed?

Freedom Is Out There . . . If You Want It

"Just as ripples spread out when a single pebble is dropped into water, the actions of individuals can have far-reaching effects." — Dalai Lama

This section has mostly been about motivating you to go after total freedom. We discussed how freedom in terms of money is well and good, but the freest people are those with all the time on their hands. One without the other most often leads to misery.

We also talked about how to conquer the crisis that occurs when you really do achieve total freedom: What do you do with all that time and money? What do you do with yourself? We also suggested a few solutions from those who've succeeded in the land business. You could follow in their footsteps or forge your own path.

All it takes is saying yes to the land business. It's going to be a wild ride, but the team and I have your back. We're so grateful when new people try it out and start replacing their old income, and we're overjoyed when people start reclaiming the hours in their week and devoting them to what matters most. We hope you will too, but we can't make the decision for you. Total freedom can be achieved through this system, but only if you want it.

Will you become Dirt Rich with us?

Conclusion

Jeff Dettmer, who you met earlier, is a land investor I know. He works with aokland.com. I recently came across something he said that resonated with me, and I thought it would be the perfect way to put a bow on this book.

Remember, we've talked about the systems, processes, automations, and people necessary for the day-to-day operations of land investing. Why? So you can achieve not only financial and locational freedom but also *free up time*. This will enable you to have the freedom to pursue anything you want . . . but it takes a bit of work. However, once you extract yourself from the day-to-day operations of your business, you'll walk into the land of freedom and self-actualization. It's a nice place.

About land investing, Jeff had this encouragement for folks at all levels: "Just keep building and building and compounding, compounding. On Day One, you put your head down, and you keep it down for a few years, and right when you're ready to pull your head up, you look around and say, 'Oh my gosh, look what we've created without having to use much of our own time.'"

And honestly, that's the dream. When you put your head down and push through it, it'll feel like hard work. However, you're like an old-school miner who can't see how far they're digging until they pause and look around. Believe me, with consistency, you'll amaze even yourself.

The steps of this book are a bulletproof system for optimizing your land business. It involves hiring inexpensive virtual assistants and using high-tech automation tools to create a passive income machine. How do you know when you've done it right? When Mondays and Saturdays feel like the exact same day to you.

Like any machine, however, you have to build it. Then, you have to drive it. Thankfully, you get to teach someone else to drive it for you after that. In our time helping hundreds of people with their land business, we've seen countless examples where it snowballed quicker than expected and gave the owner total freedom in one to three years. This can be your story too.

How do you get there?

1. Start your swim lanes. We've already provided the outline for you, now you have to set them up for yourself.
2. Make deliberate action plans. We recommend setting up a plan for every ninety days, and then hauling it to get there every time.
3. Get the parts of the business you like least out of your way first. When you have the capital to bring on a virtual assistant and/or intake manager, give them those tasks first.
4. Start automating and training your team with LGPASS and GeekPay, the greatest land investing tools known to man.

If you need a little bit of rocket fuel to get started, visit https://www.thelandgeek.com/coaching/ and check out our year long coaching program. It's designed to help you scale with our team to provide you the accountability, support and focus you want to achieve freedom faster.

If you ever need help, give us a shout on TheLandGeek.com. We're building a community of savvy land investors who've ditched the rat race once and for all, and we need your help to teach all the new

people coming in. After all, if you've been in business for just a day, you already have something to teach a newbie.

The rest is up to you. I can give you all the right knowledge (and I have), and all the best encouragement (and you know I have), but only you can take steps down the path. Only you can launch the business and start buying. Only you can start selling, bring in virtual assistants, automate tasks, and train yourself out of a job. I can stand here screaming at you all day about how it's worth it, how you'll love it, and how you'll never look back, but I'd rather encourage you to simply try it for yourself.

Here's to your newfound freedom! Let freedom ring!

Get Even More Help

If you want more tools, resources, and support to implement what we talked about here, just visit TheLandGeek.com/DirtRich2.

There you'll find DIY resources and ways to get even more help from me and The Land Geek community.

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About the Author

Mark J. Podolsky (a/k/a The Land Geek) is the country's most trusted and foremost authority on buying and selling raw, undeveloped land within the United States. He has been actively investing since 2001 and has completed over 6000 unique transactions. In addition to *Dirt Rich 2*, he is the author of *Dirt Rich*, which together help investors create passive income in real estate without renters, renovations, or rehabs.

Mark is the founder of GeekPay.io, an innovative software-as-a-service company specializing in payment automation and hosts of the top-rated podcasts in Apple Podcasts' investing category (titled *The Art of Passive Income*) and *The Best Passive Income Model*. He is also the host of the *Land Geek Podcast: Work Smart. Earn More. Learn How*.

Escaping solo-economic dependency changed Mark's life in so many positive ways that he decided to teach, coach and mentor others to help them achieve their financial goals.

His website www.TheLandGeek.com is the definitive place to start your passive income journey.

Notes

[←1]

Sheena S. Iyengar and Mark R. Lepper, "When Choice Is Demotivating: Can One Desire Too Much of a Good Thing?," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 79, no. 6 (2000): 995–1006, https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.79.6.995.